

Subject focus in French and Spanish

Alessia Cassarà

 Open Romance Linguistics

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Alessia Cassarà

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1 General introduction

1.1 Why investigate subject focus?

Language variation can be defined as the availability of two or more forms for the same grammatical, morphological or phonological phenomenon within the same variety (Labov 1972). The choice of using one form or the other is, however, not a matter of pure optionality. Rather, variation is determined by specific choices, often reflecting particular communicative needs. Our utterances are indeed organized in such a way that the speaker adds or omits information, based on his/her own intention and on the (presumed) hearer's knowledge of the current state of affairs. In other words, communication is "packed" and structured according to principles that belong to the discourse domain, which are reflected by different linguistic means, and vary from language to language (Krifka 2008, Komagata 2003, Ward & Birner 2001). The term *Information Packaging* (Chafe 1976) or *Information Structure* (Halliday 1967) indicates how information conveyed by linguistic means fits into the (hearer's mental model of the) context or discourse.

Speaker and hearer share a discursive *Common Ground* (henceforth CG) (Stalnaker 1974, Karttunen 1974, Lewis 1979, Simons 2025), where information is constantly *managed* through communicative strategies, such as questions and answers. Roberts (1996) considers that CG-management is driven by hierarchies of open questions in need to be settled. Within the universe of discourse, the new, relevant piece of information that resolves an open question is generally referred to as focus. Focus is a phenomenon that originates in discourse structure, semantics, and pragmatics (Krifka 2008, Rooth 1985, 1992, Schwarzschild 1999, Von Stechow 1990).

In Alternative Semantics (Rooth 1985, 1992), focus is defined as that part of the sentence selected from a series of contextually-relevant alternatives, that fulfils the wh-variable contained in an (explicit or implicit) question. When such a new, relevant piece of information corresponds to the (grammatical or semantic) subject of the sentence, the literature generally employs the term *subject focus*. An example is provided in (1):

- (1) a. Who opened the door?

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- b. [Mary]FOC [opened it]BACKGROUND.

In (1), the subject *Mary* satisfies the *wh*-variable *who* contained in the question and is therefore analysed as the focus. The rest of the clause (‘opened it’) represents information already shared in the CG by speaker and hearer, and is generally referred to as the *background* proposition (Von Stechow 1982, Krifka 1992, 2015).

Focused subjects are by no means an understudied topic. Over the years, the phenomenon has attracted the attention of several scholars. Such interest stems most probably from the frequently-observed correlation between this information-structural function and a plethora of syntactic, prosodic and morphological phenomena.¹ This correlation has been reported for many closely-related and unrelated languages, where focus on the subject usually triggers non-canonical phenomena, while focus on a non-subject argument, by contrast, is generally said to be expressed through “unmarked”, canonical strategies.

This difference in encoding focus has been defined as the “argument asymmetry” in focus realization (Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010), and it can be summarized as follows: if, for some languages, focus on subjects obligatorily induces a non-canonical marking strategy, focus on non-subjects does so only optionally. Consequently, “if a non-canonical structure occurs with focus on non-subjects, it is expected to occur with focus on subjects too” (Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010: 170–171). Evidence for the existence of this phenomenon has been provided for Hausa (Hartmann & Zimmermann 2007), West Chadic languages (Zimmermann 2011), several Kwa and Gur languages (Fiedler & Schwarz 2005) and Northern Sotho (Zerbian et al. 2007).

Romance languages, such as French and Spanish, are no exception to this tendency. Lambrecht (1994), in his seminal work on the mapping between information-structural categories onto syntactic forms, claimed that both French and Spanish speakers make use of a combination of complex syntactic and prosodic operations to prevent the hearer from interpreting the subject of the sentence as the topic. More specifically, in French, a subject interrogative (e.g., ‘Who opened the door?’) is commonly answered using a rather heavy syntactic strategy, namely a

¹Note that some approaches consider the mapping of focus into syntax a correlation. Focus exists first as a discourse concept, and syntax/prosody reflects it. For example, the fact that focus tends to appear in certain syntactic positions (like sentence-final or cleft constructions) is treated as a statistical or functional tendency, not a strict rule. Conversely, according to other approaches, focus is not only correlated to, but rather defined by formal correlates (e.g., Chomsky 1970), i.e., it is only by having a formal marker (like stress placement, syntactic movement, clefting) that something counts as focused. I would like to thank Andreas Dufter for this suggestion.

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cleft sentence, while in Spanish, the same context would trigger a reordering of the constituents of the clause, with the subject appearing in a postverbal position:

- (2) French
 - a. *Qui a ouvert la porte?*
'Who opened the door?'
 - b. *C'est [Marie]_{FOC} qui l'a ouverte.*
'It is Marie who opened it.'
- (3) Spanish
 - a. *¿Quién abrió la puerta?*
'Who opened the door?'
 - b. *La abrió [Maria]_{FOC}.*
'Maria opened it.'

Following this tradition, a considerable number of articles investigating narrowly focused subjects in French and Spanish have been produced by both formal and functional schools (for Spanish: Zubizarreta 1998, Costa 2001, Samek-Lodovici 2001, Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006, Gabriel 2007, 2010, Heidinger 2013, Uth 2014, Cabrera 1999, Feldhausen & Vanrell 2015, etc. For French Prince 1978, Sornicola 1988, Dufter & Jacob 2009, Apothéloz 2012, Blanche-Benveniste et al. 1990, Roubaud 2000, Féry 2001, Choi-Jonin & Lagae 2005, Lahousse 2006, 2011, Lahousse & Lamiroy 2012, Destruel 2012, Karssenberg 2017, 2018c, etc.²). Many of these authors have questioned Lambrecht's one-to-one correspondence between form and function, arguing that the claim that focus on the subject is encoded in French by clefts, and in Spanish through postverbal subjects, is probably too simplistic and categorical: like French, though less freely, Spanish may also use cleft constructions (Cabrera 1999, Feldhausen & Vanrell 2015):

- (4) *Es [Juan]_{FOC} el que viene.*
'It is Juan who comes.' (Feldhausen & Vanrell 2015: 8)

Similarly, French, like Spanish, may use (a type of) subject-verb inversion for a restricted set of sentences (see Lahousse 2011 for a detailed description):

- (5) *Paieront une amende [tous les automobilistes en infraction]_{FOC}.*
'All drivers in breach of the law will pay a fine.' (Marchello-Nizia 2007: 109)

²A more comprehensive list of references can be found in Chapter 2 of this book.

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Such findings have repercussions for a typology of focus realization. Many authors tend to categorize languages according to the main strategies to mark focus. However, especially in theoretical accounts, language-internal variation is often neglected. The empirical elicitation of focus, on the other hand, has provided ground for fertile discussion. For instance, a noteworthy finding is that focus on a subject argument in both languages can also be expressed by (prosodically marked) *in situ* subjects (Gabriel 2007; Féry 2001; Destruel 2012; a.o.), as in (6) and (7):

(6) Spanish

- a. *¿Quién compró el diario?*
'Who bought the newspaper?'
- b. [María]_{FOC} *compró el diario.*
'María bought the newspaper.'

(Gabriel 2006: 2)

(7) French

- a. *Qui a escaladé la montagne?*
'Who climbed the mountain?'
- b. [Arnim]_{FOC} *a escaladé la montagne.*³
'Arnim climbed the mountain.'

(Féry 2001: 10)

The fact that subject focus in both languages can be encoded using only prosody shows that Lambrecht's (1994) categorizations are often too strict, and that a more flexible classification is desirable.

Even within the empirical framework, however, the majority of the studies so far produced do not exhaust the formal possibilities offered by the two languages mentioned. For instance, in experimental studies that elicit focused subjects, speakers are usually instructed to avoid answering with a single constituent and to reply rather with sentences containing a verb (e.g., Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010).

Yet, in spoken natural language, both French and Spanish speakers dispose of a series of competing means, whose alternation is possibly determined by several contextual and linguistic factors. This is the case of fragment answers (Merchant 2005) or the so-called "reduced" clefts (Belletti 2008a, Doetjes et al. 2004, Hedberg 2000, Buring 1998, Mikkelsen 2012), visible in (8) and (9), respectively:

(8) a. Who opened the door?

³Note that not all authors accept that preverbal subjects in French can realize subject focus (e.g., Lambrecht 1994).

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- b. [Mary]_{FOC}.
- (9) a. Who opened the door?
- b. It was [Mary]_{FOC}.

Even though they have received less attention, these strategies are nonetheless very frequent in spontaneous speech. Their configuration is somehow less complex and more economic than sentences where both the focus constituent and the background proposition are expressed. In the functionalist tradition (Givón 1985, 1995, Haiman 1985, Bates & MacWhinney 1989), language structure is an iconic reflection of external factors. This means that “length, complexity, or interrelationship of elements in a linguistic representation parallels the form, length, complexity, or interrelationship of elements in the concept, experience, or communicative strategy that representation encodes” (Newmeyer 1992: 756). Adopting this functionalist view, it is natural to wonder when speakers would choose more material and when they use less to express the same communicative function. According to Givón (1985), language economy is taken to be a major motivation for iconicity, so any iconic motivation is by definition an economic one.

This book also considers strategies such as those illustrated in (8) and (9). Building on spontaneous speech data, the book provides a more comprehensive account of how subject focus is expressed in French and Spanish declarative sentences, and investigates the appropriateness conditions for the use of alternative focus-marking devices for the same focus category. Concepts such as language economy are crucial to account for the alternation among different forms that express the same communicative function.

The main goal is, therefore, to investigate whether the occurrence of different marking strategies for focused subjects is motivated by specific linguistic and/or pragmatic factors, by adopting a quantitative variationist perspective (Labov 1972). Some of these factors have already been discussed by both formal and functional approaches in relation to focus: for instance, it has been claimed that the type of focus, and especially, the notion of *contrast*, plays a fundamental role in determining the syntactic form produced. In her seminal work on Spanish focus realization, Zubizarreta (1998) claims that subject foci must obligatorily occur in the postverbal position. However, in the presence of contrast or correction (Van Leusen 2004, Steube 2001, Repp 2010), the focused subject might also be expressed *in situ*. Similarly, different cleft formats in French have been said to correlate with different types of focus: *c’est* clefts, for instance, are generally reported as expressing exhaustive focus (see Kiss 1998 for the notion of exhaustivity), while *il y a* clefts would occur more frequently in contexts where exhaustivity is not conveyed (De Cesare & Garassino 2015, Karssenberg 2017).

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It has also been claimed that the choice among different cleft formats is linked to the givenness (Firbas 1966, Chafe 1970, Prince 1992) and the weight of the subject constituent. Lambrecht (1994) advocates a strong correlation between *il y a* clefts and newly-introduced subjects, while Roubaud (2000) has noted the frequent occurrence of heavy, clausal subjects with pseudo clefts⁴, as in (10):

- (10) *Ce qui m'énerve c'est [quand il crie]FOC.*
 'What bothers me is when he screams.' (Roubaud 2000: 178)

Additionally, focus has been said to interact with the argument structure of the verb in languages like Spanish or Italian (Burzio 1986, Rizzi 2013, Belletti 1988), and that this interaction has an impact on the position of the subject. Some authors attribute this phenomenon to the differences in the thematic properties of the arguments in the sentence (Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006), whereas others claim that the number of arguments itself would be responsible for the presence of more than one focus-marking strategy (Gabriel 2007): if transitive verbs favour *in situ* focusing of the subject, monoargumentals are said to enhance the VS order.

While systematic analyses involving focused subjects and their correlation with verb type (or argument structure) have been carried out for Spanish, the same cannot be said French. More specifically, focus on the subject in French has not yet been investigated in relation to the argument structure of the verb accompanying the subject. Building on previous studies, this project aims at filling this gap by investigating the semantic and contextual factors that lie behind speakers' choice among different strategies, showing that language-internal syntactic variation is not free and unconstrained but rather regulated by specific communicative and linguistic conditions.

A second problem with previous accounts is of a methodological nature. Many functionally-oriented authors investigating information structure have pointed out the need for highly comparable material based on spontaneous speech. Information structure, being the way in which communication is "tailored" (Prince 1981) and organized between speaker and hearer, is by definition more tangible in dialogical spontaneous situations than in written or formal texts (e.g., narratives, journalistic texts, etc.). Thus, a cross-linguistic study of different pragmatic functions would require highly comparable data.

This book addresses the issue of comparability, building on the analysis of two highly comparable sub-corpora of spontaneous dialogues (sgscorpus), collected by Adli (2011) in 2005. Both the French and the Spanish sub-corpora have been elicited using the same game task, and exhibit, as a consequence, many

⁴The term can be attributed originally to Bach & Peters (1968).

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similarities in the setting or the content of the dialogues. The investigation of information structure has always presented a methodological challenge. At present, scholars working empirically on this branch agree that the method of the question-answer pair is the most reliable way to retrieve the correct information-structural partition of the sentence (e.g., Question Under Discussion approach to focus, Roberts 1996, Riester et al. 2018, Riester 2019). The sgscorpus, being mostly dialogical, presents a methodological advantage in this respect.

Finally, for both French and Spanish focus subjects, many authors to date have generalized their claims to the language in its entirety, not taking into account the presence of diatopic variation among regions. In the case of Spanish, at least, information-structural phenomena are particularly sensitive to such variation.⁵ One example is the case of Southern Peninsular Spanish (SPS, Andalusian or Extremaduran), where non-contrastive focus on the subject is said to be expressed more often in a preverbal, canonical position rather than postverbally (Jiménez-Fernández 2015).

- (11) a. *El chocolate que tenía escondido ya no está. ¿Quién lo ha encontrado?*
 ‘The chocolate I had hidden is not there anymore. Who has found it?’
 b. *[Jimena]FOC lo encontró. Y se lo ha comido entero.*
 ‘Jimena found it. And she has eaten it all.’ (Jiménez-Fernández 2015: 6)

Considering this, the results for the corpus studies presented in this book are delimited to a very specific variety of both French (Parisian French) and Spanish (Barcelona Spanish), and the claims are restricted to those specific varieties exclusively. Consequently, they may not fully apply in a different geographical area.

Overall, this book is meant to make a further contribution to the intricate question of focused subjects and their realization in French and Spanish. It does so by adopting a variationist comparative approach building on spontaneous speech data, considering every conversational strategy through which this function is expressed, and providing an account for the pragmatic and linguistic motivations behind speakers’ choices to opt for one strategy rather than the other.

⁵In this respect, the two languages differ considerably: while for Spanish, diatopic variation has been claimed to affect the way in which focus is realized, in French, the phenomenon seems to be rather homogenous, and no noticeable regional differences have been reported. I thank Andreas Dufter for this suggestion.

1 General introduction

1.2 Goals and structure of the book

This book is subdivided into three major parts: Part I contains the **Theoretical Background**, where I summarize previous accounts of focused subjects. I start by delimiting the notion of focus and its expression, reviewing at first existing literature on focus as a universal information-structural category (Zimmermann & Onea 2011), then narrowing down on subject focus expression. I concentrate particularly on the case of constituent focus realization and on the different focus types that have been identified in the literature (information, contrastive, etc.) (CHAPTER 2).

I then present both formal and functional approaches to focused subjects in Spanish and French, first summarizing the studies that have been conducted first individually on the two languages, and then comparatively (CHAPTER 3).

Part II includes three **comparative corpus studies** carried out using the same corpus (sgscorpus, Adli 2011), but tackling different aspects of subject focus realization. As it has been often said, both clefting in French and constituent re-ordering in Spanish are but two of several means to focus subject constituents and compete constantly with a series of alternative focus-marking devices. Sentence accent and phrasing, for instance, where prosody functions as the only means for constituent focus *in situ*, has been claimed to be a valid alternative to word order (Dufter & Jacob 2009). The range of possibilities, however, is not limited to these categories. As illustrated above, more economic strategies, such as fragment answers (8) or reduced clefts (9), can also be used to encode the same pragmatic function. The first research goal of the book is thus to clearly identify the *envelope of variation* (Labov 1972), i.e., the strategies that speakers produce to mark focused subjects in both languages, and discuss them from both a language-internal and a comparative perspective.

In CHAPTER 4, I report the results of the extraction of all subject focusing strategies from both the Spanish and the French sub-corpus. This part has an exploratory purpose, and is mostly descriptive. As will be shown, focus-marking strategies for subjects are relatively infrequent (as already argued by other authors, see for instance Brunetti 2009, for Spanish and Italian), and some structures show very few occurrences. Given that a subject in focus is, by definition, a marked information-structural configuration, the scarcity of such data points is not surprising. Yet, the corpus exhibits variation at the level of the realization of narrowly focused subjects, displaying a gamut of competing means for both Spanish (e.g., postverbal subjects, *in situ* focus, clefting, fragments, reduced clefts) and French (e.g., clefting, *in situ* focusing, reduced clefts, fragments, dislocations). Interestingly, some structures appear in both languages (e.g., clefts, fragments,

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in situ, etc.). However, their frequency varies considerably from one language to the other.

CHAPTER 5 investigates the alternation between “full” (e.g., clefts) and “elliptical” (e.g., fragments) answers⁶ in both languages. The corpus query has revealed that speakers dispose of more or less economic means to express a focused subject. Some of these structures, such as postverbal subjects, clefts or *in situ* focusing, etc., exhibit a clear focus-background partition, where the subject is the focused element of the sentence and the rest of the clause⁷ is the background, i.e., information already shared and known by speaker and hearer. Other strategies, on the other hand, only display the focused part (the subject), while the background proposition has been elided. This is the case of fragment answers (8) or reduced clefts (9).

The systematic study of competing variants requires not only the identification of these forms, but also of the individual contexts in which differences between them may arise. To tackle this question, each strategy is investigated in its context, i.e., in relation with the preceding (explicit or implicit) question it constitutes an answer to. The main intuition is that, in a dialogical context, the activation of the background proposition plays an important role when speakers choose between “full forms”, such as clefts or postverbal subjects, and “elliptical forms”, such as fragments or reduced clefts. In other words, when the background material is highly activated because the question immediately precedes the answer, speakers opt for a more economic form, e.g., a fragment answer. Conversely, when the background material is not fully activated because of intervening utterances or when the question is implicit, a cooperative speaker will use a more explicit form (e.g., a cleft) to facilitate comprehension. The idea that shorter forms, such as reduced clefts, are felicitous with immediately-preceding questions has already been postulated in the literature (Belletti 2008a, Katz 2000). However, it has never been empirically investigated, nor operationalized.

In this chapter, I propose an operationalization of the distance between question and answer, adopting the Question Under Discussion (QUD) approach to focus (Roberts 1996, Büring 2003, Beaver & Clark 2009, Riester et al. 2018), and distinguishing among three degrees of immediacy of the QUD (immediate, not-immediate, implicit). The results show that highly activated QUDs favour the presence of elliptical answers, while not-immediate or implicit QUDs are more

⁶The terms *full* and *elliptical* refer here to answers where the background proposition is either uttered (e.g., a cleft) or omitted (e.g., a fragment), respectively.

⁷Note that cleft sentences are bi-clausal structures. The background proposition, in this case, is generally contained in the relative clause.

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frequently answered with full forms. Although there is no one-to-one correspondence between level of activation of the backgrounded proposition and strategy used, the results reported in Chapter 4 provide evidence of the fact that the choice of the sentential form is, to some extent, influenced by principles such as language economy, or the “Principle of Communicative Efficiency” (Levshina 2022: 30).

CHAPTER 6 narrows down the investigation on the syntactic phenomena that have been mostly discussed in the literature: Spanish subject position (SV/VS) and different cleft formats. The analysis reported in this chapter investigates the interacting semantic and discourse factors that have been claimed to influence the occurrence of these phenomena. As mentioned in the previous section, it has already been assessed that the way in which focus is realized is dependent on other factors, such as the length of the constituent, type of focus conveyed or verb type (Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006; Gabriel 2007, a.o.). If a considerable number of publications has found an effect of argument structure in focus expression, the same reasoning has never been systematically applied to French, and the role of argument structure in interaction with focus remains unclear for this language. Given that French clefts have been considered a discourse-pragmatic equivalent of Spanish postverbal subjects (Lambrecht 1994, 2010, Belletti 2008a, Lahousse & Lamiroy 2012), the lack of literature investigating this correlation is somewhat surprising.

In this chapter, I show how different factors influence the syntactic structure that speakers prefer, albeit to different degrees. Because of typological differences between the two languages, these factors affect subject focus realization at different levels: if, in Spanish, verb type and givenness of the subject results in word-order alternations (SV, VS), in French, a language with a relatively rigid order of the constituents, the same combination of factors results in different cleft formats.

Finally, Part III presents a comparative analysis of the results for the two languages (Chapter 6). The findings are interpreted from a variationist perspective (Labov 1972, 1994, 2006). Within this framework, a variable is understood as a general or abstract feature that is subject to variation, whereas the specific realizations of the variable in speech are referred to as variants (Meyerhoff 2018). The results of this study show that different focus-marking strategies within the same language can be regarded as optional variants of a single variable, and that their distribution in natural speech can be explained by specific conditioning factors.

The main goal of the present study is thus to investigate whether there are differences and similarities in the way two closely-related languages encode subject

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focus, and to motivate speakers' communicative choices. The research questions of the book can be summarised as follows:

- **Research question n.1:** What answering strategies are used to mark subject focus in French and Spanish? How do the two languages differ in this respect?
- **Research question n.2:** What determines speaker choice between full and elliptical forms when expressing focused subjects in the two languages?
- **Research question n.3:** How do factors such as focus type, givenness and argument structure contribute to syntactic variation in the expression of subject focus in the two languages?

The outcome of this study contributes to several innovative aspects: i) it offers an empirical contribution to the investigation of subject focus realization from both a language-internal and a comparative perspective, ii) it provides an account for the alternation between full and elliptical focus-marking strategies in terms of distance between question and answer iii) and it investigates factors that influence the syntactic realization of focus, both individually and in interaction.

It is important to keep in mind that the findings of this book are highly register-dependent. Being based on dialogical data, the same results may not be obtained if applied to, say, written and/or formal texts (e.g., narratives, journalistic texts, etc.). This is not surprising if we consider that the pragmatic function of some constructions, such as cleft sentences, varies considerably across different text types. Therefore, the claims issued from the results of the present analysis are not intended as a general theory on cleft- or postverbal subject- usage in any possible contexts. Rather, the investigation is limited to the usage of these constructions in spontaneous dialogues, which, however, are one of the most frequent registers experienced by humans (Du Bois 1987: 836).⁸

⁸I would like to thank Aria Adli for this suggestion.

Part I

Theoretical background

2 Focus and focus realization

Following Zimmermann & Onea (2011), I consider focus a universal category within the framework of Information Structure (hereafter IS). I also distinguish between the semantico-pragmatic category of focus and its grammatical manifestation in a given language. In other words, I argue that the notion of focus should be separated from its formal grammatical realization in a sentence, i.e., the syntactic domain where it is expressed and the prosodic or morphological means by which it is marked. Accordingly, I disagree with theories that define focus through specific accents or dedicated syntactic positions (e.g., Chomsky 1970, Rizzi 1997, Brody 1990). Instead, I assume that even in the absence of special marking, the informative value of an utterance is still conveyed.

In the first part of Chapter 1, the concept of focus is discussed independently of how it is marked, with an emphasis on its cross-linguistic function and its contribution to the universe of discourse. In line with Roberts (1996) and others, I view focus as a discourse-structuring device. Specifically, the central function of focus in declarative utterances is to identify the questions these utterances can answer (Roberts 1996, Büring 2003, Beaver & Clark 2009). The realization of focus, addressed in the second part of the chapter, refers to its linguistic expression through special grammatical means, such as prosodic prominence, syntactic re-ordering, and morphological markers. These devices help the hearer identify the focus (and, if possible, the background) structure of an utterance. This chapter is organized as follows: In Section 1.1, I provide a non-exhaustive synthesis of various contributions to the notion of focus as an information-structural category. I then clarify the distinction between focus structure and different focus types (Sections 1.1.1 and 1.1.2). Section 1.2 presents the different ways languages mark focus. Finally, Section 1.3 concentrates on subject focus, offering a brief overview of its syntactic manifestations across languages.

2.1 The notion of Focus

The notion of focus has its origins in discourse structure, semantics, and pragmatics (Krifka 2008, Rooth 1985, 1992, Schwarzschild 1999, Von Stechow 1990,

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inter alia). Given the complexity of the phenomenon, it is not surprising that the concept has been subject to a long and intricate debate over the years. It is thus difficult to trace back the history of focus as a linguistic notion, because the concept was expressed in different terms, and often the same term was used to express different notions. The Prague school (e.g., Mathesius 1983, Daneš 1964, Firbas 1992), for instance, made a distinction between *theme*, that part that refers to what is already known or given in the context (also known by other scholars as *the topic*, see Reinhart 1981, Jacobs 2001, among others) and *rheme*, the part that conveys new information (which corresponds to the focus of the sentence). In the sentence *John bought a new car*, for instance, *John*, the referent already known or given in discourse, was considered the *theme*, while the sentence *bought a new car*, which predicates something new about John, was called *rheme*.

In generative grammar, the term focus was used by Chomsky (1970), Jackendoff (1972), Brody (1990), Rizzi (1997), who consider focus to be the information that the speaker assumes is not shared by the hearer, while non-focused material conveys the “presuppositional skeleton”, a piece of information already shared by both speaker and hearer (Frascarelli 2010: 2122). Jackendoff (1972) introduced a syntactic feature named F. The F feature marks the focused phrase, while a phrase which is not marked with F is unfocused. F would correspond to stress prominence in a certain domain.

In a similar vein, the Cartographic approach (Rizzi 1997), building on the observation that focus is marked in several languages by various grammatical means, assumes focus to be a part of the syntactic structure, at least in the form of an abstract feature, located in a dedicated position in the C-domain (the left periphery of the sentence or LP). This is known as the Focus Phrase or FocP:

- (1) [ForceP [TopP* [FocP XP[+foc] [TopP* [FinP [IP ...tXP]]]]]]

Thus, scholars from the generative tradition claim that IS-notions like topic and focus represent distinct structural positions in the left periphery of the sentence above TP, and that such notions are defined in terms of abstract features, which trigger specific marking-strategies.

Unlike the Cartographic approach, Matić & Wedgwood (2013) argue that focus is not a core grammatical category, but rather a by-product of other linguistic systems such as aspect and modality. Indeed, even though focus-marking strategies are widely found cross-linguistically, there exist languages that do not mark focus at all.

Büring (2009), in his typology of focus realization, also discuss a series of languages that do not show any particular focus-marking strategy (e.g Hausa, see Green & Jaggar 2003, Hartmann et al. 2008).

2.1 The notion of Focus

The lack of focus realization does not imply, however, that the concept is not present in the language. According to Zimmermann & Onea (2011), formal marking of focus is not expected to be mandatory in each and every language. Languages do not necessarily make use of focus-marking devices that would yield a strict one-to-one mapping between focus and its grammatical realization. In their words, “focus is expected to be formally underspecified, and thus in need of contextual resolution, in many, if not all languages. In fact, since the utterance context heavily reduces the number of worlds relative to which an utterance is evaluated [...], the explicit realization of focus might even seem superfluous at times” (Zimmermann & Onea 2011: 1658).

Adopting this view, I consider that defining focus only by its grammatical, prosodic or morphologic realization is misleading, and I assume that focus is better identified via pragmatics. Concretely, I consider that certain (semantic or pragmatic properties of certain) contexts systematically trigger focus.

In a dialogical context, the classical pragmatic use of focus is to highlight the part of an answer that corresponds to the *wh*-part of a constituent question (Paul 1880). Drubig (2003) claims that a *wh*-question always requires a focused answer. Consequently, answers to *wh*-questions are commonly used as diagnostics for focus and its grammatical realization. Consider the example in (2):

- (2) a. Who ate the cake?
- b. [Mary]_{FOC} ate it.

In earlier investigations, focus has often been associated with concepts such as “information point” of the sentence (Bolinger 1985), “emphasis”, “importance”, “highlighting”, and “newness” (Halliday 1967). However, these concepts have been considered unsatisfactory and have failed to capture the complexity of the phenomenon in its entirety. The notion of newness, for instance, clearly gives wrong predictions. Consider the case in which a constituent that refers to something previously mentioned is in focus, such as in the case of focused subjects. Subjects are usually entities that have already been previously introduced and, as such, are discourse-given. However, a subject can at the same time represent the focus of the sentence.

An important clarification in this respect is provided by Lambrecht (1994), who considers focus (like topic) as a relational pragmatic category, that has to be distinguished from a referential category. While a relational category expresses a relation between the referent and the corresponding proposition, a referential category reflects the identifiability and activation states of discourse referents.

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Pronouns, for instance, which are the most activated referents, can also represent new information to the hearer, because they are in a relation of newness with respect to the proposition they refer to. Thus, in example (2), Mary, being a proper name, has a uniqueness reference, and is already known by both speaker and hearer. Yet, the information that it was her who ate the cake is new to the hearer.

It has been customary to draw a sharp division between semantic and pragmatic uses of focus. The classic example of semantic uses of focus is its association with exclusive particles like ‘only’. In general, ‘A only B’ means that, out of some range of properties A could have, the single property A actually has is B. Other alternatives are thus excluded (hence the term ‘exclusive’) (Velleman & Beaver 2016). For instance, a sentence like ‘Peter only dances’ indicates that the only property that Peter has is to dance (and not, say, to sing). The semantic use of focus affects the truth-conditional content of the CG. In this case, failing to set the focus right will result in the transmission of unintended factual information. Thus, the variation in truth conditions between these sentences shows that focus helps determine which alternatives are excluded.

Rooth (1985), in his Alternative Semantic Framework (Rooth 1985, 1992), describes focus as indicating alternatives, and a focus sensitive particle is one whose meaning depends on those focal alternatives. Such truth-conditional effects of focus can be distinguished from the ‘pragmatic’ uses of focus. These uses are connected to the public communicative goals of the speakers, and do not have an immediate influence on truth conditions. Rather, they contribute to guide the direction in which communication should develop. This implies that failing to select the right focus typically results in incoherent communication.

In subsequent research, it was shown that this unconstrained system of Alternative Semantics makes available too many alternatives, and allows for a number of incorrect predictions. To solve this issue, Rooth (1992) proposes a more restrained version of Alternative Semantics, by adding a context variable *C*, which refers to a contextually-given set of alternatives, and a focus operator, which introduces a presupposition requiring the value of *C* to be a subset of the (unconstrained) set of focus alternatives.

While in Alternative Semantics focus only helps to identify the relevant alternatives, which are registered at an independent level of meaning, the Structured Meaning approach (Von Stechow 1982, 1990, Jacobs 2012, Krifka 1992, 2008) assumes that focus leads to a partition of the sentence meaning into two parts: focus and background. In the Structured Meaning approach, focus has the effect of structuring the propositions denoted by sentences: the focus-influenced semantic value of a clause with a single focus is a pair consisting of (i) a property,

2.1 *The notion of Focus*

obtained by lambda-abstracting on the focused position, and (ii) the semantics of the focused phrase. In this respect, [Von Stechow \(1991: 38\)](#) states that the semantics of questions is fundamental for a focus theory: a *wh*-question sets the background for an answer, which, in turn, determines the focus of the answer.

A theory that takes questions as the “touchstone” for focus is the Questions Under Discussion (QUDs) approach (see, for instance, [Roberts 1996](#), [Büring 2003](#), [Beaver & Clark 2009](#)). Within this theory, questions, explicit or implicit, are seen as structuring discourse, and information-structural marking is seen as reflecting that underlying discourse structure. Moreover, this account collapses the distinction between semantic and pragmatic uses of focus, and analyses all effects of focus (including semantic ones) as arising from a single essentially pragmatic function: focus helps to indicate which QUD is the current question, the question the current discourse move is intended to address.

QUDs are taken to represent discourse goals, and focus-marking in an assertion indicates which QUD it answers (which question is the current question with respect to the assertion), thereby indicating the discourse goal that needs to be fulfilled.

QUDs are often considered as sets of alternative propositions and are therefore related to [Rooth \(1985, 1992\)](#)’s Alternative Semantics. Indeed, according to [Velleman & Beaver \(2016\)](#), the question-based approach to focus can be treated as an add-on to Alternative Semantics rather than a replacement. However, while Alternative Semantics says little about how listeners choose the right logical form, except in cases where the discourse makes an antecedent set of alternatives explicit, the QUD approach sets up a series of constraints which are claimed to enable speakers to arrive at the right focal alternatives. In other words, when speakers hear a sentence whose information structure is ambiguous, they would choose the structure that leads to the fewest constraint violations and the least need for accommodation or repair. Thus, this approach is not incompatible with the Alternative Semantic Framework and Structured Meaning, but rather builds on previous claims about the theory of focus. Like the other two approaches, within the QUD framework, focus is defined as the element in the answer which instantiates the open variable in the QUD.

The idea that the focus constituent is the part of the sentence that corresponds to the answer to a question ([Bresnan & Kanerva 1989](#)) is not new. Within this framework, however, an answer to a question is appropriate only if its focused constituent corresponds to the *wh*-phrase of the question. Importantly, the QUD approach posits a similar hierarchical structure even for discourses which do not involve any explicitly asked questions, such as in corrections (contrastive or corrective focus) or in out-of-the-blue utterances, in which case they can only

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be identified with recourse to the focus alternatives. In these cases, the QUD has to be reconstructed starting from the answer itself and looking at the preceding discourse context. To reconstruct an implicit QUD, [Riester et al. \(2018\)](#), [Riester \(2019\)](#) propose annotation guidelines for QUD, which will be discussed in detail in the methodology section in Chapter 4.

The QUD approach to focus presents several methodological advantages. First of all, as mentioned above, it is compatible with both the Alternative Semantics and the Structured Meaning approach. Secondly, it provides specific indications and constraints on how to retrieve the correct information-structural partition of the sentence and the consequent identification of focus. Third, it clearly indicates how to reconstruct the QUD when this is implicit, thus avoiding exclusive reliance on the syntactic form of the answer, which, as will be shown, is often underspecified and can be compatible with more than one sentence partition. Given the empirical nature of the book, in that it builds on dialogical data, implicit questions are not uncommon, and the QUD method proves particularly useful in this regard.

Finally, the correct retrieval of the QUD allows one to distinguish between focus types with a contrastive and non-contrastive interpretation. In the following sections, I will discuss the contributions to different focus structures and different focus types, and provide some examples of how the QUD method can help to differentiate efficiently among different sub-categories.

2.1.1 Focus structure

As is generally acknowledged, constituents of different “sizes” can be focused within the sentence. One of the major contributions to the focus structure of the sentence is provided by [Lambrecht \(1994\)](#), who defines focus structure as the conventional association of a focus meaning (distribution of information) with a sentence form.

A fundamental contrast is observed between broad and narrow focus ([Selkirk 1986](#), [Lambrecht 1994](#)). Such a distinction is not categorical but gradual in nature, with narrow focus referring to focus on single words or constituents and broad focus referring to complex constituents (VP) or to the case in which all parts are newly introduced into the discourse at the moment of utterance ([Féry 2008](#)). [Lambrecht \(2000: 611\)](#) distinguishes among Argument Focus (AF), Predicate Focus (PF) and Sentence Focus (SF), which are described as follows:

Sentence focus structure (SF), or all-focus sentence, expresses a pragmatically structured proposition in which both the subject and the predicate are in

2.1 *The notion of Focus*

focus. The focus domain is thus the whole sentence. This sentence type differs from predicate focus constructions, in that it exhibits no topical element, and is felicitous as an answer to questions like ‘What happened?’. Consider the example in (3):

- (3) a. What happened?
 b. [My car broke down]_{FOC}. (Lambrecht 1994: 223)

Predicate focus structure (PF), also called VP focus, is considered universally the unmarked type by Lambrecht (2000: 622), and coincides with the traditionally recognized topic-comment organization of information in a sentence. The Predicate focus structure is a sentence construction expressing a pragmatically-structured proposition in which usually the subject (although it can also be another constituent) is the topic (hence within the presupposition) and in which the predicate expresses new information about this topic. The focus domain is, thus, the predicate phrase (or part of it). An example is provided in (4):

- (4) a. What did Laura do yesterday?
 b. She [went to the park]_{FOC}.

Argument Focus structure (AF) refers to the situation in which the focus domain is represented by a single constituent that has an argumental status (5):

- (5) a. Who stole the book?
 b. [Marc]_{FOC} stole it.

The three focus structures are used in different communicative situations, and are felicitous as answers to different QUDs. As mentioned above, Lambrecht (2010) considers the Predicate focus (PF) to be the “unmarked” structure and the one most frequently found across languages. Conversely, the Argument focus (AF) category, where the focused constituent is the subject (“identificational” sentence in Lambrecht’s terms), is described as the most “marked”, infrequent case. In this book, I will concentrate mainly on the Argument Focus structure, this being the category to which narrowly-focused subjects belong. The other two categories and their mapping onto grammar are beyond the scope of the present work. In the Argument focus condition, the focused constituent can trigger different pragmatic inferences. These interpretations correspond to different sub-types of focus, and are discussed in the next section.

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2.1.2 Focus types

A considerable amount of work, from both a generative and functional perspective, has been dedicated to distinguishing different types of foci, relying mainly on semantic and pragmatic differences. Due to the complexity of the phenomenon, the terminology used by different linguists has often been inconsistent, which has prevented, at times, a reliable comparison of the interpretation of certain kinds of focus across languages. There is a general tendency, advocated mainly by Bolinger (1972) and Schmerling (1973), to distinguish between “neutral” focus, whose main function is to express the most important part of the utterance (see, for instance (5)), or what is new in the utterance, and other pragmatic uses of focus that aim to correct information (also called ‘contrastive’, ‘corrective’ or non-neutral).

According to Krifka (2008), in the case of “contrastive/corrective” focus, the focus alternatives must include a proposition that has been proposed in the immediately-preceding CG. This leads to a corrective interpretation in case the context proposition was different (see also Truckenbrodt 1995, Rooth 1996, Steube 2001, Van Leusen 2004, Repp 2010 for an exhaustive analysis of this focus type).

Kiss (1998) advocates a further distinction between identificational focus and information focus (see also Rochemont 1986; Campos & Zampini 1990). The two sub-types are differentiated for semantic reasons: identificational focus performs exhaustive identification of a set of entities given in the context (discourse-given) or in the situation (situationally-given), while information focus simply marks the non-presupposed nature of the information it carries (Riester & Baumann 2013). Consider the following example:

(6) Identificational focus

[PÉTER]_{FOC} *aludt a padlón.*

‘It was Peter who slept on the floor.’

(Kiss 2008: 75)

Szabolcsi (1981) describes the exhaustive interpretation of the focus in (6) with the following formula “For every x, x slept on the floor if x = Péter”. Thus, identificational focus excludes, by definition, all the other possible alternatives of the set. In the case of information focus, on the other hand, such interpretation is not conveyed:

(7) Information Focus

a. What did you bring Mary?

b. I brought her [flowers]_{FOC}.

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While in (6) the only possible referent for which the proposition holds is Peter, such an implication is not conveyed in (7). In other words, adding ‘and John too’ to (6) would be pragmatically infelicitous, while adding ‘and chocolates too’ to the (7) would be quite acceptable in context. As mentioned above, this would be attributable to the fact that identificational focus always carries an exhaustive interpretation, while information focus simply communicates the non-presupposed part of the information.

Kiss (1998) provides arguments in favour of such differentiation based on examples from Hungarian, where this distinction is said to be reflected in the grammar of the language. According to the author, identificational focus, being the most marked type, always triggers reordering of the constituents in the sentence (e.g., the use of a cleft sentence), while for information focus, which acts as a default type, such an operation is not required.

While Kiss gives a fundamental semantic distinction between focus types, the concept of exhaustivity is still a matter of debate. In particular, for some authors (see for instance Horn 1981, Destruel & DeVeugh-Geiss 2018), reordering of the constituents is not a reliable criterion to detect the exhaustive interpretation of the focus constituent. In some cases, an exhaustive focus can also be expressed by *in situ* strategies (Gabriel 2010, Féry 2001, Uth 2014), and non-exhaustive focus can also involve reordering of the constituents. Rather, the context of the sentence, when possible, should be the only reliable way to determine exhaustiveness.

Destruel (2012), for instance, showed that associating additive particles such as ‘too’ with *it*-cleft sentences in French does not lead to ungrammaticality nor to pragmatic infelicity. These authors suggest that exhaustiveness is a pragmatic implicature (hence cancellable) rather than a semantic implication. The notion of exhaustivity associated with French clefts will be further discussed in Chapter 2 and Chapter 5 of this book.

Moreover, Kiss (1998) considers contrastive/corrective focus to be a sub-type of the identificational one. Also according to Tomioka (2008), the notion of contrastivity is connected to diverse linguistic phenomena, such as, e.g., exhaustive answers in question-answer pairs, contrastive statements, or instances of corrective focus.

Thus, the term ‘contrastive’ has also been commonly used to refer to cases where the choice of an element among a set of explicitly mentioned alternatives automatically excludes the other possibilities. Such exclusion can be carried out via two processes: either selecting one alternative among a set of explicit possibilities (Dik & Van der Hulst 1981), or correcting a previously mentioned value. This is the position taken by Chafe (1976), where contrast is thought to be any

2 Focus and focus realization

instance of focus where one or more alternatives to the focused expression have been explicitly mentioned in the preceding discourse. Moreover, it always carries an exhaustive interpretation.

In some theories, the notion of contrast and correction are collapsed and reduced to cases where focus implies removal of information and insertion of new information. The two examples below exemplify the two semantic processes:

- (8) Contrastive Focus
 - a. Who stole the book, Marc or John?
 - b. [Marc]_{FOC} stole it.
- (9) Corrective focus
 - a. John stole the book
 - b. [Marc]_{FOC} stole it (and not John).

While some scholars advocate a further distinction between contrastive and corrective, Krifka (2008) states that the distinction between identificational and information focus is unmotivated, and that the two categories should simply be combined under the definition of information focus (see, for instance, Vallduví 1992). Krifka (2008) claims that all focus types (contrastive or identificational or information focus) are in some sense tied to the notion of alternatives, and that the differences between the various interpretations can be captured in terms of the ways in which the ordinary meaning of the focused constituent interacts with the set of alternatives. Therefore, in his theory, he aims to simplify the differentiation among sub-types into two major categories, namely “open” focus (open set of alternatives) vs. “closed” focus (restricted set of alternatives), and to restrict the term “contrastive” only to cases which truly involve correction or additive particles (e.g., too).

Conversely, Torregrossa (2012), Cruschina (2012, 2021), Cruschina & Mayol (2024, 2025) are increasingly calling into question the usefulness of the “traditional” dualistic distinction between *neutral* (information/identificational) focus and *non-neutral* (contrastive, corrective, etc.) focus by providing evidence in favor of more fine-grained and gradual pragmatic distinctions.

Nevertheless, the distinction between *neutral* and *non-neutral* focus type continues to be particularly advocated due to its presence in the syntax of certain languages. For instance, it is commonly assumed that contrastive (hence non-neutral) foci licence certain word orders that would be judged infelicitous if they were to simply express information focus. A classic example is fronted foci in Spanish or Italian, where the common locus for focus is the postverbal slot of

2.2 Focus realization

the sentence. Indeed, it is claimed that, if a focused constituent appears preverbally, it almost always has to bear a contrastive (or corrective) interpretation and a specific prosodic contour (Benincà 1988, Bianchi 2013, Zubizarreta 1999). It must be noted, however, that there is no consensus in the literature on the question of specific focus types, and syntactic position or syntactic construction. In principle, contrast can also be encoded postverbally, while information can also be expressed *in situ* (Cruschina 2021, Cruschina & Mayol 2025). Brunetti (2004), for instance, argues that a fronted focus can simply answer a question. The question, however, has either to be implicit or not present in the immediately preceding discourse.

On a more general level, many linguists interested in the phenomenon have investigated whether the semantic or pragmatic inferences observable across focus types and focus structures are in fact reflected in the grammar of natural languages. By today, there seems to be a general tendency to answer this question in the negative. Although some patterns are visible, the strict one-to-one mapping between focus type and corresponding formal marking across languages remains largely theoretical. Instead, many structures appear underspecified with respect to the type of focus they encode, and are often compatible with different focus interpretations. This is true for both focus structure and focus realization. The issue of realization will be discussed in the next section.

2.2 Focus realization

The term focus realization, or focus marking, is generally used to indicate the formal mechanism that signals a focus relation between a pragmatically construed referent and a proposition (Lambrecht 1994), or to refer to the linguistic realization of focus by way of special grammatical means, such as, focus accenting, syntactic reordering, morphological markers, etc. (Büring 2009). Given the distinction between focus and focus realization, and given the above characterization of focus as a universal cognitive or semantic category at the level of information structure (Zimmermann & Onea 2011), it is not the semantico-pragmatic category of focus, but rather its grammatical realization which is subject to cross-linguistic variation.

As has previously been observed, languages show a wide range of grammatical means for marking a focused constituent as such, ranging from phonological and prosodic devices (accenting, prosodic phrasing), through morphological devices (focus markers), to syntactic devices (constituent reordering). However, as mentioned above, focus marking is not mandatory in all languages. Rather, it seems

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to be formally underspecified (and therefore in need of contextual resolution) in many, if not all languages (Zimmermann 2011).

Thus, the grammatical realization of focus is often ambiguous. Thus, the grammatical realization of focus is often ambiguous, in that it is compatible with more than one focus-background structure. Moreover, the term *focus marking*, when used in this general way, implies that the formal devices used in the marking of focus are found exclusively in focus constructions (Fiedler et al. 2010). Nevertheless, some cross-linguistic patterns can be identified. The range of possibilities for marking focus is rather wide, and it would be difficult to mention all the possible strategies. Lambrecht (1994) identifies the following classification:

- Exclusively prosodic (e.g., English, German)
- Morphological (e.g., Wolof, West Chadic)
- Prosodic and morphological (e.g., Japanese)
- Prosodic and syntactic (e.g., Italian, Spanish, French)

In the generative account, the different focus-marking mechanisms have been regrouped into two main syntactic strategies, the *in situ* and the *ex situ* strategies (Aboh et al. 2008). The *in situ* option is generally considered to be the most economical strategy, since the focused constituent is realized in the position defined by the argument structure of the verb, while languages that show the *ex situ* option realize the focused constituent in the left periphery of the sentence (or C-domain in Rizzi 1997), immediately followed by the verb. Büring (2009), in his Prominence Theory of Focus realization (Truckenbrodt 1995, Büring 2009), claims that all focus-marking strategies, whether syntactic or not, can be analyzed under the umbrella of structural prominence, and that all languages are subject to one single constraint in focus realization, namely (10):

(10) **FocusProminence**

Focus needs to be maximally prominent.

In Büring's account, the notion of "prominence" is proposed as a prosodic one (as originally intended by Truckenbrodt 1995). FocusProminence is thus considered to be the only way focus interacts with the formation of structure. Even in morphological focus-marking systems, morphemes can serve to mark heads and/or boundaries. In other words, these morphemes would not literally mark the focus but rather the structural position in which focus is realized. However, adjustment strategies need not be prosodic: "if the prosodic system of a language

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does not allow A in the string A-B to be prominent, two more options arise: no adjustment whatsoever or syntactic adjustment to get A into a prosodically prominent position. The latter case will result in a language that marks focus by constituent order variation” (Büring 2009: 7), as is the case in Spanish (Zubizarreta 1998). Given that FocusProminence makes reference to prosodic structure, this implies that, according to this view, marked constituent order is established only after prosodic structure is built.

Most of the semantic literature on focus assumes that a focused constituent contains a pitch accent, though focus may extend beyond the accented constituent itself (e.g., Jackendoff 1972, Selkirk 2008, *inter alia*). Although such accents do not always affect the truth-conditional meaning of a sentence, especially in the absence of focus-sensitive operators like ‘only’, they can strongly affect the appropriateness of an utterance (Horn 1981, Beaver & Clark 2009). Lambrecht (1994) agrees that the common denominator among different focusing strategies is the prosodic prominence of a given syllable in the sentence. It is also the only device which can occur by itself, without being complemented by another coding system (as is the case in English). It would seem therefore that the role of prosody in focus marking is, in some sense, functionally more important than morpho-syntactic marking. This is no doubt a consequence of the iconic relationship between pitch prominence and the degree of communicative importance assigned to the focal portion of a proposition.

In French for instance, differences in the prosodic structure of a language account at least in part for the use of particular focus-marking systems. For example, it seems likely that the use of cleft constructions for the marking of focus differences is generally attributed to the fact that this language has both a relatively rigid constituent order and a relatively rigid rhythmic structure (Dufter & Reich 2003).¹

Phenomena of non-canonical word order are particularly visible across languages in the case of contrast or correction. As argued in Zimmermann (2008), Repp (2010), the notion of contrast refers to the fact that a particular focus content, or a particular speech act containing a focus, or a particular focus-background partition, is unexpected for the hearer from the speaker’s perspective, and may thus create problems for the successful update of the CG. Since unexpected facts are more difficult to accommodate, the speaker will often try to facilitate the

¹Note that the authors do not imply that cleft sentences are the only means to mark different focus types in French, and this claim is also supported by the corpus study reported in Chapter 3 of this book, where I show how different focus types can be expressed by several means in spoken French, albeit with different frequencies.

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hearer’s task of adjusting her background assumptions accordingly for successful communication. One possibility for the speaker to direct the hearer’s attention, and to facilitate the task of shifting the background assumptions, is to use a non-canonical, i.e., a structurally more complex sentence that comes with additional grammatical marking in form of, for instance, a particular intonation contour, syntactic movement, a cleft structure, or the insertion of morphological markers. As [Krifka & Musan \(2012\)](#) point out, there is a relatively strong need to express contrast cross-linguistically, and to express it with more explicit means such as syntactic movement. This can be explained by the plausible principle that if something is unexpected, it should be marked explicitly.

If contrast and correction seem to be consistently marked, information focus-marking, on the other hand, often appears undetermined. This observation is particularly relevant in the case of object focus. As already mentioned in the section 1.1, object focus is consistently expressed across languages through “unmarked” strategies (see the “Argument Asymmetry” in focus realization, [Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010](#)). In languages that mark focus by means of a combination of prosodic and syntactic strategies, such as French and Spanish, realizing focus on the object generally results in the canonical SVO order. In the absence of explicit focus marking, the focus-background structure is massively underspecified by the grammatical system, and is hence in need of contextual resolution. Conversely, as has often been stressed, a focus on the subject seems to require special marking across languages. As happens in the case of contrast or correction, it is often assumed that subject focus is explicitly marked because it conveys, once again, an “unexpected” interpretation of the subject as new information, that is more difficult to accommodate ([Lambrecht 2000](#)). This subject/object asymmetry in focus realization will be discussed in detail in the next section.

2.3 *The Argument asymmetry in focus realization*

Previous work on IS has identified a well-known asymmetry with respect to the realization of focused constituents across numerous languages. It has already been observed for some languages that focus on subjects obligatorily induces a non-canonical structure, while focus on non-subjects only optionally does so ([Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010](#)). This is presumably attributable to the frequent correlation between certain information-structural functions and certain syntactic constituents, where subjects are generally considered topics “by default”, while objects usually convey new information to the hearer.

Our utterances tend to be construed around and about subjects, which exhibit

2.3 *The Argument asymmetry in focus realization*

a range of semantic and discourse-related properties (e.g., givenness, agentivity, activation, etc.) which overlap with the ones displayed by topics. A subject in focus is, therefore, a marked option of the language and, consequently, less frequent. Given the general tendency in language to express marked interpretations through marked forms, it is not surprising that subject focus is consistently encoded by non-canonical strategies, while object focus generally lacks formal marking.

Evidence for this subject/non-subject asymmetry in focus realization has been provided for several languages including Hausa (Hartmann & Zimmermann 2007), West Chadic languages (Zimmermann & Onea 2011), several Kwa and Gur languages (Fiedler & Schwarz 2005) or Northern Sotho (Zerbian et al. 2007). The guiding hypothesis is that the special status of focused subjects is conditioned by information-structural factors, i.e., subjects in their canonical sentence-initial position are prototypically interpreted as topics (Li & Thompson 1976). Consequently, if the contextual cues establish a subject as focus, this conflicts with its primary information-structural function as non-focal information. In order to resolve this conflict, the focused subject will have to be realized in a non-canonical structure, for instance, by means of special morphological markers and/or syntactic reorganization (Fiedler et al. 2010).

According to Lambrecht (2010), speakers have an unconscious inclination to interpret isolated sentences as information-providing topic-comment sentences. Consequently, he considers that such articulation of the sentence represents, communicatively speaking, the most common type. In other words, it is more common for speakers to convey information about given discourse entities than to identify arguments in open propositions. Therefore, the different non-canonical strategies that encode subject focus would serve the purpose of “detopicalization” of the subject, i.e., they would enhance comprehension of the subject constituent as new information to the hearer, rather than as the entity the sentence is about (Reinhart 1981).

Following from these considerations, it might be that a subject in focus conveys an interpretation that is more costly to accommodate for the hearer because of its unexpectedness. This would also explain why object focus rarely shows a specific formal marking.

Additionally, the default domain of focus is generally assumed to be the entire VP (Drubig 2003), where objects are generally included. Since a direct object is already found in the default focus domain, additional encoding is not required, and speakers opt for more economic ways, such as canonical structures.

As has been pointed out, the focus asymmetry is also observable in the majority of Romance languages. Elicitation tasks of Canadian French (Skopeteas &

2 Focus and focus realization

Fanselow 2010) have shown that speakers overwhelmingly chose to use a cleft sentence to answer a question on the subject, while they opted for the SVO canonical structure whenever the focus was on the object. In the experiment, constructions with clefted objects did not occur at all.² Thus, to focus non-subject arguments like object, which are generally found sentence-finally, the *in situ* strategy is preferred because it is more economic than using a cleft (Destruel 2012).

Economy is said to determine the speaker's choice among existing structural alternatives for the expression of the same propositional content. This reflects the 'least effort' principle (Zipf 1972), which has been shown to account for several properties of language processing (Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010, 2011). In particular, *in situ* focus does not involve any syntactic operation, and hence qualifies as the least complex structure. Since a cleft construction contains additional structural material, it is plausible to assume that clefting involves a higher degree of structural complexity, and is therefore used only when strictly needed (e.g., in the case of a contrastive or corrective interpretation of the focused object). This generalization, however, does not account for the fact that, even for subject focus, we may also find more economic strategies in French or Spanish. If a cleft is an ideal strategy to focus the subject in French, then why do we find also *in situ* focusing for subjects? Conversely, if a postverbal subject is the means to encode subject focus in Spanish, why do we also find clefts? These questions are addressed in the next chapter, where I compare various studies on different focusing strategies for subjects in both languages from a language-internal and a comparative perspective.

²It must be noted, however, that in this study, speakers were forced to provide full sentences as answers. I thank Andreas Dufter for this suggestion.

3 Subject focus in Spanish and French: an unsolved matter

3.1 Introduction

The argument asymmetry described in Chapter 1 is particularly visible in the realization of focus in Spanish and French. Both languages, in fact, are said to adopt non-canonical means to focus the subject, while a canonical SVO order is generally preferred to express object focus (cf. [Lambrecht 1994](#) for both languages). However, there are considerable differences between the two languages. In many theoretical views, focused subjects in Spanish are associated with the re-ordering of the constituents in the sentence, where the focused subject appears in a postverbal position, rather than its usual preverbal (topical) one.

- (1) a. *¿Quién abrió la puerta?*
‘Who opened the door?’
b. *La abrió [Maria]_{FOC}.*
‘Maria opened it.’

This word order, generally called postverbal, VS order or subject-verb inversion, is also reported for the majority of members of the Romance family. Although micro-differences can be observed, Italian, Romanian, Catalan, European Portuguese and many non-standard varieties make use of this possibility to mark the subject as narrow focus of the sentence.

In the case of French, however, postverbal subjects (see [Lahousse 2006](#) and [Lahousse \(2011\)](#) for an exhaustive overview of the VS order in French) do not exhibit the same information-structural properties of their Spanish counterpart, and are almost exclusively found in written (mainly literary) texts ([Delbecque 2006](#)). [Dufter & Gabriel \(2016\)](#), for instance, claim that the possibility of VS in French is restricted to very few cases: it is felicitous with unaccusative verbs and in passive constructions. However, it is marginally possible with locative inversion and, notably, severely constrained in transitive constructions, such as in (2):

3 Subject focus in Spanish and French: an unsolved matter

- (2) *Rendront un devoir [les élèves qui ont raté l'examen de chimie]_{FOC}.*
 ‘The students that failed the chemistry exam must submit an assignment.’
 (Dufter & Gabriel 2016: 431)

According to Lambrecht (1994), in spoken French, the corresponding means to focus the subject is a *c’est* cleft.

- (3) a. *Qui a ouvert la porte?*
 ‘Who opened the door?’
 b. *C’est [Marie]_{FOC} qui l’a ouverte.*
 ‘It is Marie who opened it.’

This difference between the French and the Spanish (or most of the other Romance languages) focus-marking system is generally attributed to the difference in the syntactic and prosodic characteristics of the two languages. As is generally acknowledged, the possibility of realizing the subject in postverbal position (also called “free inversion”) is part of the “Null Subject Parameter” (cf. Rizzi 2013, Biberauer et al. 2009, *inter alia*), and the VS order has often been considered a major strategy for subject focusing in a pro-drop language like Italian or Spanish (cf. Belletti 2008a). It should be noted, however, that the existence of correlations between the positive setting of the Null Subject Parameter and other grammatical properties—such as the possibility of free inversion—has been repeatedly questioned (Newmeyer 2005). In particular, typological research (Gilligan 1987) has shown that the purported correlation between null subjecthood and freedom of constituent order is empirically untenable.

Nevertheless, the lack of postverbal subjects and the prevalent use of clefts in French is, at least in part, attributed to the fact that this language has both a relatively rigid constituent order and a relatively rigid rhythmic structure (Dufter & Reich 2003). According to Dufter & Gabriel (2016), deviations from the basic declarative subject-verb-object order have become less and less available over time in the history of French.

Moreover, according to Lambrecht (2001), “the occurrence of cleft constructions in a language correlates with the degree of positional freedom of prosodic accents and syntactic constituents in that language” (Lambrecht 2001: 488). Prosodically, Spanish is a language that displays lexical stress. This implies that speakers can signal focus by assigning pitch accent to a particular constituent. In French, on the other hand, prosodic prominence is obligatorily realized at the right edge of the Phonological Phrase, and cannot be displaced from this default position in order to signal focus on non-phrase-final constituents *in situ*. Thus, French does

3.1 Introduction

not display pitch accents to mark focus, but rather assigns prosodic prominence at the right edge of the phonological phrase through phrasing, i.e., a boundary tone, and not a pitch accent (Féry 2001).

In sum, while Spanish can assign prosodic prominence on a particular constituent, French needs to create phrasing. A cleft sentence would therefore be an optimal strategy to mark focus prominence, by creating two intonational phrases (through a copular sentence and a relative clause) and by positioning the subject at the end of that phonological phrase, i.e., at the boundary tone, so that it can receive prosodic prominence. This would explain why, in the case of object focus, no movement of the constituents or specific construction is needed. SVO being the canonical word order in both French and Spanish, a direct object is already in a position where it can receive prosodic prominence. A canonical SVO word order is also more economic than a cleft sentence, whose bi-clausal structure makes it “heavy” and “costly” (cf. Destruel 2016 for an experimental study).

Thus, the usage of clefts is generally considered a “compensatory device” (Doherty 2001: 457; Di Tullio 2006: 487) for the lack of word order flexibility and lexical stress, and is avoided whenever alternative focus-marking strategies are possible. Such a “trade-off” view on clefts, however, has been questioned by recent diachronic studies (Dufter 2008) that have investigated the frequency of clefts from Old French, a null-subject language with lexical stress different from Modern French, which, as mentioned above, has become very restricted in terms of word order flexibility and accentuation. The results of this diachronic study have revealed an overuse of clefts even in the presence of other, more economical focus-marking devices, suggesting that the rise and the frequent usage of cleft constructions in Modern French must be attributed to factors other than this “compensatory” function.

Lambrecht (2001) considers both the Spanish VS order and the French *c’est* clefts as operations of “detopicalization” of the subject, thus advancing the claim that these two strategies, even if syntactically considerably different, share important pragmatic similarities. This assumption has been repeatedly challenged by several empirical studies, that have shown that variation in the realization of focus can be observed not only cross-linguistically but also language-internally. Indeed, in both Spanish and French, experimental studies have revealed the possibility of *in situ* focus, even in non-contrastive interpretations (e.g., Gabriel 2007, 2010, Heidinger 2013, Vanrell & Fernández-Soriano 2013, a.o.). Moreover, recent corpus studies have found out that different cleft types (such as *il y a* clefts) can have the same IS-partition of *c’est* clefts, thus competing for the same pragmatic function (Karssenbergh 2017, 2018a).

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In this chapter, the many contributions to the investigation of subject focus are reviewed and discussed extensively. I present studies conducted by both formalist and functionalist authors, highlighting the main findings and problematic issues. The chapter is organized as follows: in section 2.1, I provide an overview of the studies on subject focus in Spanish, both from a theoretical and an empirical perspective. Section 2.2 summarizes the theoretical and empirical studies conducted for subject focus in French. In section 2.3, I compare the factors that have been claimed to interact with focus realization in the two languages. Finally, in section 2.4, I point out the research gap that I intend to fill with the present investigation.

3.2 Subject focus in Spanish: previous studies

Concerning the question of the realization of Spanish focused subjects, it is possible to distinguish two schools of thought: on one side, the theoretical approaches (cf. Zubizarreta 1998, Ramalle 2005, Costa 2001, Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006, Samek-Lodovici 2001, *inter alia*), on the other side, the functional ones (cf. Gabriel 2007, 2010, Heidinger 2013, Uth 2014, Hualde 2002, *inter alia*).

In a nutshell, in theoretical approaches, focused subjects in Spanish must necessarily occur in IP-final position, making postverbal subjects (or VS order) the only possible way to realize information focus on the subject.

- (4) *Comió una manzana [Juan]_{FOC}.*
 ‘Juan ate an apple.’

In this view, *in situ* (or prosodic) marking of focus on the subject is reserved to a contrastive interpretation of the subject referent (Zubizarreta 1999: 4228). However, such claims are often based on introspection or grammaticality judgments. The functional side does not entirely contradict the position defended by formal approaches. Rather, it advocates a weaker version of the above theory, showing through experiments that subject focus can also be realized by other strategies, such as *in situ* focusing (Gabriel 2007, Heidinger 2013, Uth 2014) or clefts (Feldhausen & Vanrell 2015), even in the case of a non-contrastive reading.

The main distinction between the two views can be resumed as such: while formal approaches argue in favour of a deterministic relationship between form and function, functional studies acknowledge the existence of variation and the possibility for the same pragmatic function to be expressed by different forms. I will first review the formal schools and then the functional ones, pointing out the factors that have been claimed to determine the optionality among different focus-marking devices, and which are relevant for my argumentation.

3.2 Subject focus in Spanish: previous studies

3.2.1 The formal framework: postverbal subjects

The term postverbal subject or VS order covers a series of syntactic phenomena that are not all necessarily related to focus. Subject-verb inversion can occur in a range of different linguistic contexts that are either constrained by syntactic requirements¹ or justified by stylistic reasons. Since this book is concerned with focus, the above-mentioned cases are not discussed here. Additionally, cases where the VS order expresses an all-focus interpretation orthetic judgement (Sasse 1987) are also out of the scope of the present study. Rather, postverbal subjects are considered only when they function as a focalizing means for the subject alone. There are various explanations that can be found in the literature of why a focused subject must appear sentence-finally in Spanish:

1. **Prosodic reasons** Cinque (1993) relates focus to stress and stress assignment rules. According to his view, stress must be assigned to the most embedded metrical constituent, which also corresponds to a syntactic constituent. He proposes that the accent indicating focus in a phrase must coincide with the most prominent accent (nuclear accent) in the phrase. This implies that the focus accent must fall on the most embedded constituent of the phrase as well. In languages that exhibit canonical SVO order, like Spanish, the most embedded constituent is the object.² Thus, in the case of object focus, no conflict can be observed between nuclear stress and focus accent, since it is always the rightmost element that receives the nuclear stress. Conversely, in the case of subject focus, intonation, constituent order requirements and focus prominence can be in conflict with one another (Selkirk 1995, Truckenbrodt 1999).

Truckenbrodt (1999), for instance, has shown that sacrificing the canonical pattern of phonological phrasing is a strategy that some languages use to solve such potential conflicts. Zubizarreta (1998), in her seminal work on postverbal subjects, suggested that in order to assign stress to the most deeply embedded element even under information focus, languages use two options: (i) render non-focused material invisible for the stress assignment algorithm, so that the focused constituent automatically qualifies as the most deeply embedded constituent; or (ii) alter word order to get the focused XP to be the most deeply embedded item. English has been argued

¹For instance, obligatory subject verb inversion with focus fronting (FF) and in *wh*-questions (see Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006).

²The term *object* here is an umbrella term that includes direct objects, indirect objects or prepositional phrase, depending on the argument structure of the verb.

3 *Subject focus in Spanish and French: an unsolved matter*

to belong to the first category, whereas Spanish has been attributed to the latter class. Thus, in Zubizarreta's Minimalist approach, the object would undergo p(rosodically-motivated) movement to allow the focused subject to be the most deeply embedded element and, thus, to receive prosodic prominence (but see [Ordóñez 2000](#), a.o., for an alternative view, positing the existence of object scrambling past the *in situ* subject). Movement operations such as these would be triggered by abstract IS-features situated in the underlying structure of the sentence (e.g., [Focus]).

P(rosodically motivated) movement is assumed to be obligatory in the case of information focus, and any deviation from this pattern is considered pragmatically infelicitous or even ungrammatical. This is also the view shared by classical optimality-theory (OT) approaches (e.g., [Costa 2001](#), [Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006](#), [Samek-Lodovici 2001](#)), according to which constructions with non-final focus are ruled out due to a violation of a high-ranked constraint such as the NSR ("Nuclear stress rule"), requiring nuclear stress to fall on the rightmost constituent of the sentence. A SVO configuration, with the subject receiving prosodic prominence would thus be acceptable only in the case of a contrastive interpretation.

Building on these observations, [Büring & Gutiérrez-Bravo \(2001\)](#) suggest an analysis where the focus and intonational requirements of English, Spanish and German are essentially the same, contrary to what has been suggested in previous work. Instead, these languages differ in when and whether they sacrifice phonological phrasing requirements or syntactic requirements. As such, their analysis preserves the insights captured in [Zubizarreta \(1998\)](#), while maintaining the assumption, shared in most recent work on phonological phrasing and accenting, that prominence is not governed by parameterized syntax-based principles such as the Nuclear Stress Rule. Instead, they propose that movement of focused XPs is the strategy used to accommodate these conflicts in languages where sacrificing the canonical pattern of phonological phrasing is not an option. The difference between focus marking between, say, English and Spanish, is not prosodic prominence versus syntactic position, but rather prosodic prominence *in situ* versus prosodic prominence in a specific position.

2. **Syntactic reasons** Syntactic accounts of focus (starting from [Brody 1990](#)) encode focus syntactically by proposing the existence of a 'Focus Criterion', according to which a focused item must move to the spec of a FocusPhrase

3.2 Subject focus in Spanish: previous studies

(FocP) to enter into a Spec/Head relation with a head endowed with a Focus feature. A significant work of this type is proposed by Rizzi (1997), in his Cartographic Approach, that divides the left periphery into a series of functional heads which are represented below.

- (5) [ForceP [TopP* [FocP [TopP* [FinP [IP ...

According to Rizzi's theory, preverbal focus is situated in a designated functional projection (FocP) within the split-CP (or left periphery of the sentence) above the IP. While his theory accounts for the behavior of preverbal focus, it fails to provide an explanation for the postverbal one. Belletti (2001, 2004, 2008b,a) integrate Rizzi (1997) into a new account for postverbal focus, suggesting that the area immediately above the VP ("the lowIP area", in her terms) is parallel to the left periphery in hosting focus and topic heads. According to the author, the VS order would thus be derived via movement of the subject to a dedicated position in the so-called low periphery of the sentence (cf. also Cardinaletti 2004). Specifically, the postverbal subject moves to this low peripheral focus position where it is interpreted, while a silent *pro* fills the preverbal subject position (meeting EPP requirements). In other words, Belletti proposes the existence of another TopP – FocP – TopP sequence just above the VP. This means that, in the spirit of her analysis, postposed subjects in such cases are moved subjects, and not subjects in their *in situ* origin (as e.g., Burzio 1986 claimed). Such strictly syntactic views, however, have often been the object of criticism. Many authors have pointed out that there are empirical problems with the predictions made by these analyses (Samek-Lodovici 2009). In particular, it has been claimed that these syntactic accounts do not explain why focus allows for so many distinct positions. The hypothesis that contrastive focus is restricted to a CP-level projection and information focus to a TP-level (Belletti 2004) may at first appear to address this issue, but it is inconsistent with empirical observations. Under this hypothesis, the distribution of each focus type should be restricted to a single position. However, as will be discussed in the next section, both contrastive and information focus can occur in multiple positions. Additionally, the same theory predicts that the distributions of contrastive and new information focus do not overlap, but empirical studies have shown that they actually can (e.g., Brunetti 2009).

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3. **Pragmatic reasons** The pragmatic explanation does not contradict the other views. Rather, it adds a communicative “flavor” to the questions of postverbal subjects by assuming that the default reading of a subject, when it appears in a canonical preverbal position in SVO languages, is the topic one. This view was mainly proposed by Lambrecht (1994, 2010). Since preverbal subjects are generally interpreted as topics, languages possess a series of syntactic, prosodic and morphological means to avoid such interpretation. Starting from the assumption that there is a cross-linguistic correlation between certain IS-functions and grammatical roles, where subjects are usually topics, while the VP is normally interpreted as focus (Drubig 2003), it has been proposed that speakers would operate a process of “demotion”, “objectification” or “detopicalization” of the subject, by situating it in a postverbal position (a position generally reserved to objects). Thus, the VS order in Spanish would be an iconic means to signal to the hearer that constituent must not be interpreted as topic, but rather as the relevant part of the answer, i.e., the focus.

This view is also supported by Fiedler et al. (2010), who, building on Romance data, as well as Chadic data, suggest that there is a strong requirement for all focus constituents, and not only non-subjects, to be placed in a prototypical, and in some sense prominent, focus position behind the verb. Subject-inverting in the languages that allow it would thus obey the communicative requirement to mark the subject not only as a non-topic, but especially as focus of the sentence.

3.2.2 The functional approaches: alternative focus-marking strategies

The claim that focused subjects in Spanish can be expressed only in IP-final position, while preverbal focused subjects can only be allowed with a contrastive interpretation (see section 2.2.1) has been called into question by more recent empirical studies. These studies, using methods such as reading tasks, acceptability judgements, elicitation tasks to corpus studies, have revealed that there is no one-to-one mapping between form and function, and that different syntactic positions can correspond to the same pragmatic function or, conversely, that the same pragmatic function can be expressed by different syntactic configurations (e.g., Hualde 2002, Feldhausen & Vanrell 2014, Heidinger 2013, Gabriel 2007 and Gabriel 2010 for Argentinean Spanish; Muntendam 2013 for Andean Spanish; Hoot 2016 for Mexican Spanish; Vanrell & Fernández-Soriano 2013 for Canarian Spanish).

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In particular, it has been shown that preverbal subjects can receive prosodic prominence even in the case of non-contrastive focus, and that contrastive focus can also be expressed by a subject appearing postverbally. Brunetti (2009), for instance, presents a qualitative corpus study on focus fronting in Italian and Spanish. The analysis of the contexts in which these utterances occur shows that only a subset of the fronted foci relates to an antecedent in discourse that is contrasted or corrected by the focused referent.

As such, empirical approaches to subject focus in Spanish do not contradict entirely the claims advanced by formal theories. Rather, they contribute to a contextualization of such claims, by showing that language-internal variation, and hence optionality, must be accounted for, instead of simply being labeled as “differences at the spell-out”, “competing grammars” or “dialectal differences”. Alonso-Ovalle et al. (2002), for instance, reports two experiments in which 12 question–answer pairs were submitted to 80 and 72 participants, respectively. Two different potential answers were offered for each question, one with SV order (6b) and one with VS order (6b’).

- (6) a. *Quién vino?*
 ‘Who came?’
 b. [*Juan*]_{FOC} *vino.*
 ‘Juan came.’
 or
 b’. *Vino* [*Juan*]_{FOC}.
 ‘Juan came.’
- (Alonso-Ovalle et al. 2002: 17)

Contrary to the predictions of a theory like the one proposed by Zubizarreta (1999), the answer *Juan vino* (6b), in which the subject is the first constituent, and thus does not receive default stress, is chosen as the answer to the question ‘Who came?’ 51.5% of the time (as reported by Biezma 2014). Important additional evidence is provided by Ocampo (2003). Building on spontaneous conversations, the author shows that main intonational prominence does not necessarily fall on the non-presupposed part of the sentence, i.e., the focused part of the sentence, and that speakers of Spanish used stress for many different functions. In the author’s analysis, the part of the sentence presenting new information does not actually bear stress. The results from his corpora add to the evidence that the subject in non-marked word order (SVO) can be conveyed as focused, regardless of default intonational prominence on the object.

Another prominent empirical contribution, in this respect, is the experimental study conducted by Gabriel on 18 speakers of Peninsular Spanish (Gabriel 2007)

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and 50 speakers of Argentinian Spanish (Gabriel 2010). Based on elicitation tasks through images, Gabriel came to the following conclusions: speakers of Spanish cross-dialectally prefer preverbally focused subjects in clauses with a full object NP (7), while the postverbal position is favored when the object is realized as a clitic (8), and in constructions with intransitive verbs, i.e., unaccusatives (9) or unergatives.

(7) [María]_{FOC} comió la manzana.
'María ate the apple.'

(8) La comió [María]_{FOC}.
'María ate it.'

(9) Llegaron [Julia y María]_{FOC}.
'Julia and María arrived.'

It becomes clear from these findings that subject focus in Spanish is also regulated by factors such as the argument structure of the verb and the morphological forms of the constituents in the sentence. Given that movement is a costly operation (Chomsky 1991) and hence, when possible, avoided by speakers, in a transitive sentence with two phonetically-expressed arguments, a "light" (e.g., a pronoun) subject and a full object NP, it is easier for speakers to focus the subject *in situ* (by assigning prosodic prominence), than to move it to a postverbal position, such as in (7). Conversely, when the object is "light", because it is realized as a clitic, the movement of the subject to a postverbal position is preferred, such as in (8). The author concludes that "the mechanisms of syntactic focus marking, i.e., the use of a particular syntactic construction in a given pragmatic context, is governed by strict rules to a lesser extent than suggested in much of the literature" (Gabriel 2010: 189).

These findings are in line with Lambrecht's (2010) Preferred Clause Construction (PCC) theory. Based on analyses of corpora of spoken French, the author found an overwhelming preference for a certain sentence type which is defined as "Preferred Clause Construction" (PCC). In this construction type, the preverbal position is occupied by a clitic pronoun and the postverbal position by an XP (typically a single one) with focus value. The PCC is instantiated in 95 to 97% of all clauses analyzed in the corpora. The results of Gabriel's study would then prove that this pattern is also valid for Spanish.

As reported by García García & Uth (2018), Zubizarreta (2016) does take the empirical contribution by Gabriel (2010) on Argentinean Spanish into account.

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However, this phenomenon is often dismissed as mere dialectal variation, which does not shed new light on the actual controversy.

Other empirical studies, based on a contrastive elicitation study comprising four European Spanish varieties, namely Canarian Spanish, Castilian Spanish, Basque Spanish (with L1 Basque), and Basque Spanish (with L1 Spanish) have been conducted by [Vanrell & Fernández-Soriano \(2018\)](#), who, based on 8 participants, observed a number of further patterns of syntactic variation related to focus marking. With regard to information focus on the subject, for example, they found that while speakers of Castilian and Basque Spanish (both with L1 Spanish and L1 Basque) tend to use *in situ* marking, speakers of Canarian Spanish show a significant preference for cleft constructions. Moreover, the data shows that, in most varieties, focused subjects tend to be realized *in situ* regardless of focus type.

Indeed, clefts constructions have been reported as focus-marking strategies for Spanish as well. The standard assumption in many theoretical studies is that clefts in Spanish are used to mark mainly contrastive focus on the subject (e.g., [Lambrecht 1994](#)). The rationale behind this claim is formulated in terms of economy of the language. Re-ordering of the constituents in the sentence is, by definition, less costly than using a “heavy” syntactic construction. Therefore, if Spanish speakers have more economic means to focus the subject in neutral contexts (i.e., information focus), there is no reason why they would opt for a heavier and costlier strategy. Such claims, however, have been further challenged by empirical evidence.

[Cabrera \(1999\)](#), for instance, states that simple clefts on the one hand, and (inverted) pseudo-clefts on the other, have different information structural properties, and are not limited to conveying contrastive/corrective interpretations of the subject, as in (10):

- (10) *Es [Juan]_{FOC} quien ha llegado tarde.*
 ‘It is Juan who arrived late.’ ([Cabrera 1999](#): 4247)

[Feldhausen & Vanrell \(2015\)](#) have tested these claims through elicitation tasks with 4 speakers of Spanish from Madrid. Their results showed that cleft constructions are used for both focus types, even though certain preferences can be observed: (inverted) pseudo-clefts are favored for neutral focus, while simple clefts are preferred for contrastive focus. After analyzing speakers’ answers prosodically, the authors claim that focus does not always have to bear sentential stress: in clefts, prosodic alignment (phrasing) can be a reliable correlate of focus. In other words, since clefting the subject allows the speaker to position it

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at the edge of a phonological phrase, prosodic prominence is already achieved by virtue of this position, and assigning pitch accent is no longer necessary.

As for contrastive foci, while theoretical studies claim that fronting (or in the case of the subject, *in situ* focusing) is a formal means of encoding contrastive focus in Spanish (cf. Zubizarreta 1998), other views suggest that contrast can be encoded by other alternative means. Brunetti (2009), for instance, gives examples of contrastive foci which are not fronted, as well as examples where the contrastive focus is fronted. Empirical studies, thus, suggest that variation can be found both in the case of information and contrastive subject focus, and that such variation can be accounted for by considering not just syntactic or exclusively prosodic factors, but also semantic and dialectal ones.

García García & Uth (2018), reviewing the question of subject focus in Spanish, point out the frequent lack of comparability of the results issued from the different studies due to i) methodological differences and ii) conceptual or terminological differences regarding the different focus types/categories. The authors stress the fact that many of the claims advanced in the literature are based on methods of data collection that differ considerably (e.g., elicitation tasks, reading tasks, corpora, etc.), and that such differences might have repercussions on the findings. Uth (2014), for instance, compares different elicitation tasks, and shows that even slight differences in the design of picture-based elicitation materials may have a crucial impact on both word order and intonation.

Moreover, the classification of focus categories such as “broad”, “presentational”, “neutral”, “narrow”, “contrastive”, “emphatic”, “identificational”, “exhaustive”, “corrective”, “mirative”, etc. adds confusion to the picture, since some authors might have a definition of information focus that differs from that of other authors.

Similarly, Escandell-Vidal & Leonetti (2019) present arguments in favor of Zubizarreta (1998), according to which subject foci that appear in a non-final position cannot be instances of information focus, and have to be considered occurrences of some other focus type (e.g., contrastive/corrective). Their claims are once again based on inconsistencies found at the level of the methodology or the notions used by previous empirical studies.

Reviewing the method employed by Gabriel (2007), based on elicitation pictures, the authors agree with Uth (2014), who claims that the focalized subject in this experiment tend to appear preverbally because it carries the wrong (non-intended) pragmatic inferences: since the answer that participants have to provide is too obvious, it cannot be taken as an instance of new information, but rather as an indication of epistemicity or evidentiality. Escandell-Vidal & Leonetti (2019) therefore advocate caution in the interpretation of these findings.

3.3 Subject focus in French: previous studies

In sum, while some authors state that there is no one-to-one correlation between focus type and subject position in Spanish, others reinforce the position taken by Zubizarreta (1998), and claim that a subject expressing information focus in Spanish must compulsorily appear in the postverbal slot.

3.3 Subject focus in French: previous studies

In the literature on focus in French, it is possible to observe contrastive views as well. Theoretical approaches claim that subject focus can only be expressed by a *c'est* cleft and that, due to the rigid melodic structure of the language, prosodic marking through pitch accent (e.g., *in situ* focusing) is not acceptable (e.g., Lambrecht 1994). Some empirical studies seem to confirm this claim, whereas others argue that *in situ* strategies are possible through intonational phrasing of the subject constituent (e.g., Féry 2001).

Indeed, the literature on French focus marking conventionally states that French marks focus via syntactic means. Compared to other Romance languages or to English, French is often assumed to require special syntactic constructions to mark focus, and seems to be known as the “black sheep” for not having a flexible prosody. Yet, over the last twenty years, much work has been done on the prosodic marking of information structure in French (Jun & Fougeron 2000, Féry 2001, Beyssade et al. 2015). Moreover, recent corpus studies have strengthened the argument that a *c'est* cleft is not the only means to mark information focus on the subject, and that *il y a* clefts can also carry out the same IS-function (Karssenberg 2017, 2018b).

Overall, the literature on French reveals a picture similar to the one observed for Spanish: while some authors are in favor of a one-to-one mapping between function and form, others dispute this claim, and show that the same function can be expressed by different, competing means. These studies are discussed in the following sections. Sections 2.3.1 and 2.3.2 summarize research on the realization of French focused subjects from syntactic and prosodic perspectives, respectively. Finally, Section 2.4 illustrates how the present book aims to address the gap in the investigation of this phenomenon for both Spanish and French.

3.3.1 Clefts as focalization strategies

Cleft sentences are generally assumed to be focus-marking strategies, although their distribution and IS-properties vary across languages. French, for instance, is

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a language that is claimed to make a much more abundant use of these constructions, compared to other Romance languages (Katz 2000, Dufter 2009, Cesare et al. 2016, Garassino 2022).

Importantly, not all occurrences of clefts are focus-marking devices. Several authors have pointed out that, even in French, a cleft sentence can sometimes be used in different contextual situations which are not related to focus (Prince 1978, Hedberg 1990, Delin 1992, Dufter & Jacob 2009, Mertens 2012). Such cases are out of the scope of the present work, and will not be discussed here. This being a study on focus, I will limit the discussion to cleft sentences with a focus-background articulation.

The “cleft” construction, a term coined by Jespersen (1927), is a bi-clausal construction consisting of a main copular clause, or “clefted element”, and a non-restrictive relative clause that expresses a proposition which could otherwise be conveyed in one single, non-clefted clause. The latter is considered equivalent to the cleft with respect to its truth conditional value and its illocutionary force (Lambrecht 2001: 457). The term cleft has since been extended to different types of bi-clausal constructions, such as *c’est* clefts (or it-clefts) pseudo-clefts, or *il y a* clefts (or there-clefts):

- (11) ***C’est* cleft**
C’est [Marie]_{FOC} qui a acheté le gâteau.
 ‘It is Marie who bought the cake.’
- (12) **Pseudo cleft**
Ce qui m’embête c’est [qu’ils ne nous donnent pas d’informations]_{FOC}.
 ‘What annoys me it’s that they don’t give us any information.’
- (13) ***Il y a* cleft**
Il y a [une vieille dame]_{FOC} qui habite pas loin d’ici.
 ‘There is an old lady who lives not far from here.’

Clefts have been analyzed from both derivational and functional approaches. Within cartographic syntax, for instance, it has been proposed that all clefted constituents are moved into a designated focus projection in the left periphery (Kiss 1998, 1999). In Belletti (2008a,b, 2012), the author proposes a cartographic account in which she argues for the existence of two different focus positions in the clausal map: i) the vP peripheral low focus position in the matrix clause, in the case of new information subject clefts and ii) the high left peripheral position in the reduced CP complement of the copula, in the case of contrastive/corrective object clefts – and also in subject clefts when they are interpreted/used

3.3 Subject focus in French: previous studies

contrastively/correctively (Belletti 2012: 96). Therefore, under this view, the interpretive effects associated with clefts derive directly from the syntactic position in which the focus is realized (although Haegeman et al. 2014 argue against analyzing clefts as occupying a “high” CP position).

In non-derivational frameworks, on the other hand, clefts are discussed as grammatical constructions in the sense of Construction Grammar (Fillmore 1988), i.e., as grammatical configurations in which morphosyntactic and prosodic features concur to produce particular form-function-use correspondences.

Lambrecht (1994) claims that the focus meaning of the two clauses contained in a cleft is non compositional, in the sense that it is not the computable sum of the meaning of its parts. Rather, it is a property of the complex grammatical construction as a whole. Thus, neither its form nor its interpretation can be predicted on the basis of general syntactic and semantic properties of the grammar. Clefts, in this sense, would be grammaticalized constructions whose function is to convey the pragmatic interpretation of focus.

The author also states that a *c’est* cleft would be an optimal strategy to express subject focus because of a constraint allowing only topical material in preverbal subject position in French. Such constraint would lead to an “increased necessity to resort to the use of clefts” (Lambrecht 2001: 490). Since preverbal subjects are generally topical (Chafe 1976, Keenan & Schieffelin 1976), an agent receiving focal status is often expressed as an object (i.e., in the focus phrase following the copula clause of the *c’est* cleft). In this position, it does not violate the language prosodic and syntactic constraints that demand that main stress occur at the right-edge of an intonational phrase (Jun & Fougeron 2000).

Thus, subjects are moved into a dedicated focus position (the clefted element) in which they are interpreted as a focus, and marked as such. The basic premise for this proposal is the observation that languages tend to reserve the preverbal position for topical material – material which is more readily accessible in the discourse. Moreover, this idea is implemented in Aissen (1999) through the harmonic alignment of two scales, (i) a relational scale (Subject > Non-subject) and (ii) a focus scale (Topic > Focus), resulting in the generalization that foci in preverbal subject position are not harmonic and hence should be avoided.

Therefore, a *c’est* cleft would be an optimal strategy because it allows the desired pragmatic effect of focus on the subject and, at the same time, respects the prosodic requirement of the language (phrase-final stress). By creating two separate IPs, the cleft allows the focused element to receive main stress by virtue of being situated in a boundary tone, and to fulfill the rightmost preference of the language for accent placement.

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As reported by Dufter (2009), in the generative tradition (Szabolcsi 1981, Kiss 1998, Gussenhoven 2008), the focus marking function of clefts is considered an epiphenomenon, while all occurrences of clefts are, in fact, strategies to enforce an exhaustive interpretation on the clefted constituent. In other words, the value provided by the clefted element excludes all the other possible alternatives that satisfy the *wh*-variable contained in the (implicit or explicit) QUD. This implies that examples like the one found in Jespersen (1927: 88-89), ‘It is the wife who decides’, must be considered semantically equivalent to ‘Only the wife decides’.

Similarly, Lambrecht (2001), Katz (1997) mention that one of the discourse functions of the *c’est* cleft is to identify the *X* as having the property *P*, carrying the inference that nothing else in the context displays the property. In other words, a *c’est* cleft would carry semantic exhaustivity encoded in its syntactic form.

A different view is proposed by Horn (1981), who suggests that clefts only conversationally imply exhaustivity. A number of recent experimental studies (Destruel & DeVaugh-Geiss 2018, De Vaugh-Geiss et al. 2018) has confirmed Horn’s assumption by showing that adding a continuation that cancels the initial exhaustivity of a *c’est* cleft does not affect the truth-conditional value of the sentence. Moreover, it is judged as felicitous by speakers. These results support the prediction that cleft sentences are associated with an exhaustive inference that is cancelable, and therefore not part of their at-issue meaning. Dufter (2009) himself argues that exhaustivity in these constructions should not be taken as an invariant aspect of cleft meaning, because it is not semantically entailed, but pragmatically conveyed and, hence, cancelable. Such argumentation would also justify why occurrences of *c’est* clefts are found in combination with exhaustivity particles, such as *seulement* ‘only’³ or, conversely, with additive particles such as *aussi* ‘too’, which are clear indicators of the non-exhaustive interpretation of the proposition.

In a similar vein, De Cesare & Garassino (2015), based on a corpus of authentic cleft occurrences collected from different written sources, show that this meaning component associated with clefts in English and Italian is best accounted for in terms of a conventionalized conversational implicature. Thus, whether exhaustivity is part of the coded meaning, or rather a generalized conversational implicature, is still a matter of debate. Consider, for instance, the following examples taken directly from the corpus under investigation (*sgs* corpus, Adli 2011):

³As Dufter (2009) rightfully argues, if exhaustivity were indeed part of the semantic content expressed by the cleft, one might wonder why restrictive particles such as *only* occur as modifiers of clefted constituents at all. In theory, expressions with restrictive semantics cannot be combined felicitously (cf. ?only exclusively the wife).

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- (14) *C'est seulement [moi]_{FOC} ensuite qui suis venue frapper pour la prévenir.*
 'It is only me, afterwards, who came to warn her.' (sgs French, 38/187)

If the exhaustive contribution of a *c'est* cleft is debatable, its IS-function as a focalizing means for the subject is less controversial. Destruiel (2016), for instance, compared spoken colloquial French (CoF) to Standard French (StF) in two elicitation tasks, testing 21 and 21 participants respectively. Her findings show that, in the case of CoF, participants used significantly more clefts when focusing a subject and significantly more canonical sentences when focusing a non-subject. Conversely, in the case of StF, participants allow grammatical subjects to be focused *in situ* as well as in a cleft (Destruiel & Féry 2020, Destruiel et al. 2024). Moreover, the difference between the two forms was negligible, thus confirming Lambrecht's (1994) assumption that the restriction on subject focus occurring in preverbal position is specific to the colloquial grammar of French. Additionally, she found a slight effect of focus type: participants were found to only produce slightly more clefts when expressing a correction, compared to when marking information focus.

Reichle (2014) combines corpus data (*Europarl* corpus, Koehn et al. 2005) with processing tasks (21 participants), showing that subject clefts are not only more frequent, but also more easily processed than object clefts. He considers frequency and processing costs as indicators of the fact that a *c'est* cleft is the ideal means to express focus on a subject.

Thus, these studies seem to support Lambrecht's (1994) claim that a *c'est* cleft is the preferred way of expressing subject focus in French. Lambrecht even argues that French is particularly transparent in the mapping between IS onto syntax, and posits a one-to-one correlation between cleft type and IS-function: *c'est* clefts are in fact considered the focus-marking device for argument focus, in particular subject focus. In contrast, *il y a* clefts would express sentence focus, where no information-structural partition is observable, thus conveying an all-new interpretation, with both the clefted element and the relative clause in focus (15).

- (15) [*Il y a Jean qui a téléphoné*]_{FOC}.
 'Jean called.' (Lambrecht 1988: 136)

Moreover, Lambrecht (2010) notes a correlation in terms of information status of the subject constituent: given that *il y a* clefts introduce new referents in the discourse, subjects of these constructions generally appear as indefinite NPs (e.g., *Il y a une vieille dame qui arrive* 'There is an old lady who is coming'). Crucially, such a categorical relation between focus type and grammatical construction has been questioned by empirical research. A number of studies has

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shown that the same structure can correspond to different IS-interpretations, and that the one-to-one correlation between form and function is, if anything, a theoretical assumption more than a proven fact. This also implies that the same IS-function can be expressed by different forms. For instance, it has been shown that *c'est* clefts can also be found in presentative contexts (all-new sentence) or exhibiting a topic-comment partition, where the clefted element is actually the topic and the relative clause is the comment (Dufter 2009). Similarly, recent corpus studies have shown that *il y a* clefts can occur with a focus-background partition, and not exclusively as all-focus strategies (Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010, Karssenberg 2017, 2018a).

Karssenberg (2017) and Karssenberg (2018b), for instance, conducting a corpus study on *il y a* clefts, found that a considerable number of these constructions were used to mark focus on the subject, and that the relative clause contained presupposed (old) rather than new information. To account for this finding, the author argues that what seems to determine the alternation between the two constructions is exhaustivity (or the lack of it), claiming that there is a frequent correlation between *c'est* clefts and exhaustive focus interpretation, while *il y a* clefts are more often found in non-exhaustive contexts. She also adds, however, that exhaustivity is not entailed semantically in the two clefts types, but rather conveyed by contextual cues and is, therefore, cancelable.

Additionally, several prosodic investigations of focus have contributed to weaken Lambrecht's (1994) claim of a deterministic form-function relation in spoken French. These studies are discussed in the next section.

3.3.2 Prosodic realization of subject focus in French

Despite Lambrecht's (1994) claim about focused subjects being obligatorily marked by clefts, some researchers take a canonical sentence like (16) to be completely acceptable, and argue that subject focus can also be marked via prosodic means (Beyssade et al. 2004).

- (16) a. *Qui a acheté une mandoline?*
 'Who bought a mandolin?'
 b. [*Mallarmé*]_{FOC} *a acheté une mandoline.*
 'Mallarmé bought a mandolin.' (Beyssade et al. 2004: 478)

Belletti (2018) points out that French speakers do not totally exclude SV answers similar to the English type, even if she does not provide empirical evidence for this claim. Similarly, Skopeteas & Fanselow (2010) found that 10 native

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speakers produce narrowly-focused subjects in their canonical sentence-initial position at a high rate (45.3% of the time). Finally, Samek-Lodovici (2005) develops an optimality-theory account where *in situ* realization is claimed to be the optimal output for subject focus.

A prominent contribution, in this respect, has been made by Féry (2001) who conducted a production task in which 10 native speakers read the answering component of a question-answer pair. Although given the option to change the wording if judged unnatural, participants marked focus on grammatical subjects via prosodic phrasing (i.e., by realizing the subject in its own prosodic phrase), retaining the canonical order in most cases. These findings led her to formulate the Phrasing Hypothesis (Féry 2001), according to which prosodic marking of focused subjects in French is possible by creating phrasing on the subject constituent. Therefore, even if assigning pitch accent on a single syllable is banned, the *in situ* strategy is still acceptable by virtue of situating the subject constituent in a boundary tone, thus giving it prosodic prominence.

Of course, one limitation of this study is that the participants are given scripts for the sentences to produce. One reason why they chose not to vary the sentence structure, and produce a cleft instead, could simply be that they considered changing the word order more costly than maintaining it. Yet, her study showed that prosody is sensitive to information structure in French, a finding that has important implications on the debate about subject focus and its realization.

More recently, Greif & Skopeteas (2021) conducted an experiment with 16 native speakers, examining whether canonical sentences and cleft constructions could be used with different prosodic realizations with different treatments of corrective focus in typologically different languages, including French. Their findings reveal that both canonical sentences, with a higher prosodic prominence on the edge-tone syllable of the subject, and cleft sentences are possible. When comparing the production task with the results from an acceptability judgement, they found that canonical sentences are slightly more felicitous in the case of object focus than in case of subject focus, but are nevertheless accepted, even when focusing the subject.

This shows that the expression of subject focus in French may be more complicated than previously acknowledged and that more thorough empirical work is still needed to understand the exact conditions under which clefting is required, which cleft types are used as focus-marking strategies and how often the *in situ* strategy occurs. Even if all the strategies discussed above are possible, it is not clear with which distribution they occur and, especially, what determines the optionality among them.

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3.4 Filling the gap

Considering the studies discussed above, it is safe to conclude that the question of subject focus for both languages is far from being resolved, and that more research is needed. Although many theoretical studies hint at a one-to-one correlation between form and function, empirical data seems to suggest that such a claim is too strong.

3.4.1 The importance of argument structure

The overall impression is that Spanish constituent order is indeed free, and that focused constituents can appear in various positions, irrespective of the type of focus (contrastive or informational). However, as Gabriel's (2007) study shows, other linguistic factors may interact with focus (and focus types), such as the argument structure of the verb, the morphological form (and hence the information status) of the subject or constituent weight.⁴

A similar scenario can be observed for the use of different cleft formats in French. For instance, it had been initially claimed that sentences like *c'est* clefts or pseudo clefts display the same communicative properties and, as such, are totally interchangeable (Akmajian 1970). It has become clear, however, that the variation among these forms is not totally free and unconstrained, but rather regulated by specific factors. In fact, *c'est* clefts have been claimed to be "preferred with shorter constituents such as pro-forms, whereas pseudo-clefts more readily accommodate longer, in particular clausal, elements in the cleft position" (Dufter & Gabriel 2016: 24). This implies that the morphological form of the subject constituent (and thus its level of referentiality) has an impact on the realization of focused subjects in French as well. Similarly, to account for the alternation between *c'est* and *il y a* clefts, Karssenbergh (2017) points out the role of exhaustivity (and hence of focus type). Her assumption, however, was not tested within her study.

If focus type and activation of the subject constituent have been claimed to affect the realization of subject focus in both languages, the role of argument structure has only been investigated in relation to focus in Spanish, i.e., in correlation to Spanish pre- and postverbal subjects. How argument structure interacts with French focus realization, however, remains so far unexplored. In other words,

⁴For instance, focus realization might be subject to the "End-Weight Principle" (Quirk et al. 1985, Hawkins 1994, 2004) according to which informationally "heavy" constituents are placed toward the end of the clause. This principle provides a processing-based explanation for the alignment of focus with clause-final or prosodically prominent positions.

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there is no systematic study that investigates whether the argument structure of the verb may affect, say, the choice among different cleft types.

3.4.2 Elliptical strategies

A further limitation may be found in many elicitation tasks, where participants are usually instructed to respond to the stimulus questions with full answers, thus limiting the range of possibilities in the answer type and the spontaneity of expression. These studies tend to exclude any type of elliptical utterance from their analysis (e.g., Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010). Since many studies on focus in Romance languages concentrate on syntactic variation (and on the position of the arguments with respect to the verb), the requirement for producing full sentences is not surprising.

Nevertheless, these elliptical structures are extremely frequent in spoken speech and, at least in dialogical situations, they produce a much more natural effect than their full counterparts. Evidence from studies on register and utterance type suggests that fragmental sentences are not only very frequent, but constitute even the majority of sentence types in spontaneous dialogues. For instance, according to Du Bois (1987), while speakers tend to produce heavier structures in narratives (e.g., in classical sociolinguistic interviews), full sentences are sometimes unnecessary and redundant in dialogues. In the latter situation, a shorter answer type is perfectly acceptable for the communicational needs of the speakers.

Similarly, Krifka (2008) notes that in spontaneous speech, speakers tend to omit the presuppositional part of the information, and to utter only the informative part, i.e., the focus. The same has been claimed by Fiedler et al. (2010) in their cross-linguistic investigation of subject focus. Also according to Lahousse & Lamiroy (2012), sentences like (17) may not sound totally natural to certain speakers because the answer to the same questions in spontaneous speech is likely to be the subject alone (as in (18)):

- (17) a. *Qui a mangé les gâteaux?*
 ‘Who ate the cakes?’
 b. *Ont mangé les gâteaux [Marie, Pierre et Stéphanie]_{FOC}.*
 ‘Marie, Pierre and Stephanie are those who ate the cakes.’
- (18) a. *Qui a mangé les gâteaux?*
 ‘Who ate the cakes?’
 b. *[Marie, Pierre et Stéphanie]_{FOC}.*
 ‘Marie, Pierre and Stephanie.’ (Lahousse & Lamiroy 2012: 398)

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Ortega-Santos (2016) points out that the literature on focalization processes in Spanish and beyond rarely considers the interaction between focus and ellipses, even though a considerable number of studies has noted the need for the element surviving ellipses, also known as “the remnant”, to be focused and, as such, to escape the ellipsis site (see Merchant 1999). However, the interplay between ellipses and focus only figures marginally in the literature on focalization in Spanish, in spite of the already-noted connection between these structures and their IS-properties (Merchant 1999, *inter alia*).

Finally, Escandell-Vidal & Leonetti (2019), reviewing the studies on the realization of subject focus in Spanish, stress that in wh-questions eliciting information focus on the subject, the preferred answer is always a fragment and not a complete one (also noted by Féry 2017). The authors claim that the reason lies in the fact that the default option for presupposed (backgrounded) information is to be elided. Thus, when participants are forced to produce sentences including all the elements in the utterance, “they are prevented from producing a natural, spontaneous answer” (Escandell-Vidal & Leonetti 2019: 9).

As for the investigation of focus in French, several authors have noted that the most natural answer to a subject interrogative in dialogues is what has been defined in the literature as “reduced clefts” (Belletti 2005, 2008b,a).⁵

- (19) a. *Qui (est-ce que qui) a parlé?*
 ‘Who spoke?’
 b. *C’est [Jean]_{FOC} (qui a parlé).*
 ‘It is Jean (who spoke).’ (Belletti 2008b: 192)

This term indicates the realization of a cleft without the presupposed part of the sentence (Frascarelli & Ramaglia 2013), and has often been the object of discussion for French and Brazilian Portuguese (Lobo & Martins 2017), even though it can be found in other languages, like Spanish.

- (20) a. *Quién ha hablado?*
 ‘who spoke?’
 b. *Ha sido [Juan]_{FOC} (quien ha hablado).*
 ‘It was Juan (who spoke).’

Karssenbergh (2017) notes that, in the case of French *il y a* clefts as well, the relative clause often tends to be omitted by speakers when it contains discourse-given information (presuppositional information), leaving only the clefted element introduced by *il y a*, such as in (37b):

⁵Doetjes et al. (2004: 538) refer to such instances as “truncated clefts” (see also Buring 1998, Hedberg 2000).

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- (21) a. *Il n’y a personne qui monte.*
 ‘There’s nobody going upstairs?’
 b. *Si, il y a [Pierre]_{FOC} (qui monte l’escalier).*
 ‘There is Pierre (who goes upstairs).’ (Karssenbergh 2017: 202)

Evidence from acquisition (Lobo et al. 2019) shows that the production of full clefts increases significantly with age, whereas the proportion of reduced clefts, which are more frequent than full clefts, decreases from the age of 4. Lahousse & Jourdain (2019) conducted a corpus study on the spontaneous speech of early childhood (age 1-3 y.o.), and found that reduced clefts are more frequent than other cleft types, and that full clefts tend to appear at a later stage of this age range.

As for the usage of these structures, Belletti (2005) claims that reduced clefts are preferred as answers in contexts where the subject interrogative immediately precedes the answer as in (18), even if her claim is not based on empirical evidence. Similarly, Reichle (2014) claims that in Q-A pairs with fast turns, “full” clefts might be considered unnecessarily wordy, and the presupposition contained in the relative clause is not necessarily repeated in the response. He states: “Such abbreviated responses are possible when the clefted relative clause is highly activated due to having just been mentioned” (Reichle 2014: 8). However, the longer responses (with a full repetition of the cleft in the response) are possible, and findings from judgment tasks indicate that native speakers find such pairings acceptable (Reichle 2014).

Katz (2000) had already conducted an acceptability judgement study, comparing the participants’ evaluation of full clefts vs. reduced clefts. The author concludes that both structures are judged to be felicitous by speakers of French. Apart from this acceptability task, both in the case of reduced clefts and in the case of fragments there are no systematic empirical studies that investigate the frequency of these strategies (either reduced clefts or fragments) in the two languages, nor the pragmatic contexts in which they occur.

The need for more empirical investigation is also advocated by Destruel (2016), who points out that:

“Full sentences are not typically used in natural discourse, and ensuring that participants use such forms may have led to elicited data that contains a biased, non-optimal variant of participants’ speech. This is indeed potential drawback that will need to be addressed in future work. The present experiment constitutes a first step in the exploration of focus-marking strategies in different varieties of French that will certainly benefit from further empirical work exploring more naturally-

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occurring data (i.e., corpus studies and other elicitation methods like semi-directed interviews) to corroborate the current findings.” (Destruel 2016: 309).

It is important to point out that there is an ongoing debate on the exact syntactic nature of structures such as fragmental answers or reduced clefts. Concerning fragments, some authors consider these structures as covertly clausal and elliptical (Merchant 2005), while others claim that they are in fact base-generated constituents (Stainton 1998, Ginzburg & Sag 2000, Jacobson 2016), and not the result of some kind of deletion.

Similarly, in the debate concerning reduced clefts, some authors are in favor of the “reduction hypothesis” (Jenkins 1973), which posits a base-derived account, according to which these structures would be parallel in “deep and surface” structure to clefts without the relative clause (i.e., the “shortened/truncated cleft analysis”). Others, like Milsark (1976), Birner et al. (2007) present several arguments against such a truncation (or reduction) hypothesis, concluding that the similarities between ‘full’ clefts and copular sentences without relative clauses are due to functional overlap, and that one should not be derived from the other (Birner et al. 2007: 319). While the first view calls these structures “reduced” or “truncated clefts”, the second view refers to them as copular or, in the case of the ones introduced by *il y a*, existential sentences.

3.4.3 The contribution of this book

Determining the exact syntactic nature of these constructions is out of the scope of this book, as the present corpus study is mostly concerned with what these structure do from a functional perspective, and how they contribute to the universe of discourse. Nevertheless, for the purpose of the present investigation, I maintain the term “fragment” and “reduced cleft”, and I consider that, from a pragmatic perspective, both fragmental answers and reduced clefts are answering strategies where only the focused element is visible⁶, while the presupposition is implicitly shared by speaker and hearer in the CG. In other words, I do not take a position on whether, syntactically, a reduced cleft is originally a full cleft whose relative clause is elided. Rather, I employ the term reduced cleft to distinguish it from a full cleft because I consider that, communicatively, the presuppositional part of information has been reduced or elided by the speaker.

Irrespective of their syntactic nature, a corpus study that investigates the frequency of these strategies compared to other focus-marking strategies is needed, and that is one of the main objective of this book. Although the studies so far

⁶I follow Yoshida et al. (2013) and assume that, at least from a communicative perspective, focused material cannot undergo elision.

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conducted have made an extremely valuable contribution to the investigation of subject focus, it has to be recognized that a systematic corpus investigation that takes into account both full and elliptical answers would shed light on the phenomenon both from a language-internal and from a comparative perspective.

In light of what has been discussed above, the main goals of the present work are: i) to identify, through a corpus analysis, which answering strategies (both full and elliptical) are used in French and Spanish to express focused subjects, and to determine their distribution in spontaneous speech, (ii) to investigate the contexts and motivations that determine a speaker's decision to opt either for a full or an elliptical answer in both languages and, finally, (iii) to determine whether the factors such as focus type, activation of the subject constituent and argument structure of the verb have an impact on focus realization in both languages.

Part II

Empirical study

4 Frequency of subject focus-marking strategies

4.1 Introduction

In Chapter 2, I provided an overview of the different focus-marking strategies discussed so far in the literature for both Spanish and French. The comparison with functional approaches to subject focus has revealed that the theoretical assumptions proposed so far are only partly corroborated by empirical evidence, and that a more in-depth comparative investigation is needed.

Recent experimental studies have pointed out the importance of variation in the realisation of subject focus. Unlike theoretical studies, data-based research has shown that there is more than one means to mark subject focus, and that factors such as diatopic differences (Jiménez-Fernández 2015), register (Destruel 2016), argument structure of the verb (Gabriel 2007) or the information status of the subject referent (Karssenbergh 2018a,c) might have a considerable impact on the choice of focus-marking strategies.

As has often been pointed out in previous chapters, these contributions, while valuable, present some limitations. First, elicitation tasks, reading tasks, or acceptability judgements have the advantage of offering highly controlled settings and conditions, thereby increasing the comparability of results. However, these same methods reduce speakers' freedom and spontaneity of expression by prompting participants to produce full sentences in response to a visual or auditory stimulus. Consequently, structures such as various types of ellipses, fragments, or reduced clefts are often treated as “noise” and hence excluded from analysis. Nevertheless, these structures are quite frequent in spontaneous speech, and any exhaustive investigation of subject focus, or focus in general, needs to account for them as well.

Secondly, it is not yet clear whether different focus types (e.g., information focus vs. contrastive/corrective focus) map onto specific syntactic structures, or whether such a mapping can be observed at all. In other words, is there a one-to-one correspondence between contrast vs. information focus, and a specific

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construction (as the Cartographic Approach (Rizzi 1997) predicts, or are constructions under-specified with respect to their information-structural function? The corpus study reported in this chapter captures any structure produced by participants, including not only sentences that exhibit a clear focus-background partition, such as French subject clefts or Spanish postverbal subjects, but also syntactic structures where only the focused constituent is uttered while the background material is elided (e.g., fragments, reduced clefts). The study aims, on the one hand, to investigate the ways in which focused subjects can be expressed in the two languages (along with their respective frequencies) and, on the other hand, to identify possible correlations between focus types and specific syntactic structures.

Thus, the first research question has an exploratory nature. The sentences expressing subject focus are extracted and annotated according to their type. Here, “type” refers to the syntactic structure under which the pragmatic function is encoded. At this stage, I do not formulate any specific hypothesis or prediction about the possible strategies that speakers might use to convey focus on the subject in the two languages. Rather, the study explores all variants that might compete for the same information-structural function by adopting a Labovian variationist approach (Labov 1972). Additionally, it investigates whether any correlation can be observed between different focus types (information vs. contrast) and specific answering strategies. As will be shown, both Spanish and French speakers have at their disposal more than one option to encode subject focus, even though some strategies are more frequent than others. The French sub-corpus, for instance, exhibits an elevated number of different cleft formats, while postverbal subjects seem to be the preferred strategy in the Spanish dataset. Interestingly, a high number of elliptical structures can be observed in both sub-corpora. However, the distribution of these answer types varies considerably between the two languages.

This chapter is organized as follows: In section 3.2, I present the corpus used to conduct the present analysis. Sections 3.3 and 3.4 discuss the criteria adopted for the extraction and annotation of the sentences. Section 3.5 presents the findings of the Spanish corpus, while section 3.6 reports the results of the French corpus. Finally, sections 3.7 and 3.8 provide a comparative discussion for both languages and a summary of the chapter.

4.2 **Sgscorpus: General description**

The data used for the present study are part of the multilingual database *sgs* (speech production - grammaticality judgments - social data) (Adli 2011). The cor-

4.2 *Sgscorpus: General description*

pus contains spoken data in four different languages (French, Spanish, Persian and Catalan). It also includes transcription and tree-annotation of spoken language (including primary acoustic data), gradient acceptability judgments, and social structural information. The data was collected in the years 2004, 2005 and 2007.

The sample of speakers consists of mostly young or middle-aged adults. Each person was first recorded, then asked to participate in a gradient acceptability judgment test, and finally filled out an extensive social questionnaire.

The Spanish sub-corpus contains data from the Spanish variety spoken in Catalonia and was collected in Barcelona, while the data on French was collected in Paris. The empirical design was held constant between field sessions. Each linguistic production of the speaker is transcribed. This transcription facilitates readability, tree-annotation, and the application of the query tools. Being based on spontaneous speech, the *sgs* also contains elements such as hesitation markers, false starts, interjections, and repetitions.

The French part of *sgs* consists of 102 recorded interviews which contain 44,231 main lines, 51% of which are produced by 101 interviewees and 49% by the interviewers. Interviews were carried out in the summer of 2005 with French native speakers between the ages of 19 and 49 (mean age: 29). The sample is composed of 56% women and 44% men. With regard to the Spanish sub-corpus, the sample consists of 54 recorded interviews containing 10778 (52.7%) utterances produced by the interviewees and 9662 (47.3%) by other participants (interviewers or investigator). The sample of participants consists of 54 native speakers of the Spanish variety of Catalonia. 60% of the sample are women while the other 40% are men. Participants had completed at least compulsory education, and were between 17 and 48 years old (mean: 28 years). The present corpus study considers both the tokens produced by the interviewers and the ones produced by the interviewees.

Importantly, both the Spanish and the French corpus were collected using the same methodological protocol: a game task was developed, where subjects were instructed to investigate a fictive murder case. This procedure allows participants to choose which aspects of the case they want to talk about. A properly chosen fictive scenario brings subjects into the situation of asking the interviewer questions, while leaving them the freedom to choose the topics. In the scenario, the subject played the part of a police investigator, and the experimenter the doorman of the victim's building. To maintain spontaneity and authenticity, subjects were instructed to be themselves and not to imitate, for example, some commonly known literary figure.

This game task has the methodological advantage of eliciting a considerable number of question/answer pairs, which, as is well known, facilitates the inves-

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tigation of focus or, more generally, of different IS-functions. Moreover, the fact that the game task was kept constant for the two languages guarantees optimal conditions for comparability.

Despite the high comparability and the naturalness of the speech type, the corpus presents some methodological limitations as well. Being semi-directed interviews, speakers remain aware of the fact that the setting in which they have to interact is somewhat artificial and, most importantly, that they are being observed for linguistic purposes. As has often been pointed out in sociolinguistics, this prevents a fully-natural speech production (i.e., *the observer paradox*¹, see Labov 1972). Nevertheless, given that the interviewer poses no restrictions on the topics to be discussed or the linguistic forms to use, it is reasonable to claim that such interviews result in a close representation of spontaneous speech.

In the following sections, I discuss the criteria adopted for the extraction and the annotation of the critical sentences.

4.3 Criteria for the extraction

Any assertion expressing a focused subject has been identified and extracted. In line with previous approaches, I consider focus a discourse-structuring device that signals the presence of alternatives which are relevant for the interpretation of the linguistic expressions (Rooth 1992, Krifka 2008). In line with the Structured Meaning Approach (Von Stechow 1982, 1990, Jacobs 2012, Krifka 1992, 2008), I assume that focus leads to a partition of the sentence into a focus-background structure. To identify such partition (when possible), I adopt the QUD approach (Roberts 1996, Velleman & Beaver 2016, Riestler et al. 2018), according to which any assertion in a discourse corresponds to an implicit or explicit QUD. Being a dialogical corpus, the sgs contains a considerable number of explicit questions for both French and Spanish, which facilitate the identification of the partition of the sentence and, consequently, of the different focus types.

In the specific case of subject focus, I consider a critical item to be any assertion constituting an answer to an explicit or implicit QUD, where the (semantic or syntactic) subject represents the value chosen among an (open or closed) set of alternatives, that fills the wh-variable contained in the corresponding QUD. An example is provided in (1):

- (1) a. (Who ate beans?)

¹According to Labov “the aim of linguistic research in the community must be to find out how people talk when they are not being systematically observed; yet we can only obtain this data by systematic observation” (Labov 1972: 209).

4.3 Criteria for the extraction

- b. [Mary]_{FOC} ate beans. (Velleman & Beaver 2016: 7)

Following Hamblin (1973), the (implicit or explicit) QUD in (1)a can be interpreted as a set of propositions, each being the denotation of a congruent answer: $\{\text{ATE}(\text{BEANS})(x) \mid x \in \text{ENTITY}\}$. The utterance in (1)b, on the other hand, identifies one of these propositions and adds it to the CG content, stating that of all the possible alternative entities that could have eaten the beans, Mary did.

Such identification between the entity (x) and the corresponding proposition generally maps onto a subject-predicate syntactic structure, as is the case in (1)b or other focus-marking strategies (e.g., Spanish postverbal subjects). There are cases, however, where the mapping between focus on the subject and syntactic subject cannot be observed. A classic example is subject clefts in French. In a cleft, the constituent expressing the focused subject appears, in fact, as the right-hand complement of the copula and the predicate is contained within the relative clause. Pragmatically, however, both a postverbal subject in Spanish and a cleft in French correspond to an answer to a subject interrogative and express, therefore, a focus on the subject.

For instance, in a sentence like *C'est Pierre qui a volé le biscuit* 'It is Peter who stole the cookie', *Pierre* is, strictly speaking, not a syntactic subject but an attribute, while the position of the subject is occupied by a non-referential *c'*. This is also true for other focus-marking strategies that express the same pragmatic function, such as fragments, or *il y a* clefts, where the focused element constituting the pragmatic subject is in fact the direct object of the verb *avoir* 'to have'.

It has to be pointed out that both *c'est* and *il y a* clefts are generally considered grammaticalized constructions in the sense of Construction Grammar (for instance by Lambrecht 1994), where both the copula *être* 'to be' and the verb *avoir* 'to have' are, in fact, devoid of semantic content. For clefts of the *c'est* type, some authors have even suggested that the expletive pronoun *c'*, the copula and relative pronouns *qui/que* merely represent focalization morphemes (Wehr 2011: 197). Thus, for the extraction of the critical items, what is taken into account is the pragmatic function independent of the syntactic form in which it appears. Whether it is a syntactic subject or not, the item is considered if and only if it corresponds to an answer to a subject interrogative. This also implies that cases in which the subject is in the focus domain with other elements of the sentence, such as predicate focus and sentence focus (see Chapter 1), have been excluded from the extraction.

In (1), the focused subject is triggered by an explicit who-question (e.g., Who ate the beans?). This QUD, however, is not the only one that can license a subject focus. In spontaneous speech, it can also correspond to an answer to a yes-no

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question, an indirect question or simply an implicit one (see Chapter 4 for a detailed discussion on the question types found in the corpus). The diversity of the question types has precluded any automatic extraction of the data. Thus, the corpus has been manually screened and the items manually extracted. In total, 352 sentences were extracted for Spanish and 436 for French². Each sentence was extracted together with the explicit or implicit QUD it constitutes an answer to.

4.4 Criteria for the annotation

4.4.1 Annotating answer type

Among the 352 items extracted from the Spanish sub-corpus, I distinguished the following answer-types:

Postverbal subject: any subject appearing in postverbal position either sentence-finally or followed by another constituent that can be an adverb or another argument. This answer type receives the tag POSTVERBAL. The *sine qua non* condition is that the subject must express focus, and hence must constitute an answer to a subject interrogative. Therefore, subjects appearing in postverbal position, and not fulfilling this function (e.g., right-dislocated subjects or fronting of another constituent that forces the subject to a postverbal position, e.g., *eso creo yo* ‘that is what I believe’) have been excluded from the analysis. Unsurprisingly, no occurrences of French postverbal subjects have been found in the French dataset (see Chapter 2 for a discussion on these structures). An example of Spanish postverbal focused subject is provided in (2):

- (2) a. *Y, ¿Quién te atendió cuando subiste?*
 ‘And, who opened the door when you went upstairs?’
 b. *Me atendió [la fallecida]_{FOC}.*
 ‘The victim opened (the door).’ (sgs Spanish, 8/297-298)

In situ: similarly, any subject appearing in a preverbal position and expressing narrow focus receives the tag IN SITU. In this case too, the subject can appear either sentence-initially or can be preceded by an other element, such as an adverb, a discourse marker or a another argument. Since the

²The extracted items were initially 469. However, 33 of them were considered too ambiguous with respect to their IS-function, and have thus been excluded from the analysis.

4.4 Criteria for the annotation

SVO order in both Spanish and French is compatible with more than one information-structural partition, what determines the status of the subject as focus is obviously the preceding QUD. Examples of *in situ* focused subject are provided in (3) and (4) for Spanish and French, respectively:

(3) Spanish

- a. *Pero ¿Quién ha llamado a la policía?*
'But who called the police?'
- b. *[Yo]_{FOC} los he llamado.*
'I called them.' (sgs Spanish, 52/19-20)

(4) French

- a. *Il y a beaucoup de gens qui se connaissent dans cet immeuble?*
'A lot of people know each other in the building?'
- b. *Ouais, [tout le monde]_{FOC} se connaît.*
'Yes, everybody knows everybody.' (sgs French, 49/58-59)

Cleft: For Spanish, the tag CLEFT is used to annotate any bi-clausal structure where the focused subject is introduced either by a copula *ser* 'to be' or the verb *haber* 'to have' (both may vary in tense, mood, aspect, person and number), a nominal head (e.g., *la única persona* 'the only person') or a wh-element, (e.g., *quien* 'who'), and is followed by a relative clause, which pragmatically represents background information.

For French, the same label has been used for any bi-causal construction where the focused subject is introduced either by a copula, e.g., *C'est* 'to be' or by the verb *avoir* 'to have' e.g., *Il y a* (both may vary in tense, aspect, mood, person or number), and is followed or preceded (as in the case of pseudo clefts, see Chapter 2) by a non-restrictive relative clause. Importantly, I assume that any cleft construction corresponds to a canonical counterpart that may be used to describe the same situation. Thus, cases that do not meet these criteria do not fall under this label.³

Additionally, only the cleft types where it is possible to observe a clear-cut focus background partition have been included in this category. That means that the cleft sentences exhibiting an all-focus interpretation have

³For instance, syntactic constructions that look like clefts on the surface, but do not meet the requirements to be clefts, e.g., due to the presence of a restrictive relative clause or the impossibility of declefting (i.e., "cleft lookalikes", see Karssenberg 2017).

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been excluded from the analysis. For the present research question, I do not differentiate among different cleft types. The question of the correlation between cleft types and focus types will be dealt with in Chapter 5. Examples of critical items tagged as CLEFT are provided in (5) and (6):

(5) Spanish

- a. *¿La has encontrado tú?*
'But was it you who found her?'
- a. *¿Has entrado al piso?*
'Did you entered the apartment?'
- b. *Sí, he sido [yo]_{FOC} quien la ha encontrado muerta.*
'Yes, it was me who found her dead.' (sgs Spanish, 16/21-23)

(6) French

- a. *Qui c'est qui a découvert le corps en fait?*
'Who found the body in fact?'
- b. *C'est [sa femme]_{FOC} qui a découvert le corps.*
'It's his wife who found the body.' (sgs French, 7/99-100)

Reduced cleft: the tag REDUCED CLEFT has been employed for any focused subject introduced by either a copula (*ser* for Spanish and *être* for French) or the verb 'to have' (*haber* for Spanish and *avoir* for French). Here too, both the copula and the verb 'to have' may vary in tense, mood, person or number.

As already discussed in Chapter 2, I remain agnostic on whether these structures are in fact a syntactic reduction of a full cleft (the "reduction hypothesis", see [Jenkins 1973](#)) or if, on the contrary, they constitute a fully-fledged syntactic structure on their own. I assume, nevertheless, that from a communicative perspective, focused material cannot undergo elision ([Yoshida et al. 2013](#)). Therefore, in the case of reduced clefts, the background material is implicitly shared by both speaker and hearer (i.e., already present in the CG), while only the focused subject contained in the clefted element is explicitly uttered. Examples are provided in (7) and (8):

(7) Spanish

- a. *¿Eres tú quien nos ha llamado?*
'Are you the one who called?'

4.4 Criteria for the annotation

- b. *Sí, he sido* [*yo*]_{FOC}.
 ‘Yes, it was me.’ (sgs Spanish, 17/12-13)

(8) French

- a. *Qui est-ce qui a appelé la police?*
 ‘Who called the police?’
 b. *Ben, c’est* [*moi*]_{FOC}.
 ‘Well, it’s me.’ (sgs French, 20/92-93)

Fragment fragments are generally considered a subset of elliptical sentences (Merchant 2005), that may include one or more constituents. Here again, there is debate on whether a fragment is a fully-fledged syntactic structure or rather an incomplete sentence that has been reduced for discourse-related reasons. As already mentioned in Chapter 2, some authors consider these structures as covertly clausal and elliptical (Merchant 2005), while others claim that fragments are in fact base-generated constituents (Stainton 1998, Ginzburg & Sag 2000, Jacobson 2016).

Similarly to the case of reduced clefts, I remain agnostic with regard to the debate on the syntactic nature of fragmental answers. I consider, nevertheless, that these answer types are pragmatically elliptical sentences, where the focused constituent has “survived”, while the background proposition has been omitted by the speaker, and is implicitly shared between interlocutors in the CG content. For this type of answer, I use the tag FRAGMENT, such as in (9) and (10):

(9) ES:

- a. *¿Quién gritaba?*
 ‘Who was screaming?’
 b. [*La chiquilla*]_{FOC}.
 ‘The little girl.’ (sgs Spanish, 17/346-347)

(10) French

- a. *Qui vous a prévenu qu’un meurtre s’était passé?*
 ‘Who told you that there had been a murder?’
 b. *Donc, [la femme du monsieur]*_{FOC}.
 ‘So, the man’s wife.’ (sgs French, 8/31-32)

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Dislocation the tag DISLOCATION has been used to annotate those constructions where the subject is in the left periphery of the sentence, and resumed by a clitic pronoun in the core sentence. The *sine qua non* condition is, once again, the fact that the dislocated subject must be the part of the sentence that constitutes the answer to the wh-variable contained in the QUD, while the rest of the sentence is background information. No cases of dislocations with a focused subject have been found for Spanish. An example for French is provided in (11):

- (11) a. *Et, qui a entendu le coup de feu?*
 ‘And, who heard the shot?’
 b. [*Moi*]_{FOC}, *je l’ai entendu.*
 ‘I heard it.’
- (sgs French, 31/85-86)

4.4.2 Annotating focus types

Given the amount of variation in the terminology used by different linguists, it is necessary to clarify and motivate the notions and terms that will turn out to be useful for the purpose of this book. As it has been often mentioned, I will delimit the investigation exclusively to different types of narrow focus on the subject, thus excluding the cases where the subject is embedded in a larger focus domain (e.g., predicate or sentence focus).

For the purpose of the corpus study reported in this chapter, I adopt primarily the differentiation advocated in Krifka (2008) between two macro-categories of focus types: **information** and **contrastive** focus. I consider that information focus expresses the most important part of the utterance, or what is new information in relation to the utterance.⁴ At this point, I do not differentiate between an exhaustive and non-exhaustive interpretation of the focused element à la Kiss (1998), and I label both cases as INFORMATION. The question of exhaustivity and its influence in sentence form will be dealt with in Chapter 5. Examples for both languages are provided in (12) and (13):

Information Focus

- (12) Spanish

⁴Importantly, a referent can be discourse-old, or given, but still be new information in relation to the proposition it refers to; See Gundel & Fretheim (2004) for the difference between referential and relational givenness).

4.4 Criteria for the annotation

- a. *Y, ¿A quién viste subir?*
'And who did you see going upstairs?'
- b. *Bueno, es que yo salí a tirar las basuras de los vecinos.*
'Well, the fact is that I went out to throw the neighbors' garbage.'
- b. *Y en ese momento subió [el señor Rodríguez con un hombre]_{FOC}.*
'And, in that moment, mr. Rodríguez went upstairs with a man.' (sgs Spanish, 13/31-33)

(13) French

- a. *En fait, il y avait qui dans l'immeuble quand ça s'est passé?*
'So, who was in the building when all this happened?'
- b. *Alors, en fait, il y avait [la grand-mère du dessus]_{FOC} qui était là.*
'So, there was the old lady from upstairs that was there.' (sgs French, 9/261-262)

Moreover, I reserve the term contrastive focus for those cases where the focused subject is selected among a set of explicitly-mentioned alternatives, or when it replaces the variable already contained in the previous utterance. This implies that both the case of selection among a closed set of alternatives (Chafe 1976) and the case of correction (Van Leusen 2004, Steube 2001, Gussenhoven 2008, Repp 2010, Riester & Baumann 2013, Lahousse & Borremans 2014) are here conflated under the same category. This focus type is labeled as CONTRAST⁵.

Contrastive focus

(14) Spanish

- a. *¿Tú has llamado a la policía o?*
'Was it you who called the police?'
- b. *Sí, bueno hemos llamado [los dos]_{FOC} a la policía.*
'Yes, well, actually we both called the police.' (sgs Spanish, 8/51-52)

(15) French

- a. *Est-ce que c'est toi qui l'as découvert ou?*
'Is it you who found him?'

⁵This classification is slightly different from the one advocated in Krifka (2008), where cases of selection are not considered instances of contrast. Rather, the author prefers the term 'open' and 'closed' focus to distinguish among cases where the focused element is chosen among a set of either unmentioned or explicitly-mentioned alternatives, respectively (see discussion in Chapter 1).

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- b. *Non, c'est [sa femme]_{FOC} qui l'a découvert.*
 'No, it's his wife who found him.' (sgs French, 8/51-52)

This choice of focus type is motivated by various reasons. First, the distinction between *neutral* (information) and *non-neutral/marked* (contrastive) focus has commonly been assumed to affect the most syntactic variation within the Romance language family (Escandell-Vidal & Leonetti 2019, Cruschina 2021). As explained in Chapter 2, it is often claimed that contrastive foci licence certain word orders that would be judged infelicitous if they were to express information focus. A classic example is that of fronted foci in Spanish or Italian, where the common locus for focus is the postverbal slot of the sentence. Conversely, if a focused constituent appears preverbally, it is almost always assumed to bear a contrastive (or corrective) interpretation and a specific prosodic contour (e.g., Benincà 1988, Bianchi 2013, Escandell-Vidal & Leonetti 2019; *inter alia*).

As has been often stressed in Chapter 2, however, there is no consensus in the literature on the question of specific focus types and syntactic position or syntactic construction. For some authors, information focus can also appear *in situ*, while contrast can also appear postverbally (e.g., Gabriel 2007). Thus, the question of the mapping between form and function remains debatable. Furthermore, it is not clear whether elliptical syntactic structures, such as fragments or reduced clefts, can also express contrast, and, if yes, with what frequency. Given the lack of empirical investigation of these structures in French and Spanish, this question has remained unanswered so far. This is why the information vs. contrastive distinction employed in this chapter is necessary to confirm or reject considerations regarding the mapping of focus type onto syntactic form that have been pointed out so far for French and Spanish, and to explore possible IS-functions of other structures, including elliptical ones. Table 1 shows each focus type with its definition.

Note that exhaustivity implies the exclusion of alternatives as well. However, for the purpose of my study, I differentiate between the case in which the set of alternatives is open (information focus) and the case in which it is closed (contrastive). In a closed set, the alternatives can either be explicitly mentioned by the speaker or deduced by world knowledge. For instance, asking a question such as *who scored?* in the context of a football match implies that there are 11 possible alternatives.

4.5 Corpus results for Spanish

Table 4.1: Focus types investigated

Information focus	Contrastive focus
The term indicates the non-presuppositional nature of the information, performing either exhaustive or non-exhaustive identification of a set of entities.	The term indicates exclusion of other explicit or implicit alternatives, either by selection or correction.
Tag: INFORMATION	Tag: CONTRAST

4.5 Corpus results for Spanish

In this section, I report the results from the Spanish sub-corpus. I present at first the frequencies of all instances of narrow focus on the subject, without differentiating among different focus types (information vs. contrast). I then discuss every answer type with respect to its relative frequency and its correlation with different types of focus.

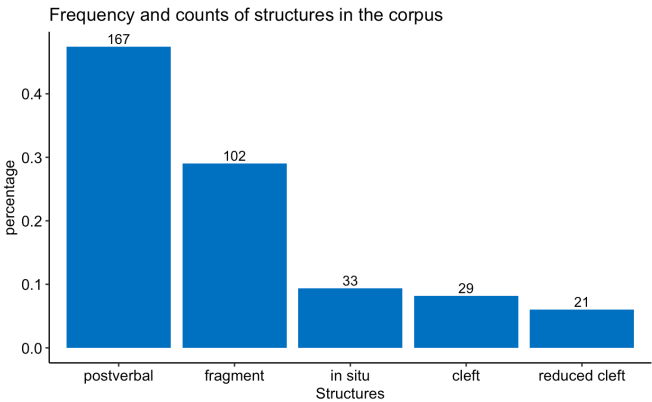


Figure 4.1: Frequency of answer types in Spanish

As Figure 1 shows, Spanish speakers produced a total of 352 subject foci. Among the 352 critical items, 48% (N= 167) are postverbal subjects, 29% (N= 102) are fragment answers, 9% (N= 33) are *in situ* subjects, 8% (N=29) are clefts and 6% (N=21) are reduced clefts. According to this data set, thus, the most frequent means to

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express focused subjects is the VS order. The corpus nonetheless shows variation in the type of answer. Speakers produced both full and elliptical structures with different distributions.

A Chi-square goodness-of-fit test was conducted to examine whether the distribution of structures differed from uniform. The result was highly significant, $\chi^2(4, N = 352) = 365.15, p < 2.2 \times 10^{-16}$, indicating that some structures occurred much more frequently than others. Post-hoc pairwise comparisons (Bonferroni-corrected) showed that postverbal and fragment structures were significantly more frequent than *in situ*, cleft, and reduced cleft constructions (all $p < .001$). There were no significant differences among *in situ*, cleft, and reduced cleft structures (all $p = 1$). These results demonstrate that postverbal and fragment constructions dominate the distribution, while cleft and reduced cleft constructions are rare.

The results for the overall frequency of the different focus types are presented in Table 2. The table shows the counts for the two focus types in the Spanish corpus, without breaking them into specific answering strategies.

Table 4.2: Distribution of focus types

Focus Type	Counts
Contrast	38
Information	314

As can be seen from the table, among the 352 subject foci, 90% (N=314) are information foci and only 10% (N=38) contrastive foci. Overall, information focus appears to be the focus type most frequently produced. This result is in line with the literature on focus, according to which contrast is, by definition, a more marked IS-function than conveying new information (Zimmermann 2008, Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010).

Table 3 reports the results for the relationship between different focus types and different answer types.

Among the 167 postverbal subjects, 155 (92%) are information foci, while 8% (n=12) are contrastive. Of the 102 fragments, 92 (91%) are information and 9% (n=10) are contrastive foci. Among the 33 *in situ* subjects, 23 (70%) express new information and 10 (30%) contrast. Through the 29 clefts, speakers conveyed 26 information (90%) and only 3 (10%) contrastive foci. Finally, among the 21 reduced clefts, 18 (86%) are information focus and 3 (14%) are contrastive.

4.5 Corpus results for Spanish

Table 4.3: Distribution of focus types by focus structure.

	Contrast	Information
cleft	3	26
fragment	10	92
in situ	10	23
postverbal	12	155
reduced cleft	3	18

A Fisher’s exact test was conducted to examine whether the proportion of contrastive versus informational focus differed across structures. The result was significant, $p = 0.001$, indicating that focus type depends on syntactic structure. Inspection of the data shows that *in situ* structures have the highest proportion of contrastive focus, whereas postverbal and fragment structures predominantly carry informational focus. Cleft and reduced cleft structures show small counts for contrastive focus, making the differences less reliable. These results suggest that *in situ* structures are particularly likely to convey contrastive focus.

4.5.1 Discussion

4.5.1.1 Overview

The corpus investigation revealed that the most frequent way to encode narrow focus on the subject in Spanish is by means of subject-verb inversion or postverbal subjects. This finding is in line with what the formal approaches to focus in Spanish have proposed so far (e.g., [Zubizarreta 1998](#), [Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006](#), a.o., see Chapter 2). Diverging from these views, however, the data shows that postverbal subjects are by no means the only way to encode subject focus, and that the same function can be expressed by other strategies. For instance, speakers produced a considerable number of fragment answers and, albeit with a lower frequency, *in situ* subjects, clefts and reduced clefts, thus confirming that there is variation in the expression of focused subjects.

At the level of the type of focus, it is possible to observe that the information type was produced with greater frequency compared to the contrastive/corrective type. As mentioned above, this is also in line with previous literature that assumes a scale of markedness of pragmatic functions, where expressing contrast is considered to be a costlier operation than simply conveying non-presuppositional information ([Zimmermann 2008](#), [Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010](#)).

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Based on these results, it is also possible to rule out the assumption of a one-to-one correlation between form and function (i.e., between focus type and syntactic structure), as all the strategies encode both focus types. A direct relationship between a specific type of focus and a single marking strategy is therefore excluded. However, some variation can be observed in the frequency with which different strategies encode various focus types. For instance, while some structures (e.g., fragments or postverbal subjects) rarely encode contrast, others (e.g., *in situ* subjects) fulfil this function more frequently. This suggests that while no strategy is exclusively tied to a single focus type, certain constructions show a stronger preference for encoding particular focus functions.

4.5.1.2 Postverbal subjects

Postverbal subjects are the most frequent means used to express focused subjects in the Spanish data set. This is in line with formal accounts on focus that assume that among the subject NPs, it is possible to find all kinds of referring expressions: pronouns, proper names, definite and indefinite NPs and (negative) quantifiers. The focused subject can be found in sentence-final position (*Llegó [la policía]_{FOC}* ‘The police came’) or can be followed by another constituent (*Sí, bueno hemos llamado [los dos]_{FOC} a la policía* ‘Yes, well, we both called the police’).

In Chapter 5, I report the result of a study where factors such as verb type, exhaustivity and givenness of the subject constituent are tested in relation with postverbal vs. preverbal subjects. I show that postverbal subjects correlate mostly with new subjects of unaccusative verbs, a result which is once again in line with previous literature on these structures (see, for instance, [Burzio 1986](#), on the association between unaccusatives and the VS order). Although all other answer types show a similar picture, postverbal subjects are the strategy that is most strongly associated with information focus (92%), and exhibit the lowest rate of contrastive foci (8%). It is interesting to note, though, that the same position can express different pragmatic inferences of focus; a finding that sharply contrasts with formal theories that assume two different syntactic positions for different focus types (see, for instance, the Cartographic Approach; see [Rizzi 1997](#)).

Among the few cases of contrastive foci, it is possible to identify both occurrences of correction and, even if marginally, selection. Consider the two examples below:

- (16) **Correction:** (Speaking about the corpse)
- a. *Pues, esta mañana lo han encontrado.*
‘Well, they found him this morning.’

4.5 Corpus results for Spanish

- a. *Bueno, lo ha encontrado [su mujer]_{FOC}.*
 ‘Well, his wife found him.’ (sgs Spanish, 7/8-9)

(17) Selection:

- a. *¿Han bajado los dos?*
 ‘Did they both come downstairs?’
 b. *Bueno, ha bajado [el marido]_{FOC} porque la mujer estaba arriba.*
 ‘Well, the husband came down because the wife stayed upstairs.’ (sgs Spanish, 17/45-46)

In (16), the same speaker corrects himself/herself by using a postverbal subject, while in (17), speaker A gives a closed set of possible alternatives, and speaker B selects one of them. Thus, contrast, as well as information, can both be expressed by the same subject position. It remains to be assessed whether any difference can be observed in the prosodic contour of each function. However, such an analysis is out of the scope of this book.

4.5.1.3 Fragments

Spanish speakers produced a total of 102 fragment answers. It is worth noting that the second-most frequent strategy is an elliptical one (102/352); this is evidence of the fact that these answer types are far from being uncommon in spontaneous speech. The fragments produced in Spanish are almost exclusively full noun phrases. The corpus revealed a total of 99 NPs and only 3 personal pronouns among the 102.

- (18) a. *Y, ¿Qué vecino encontró a la chica?*
 ‘And, which neighbour found the girl?’
 b. *Pues, [su compañera de piso]_{FOC}.*
 ‘So, her flatmate.’ (sgs Spanish, 25/46-47)

As for the type of focus expressed, in this case again, it is possible to observe an almost exclusive association with information focus (92/102), while contrast is expressed only marginally (10/102). This result is not surprising *per se*. An assertion containing a corrective focus has the communicative function of replacing the old value with a new one (see Gussenhoven 2008). To express such a function, speakers generally tend to express more rather than less material, and to resort to marked syntactic or prosodic configurations (Zimmermann 2008). Thus, fragments are felicitous strategies when expressing new information, but rarely found in corrective/contrastive contexts. Additionally, the 10 cases of correction

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found in the Spanish data set almost never appear alone, but are generally accompanied by negative polarity items (e.g., *No, la señora de arriba* ‘No, the lady from upstairs’) or by discourse markers, such as *bueno* ‘well’.

4.5.1.4 *In situ* subjects

The Spanish corpus also contains a limited number of focused preverbal subjects or focus *in situ* (n=33), where the subject appears either right at the beginning of the utterance or following DMs or negative polarity items. Unlike fragments, here it is possible to find a majority of NPs with a high referential level, such as personal pronouns or proper names; some definite NPs can also be found, while indefinites seem to be rather scarce (3 out of 33). Although there is once again a stronger association with information focus, it is possible to see that the association with contrast seems to be more frequent than in the other answer types. This finding is in line with previous research both at the level of contrast and at the level of information. On the one hand, in fact, theoretical approaches to focus (e.g., Zubizarreta 1998) argue that focused *in situ* subjects are found solely when they express contrast rather than information⁶. On the other hand, Gabriel (2007) has argued in favour of the possibility of information focus to be expressed only prosodically, without involving movement of the constituents (see Chapter 2). As reported in Chapter 2, in Gabriel’s experiment (2007), *in situ* focus is preferred with transitive verbs containing a fully-realised object NP. The author provides an explanation in terms of cost of operations, arguing that it is easier for speakers to leave the subject in its *in situ*-position, and signal focus by a higher prosodic contour, rather than by moving the full object NP to a preverbal position, and producing a marked syntactic configuration.

However, when the *in situ* subjects expressing contrastive focus (10/33) are excluded, only 6 out of 23 items fulfil this condition, i.e., only 6 sentences have a transitive verb with a fully-realised object NP (e.g., *Sí, [la familia]_{FOC} denunció la desaparición* ‘Yes, the family signaled her disappearance’). The remaining tokens contain (di)transitive verbs with an object clitic (e.g., *Sí, [ella]_{FOC} me ha avisado* ‘Yes, she warned me’) or are accompanied by mono-argumental verbs (e.g., *Pues, [su mujer]_{FOC} llegó.* ‘So, his wife arrived’).

According to the literature, *in situ* subjects should bear prosodic prominence as the iconic means to signal to the hearer that that particular constituent is the value satisfying his/her request for information, while the rest of the sentence is

⁶Even though the results reported here suggest that this claim should be expressed in terms of probabilistic frequencies rather than deterministic truths

4.5 Corpus results for Spanish

de-accented (e.g., Féry 2001). As mentioned above, a prosodic analysis of these items is outside the scope of this book. However, *in situ* subjects will be analysed quantitatively in Chapter 5, where I investigate the semantic and pragmatic factors that trigger these structures, and compare them to postverbal subjects.

4.5.1.5 Clefts

A reduced number of focused subjects is also expressed by clefts (n=29). Among the cleft types in the corpus, it is possible to find some formats introduced by the copula *ser* ‘to be’ (e.g., *Pues, fueron [los padres]_{FOC} que la vieron por última vez* ‘So, it was the parents that saw her for the last time’) or the verb *haber* ‘to have’ (e.g., *Si, de hecho hay [un par de hombres]_{FOC} que vienen siempre* ‘Yes, actually, there are a couple of men that always pass by’), a wh-element (e.g., *Quien la visita son [sus nietos]_{FOC}* ‘Who visits her are his grandchildren’), and followed (or preceded) by a relative clause. Among the focused subjects contained in the clefted element it is possible to find a majority of definite NPs (n=27), only 1 pronoun and 1 indefinite. Interestingly, the corpus also contains a limited number of inverted pseudo-clefts (terminology adopted by Feldhausen & Vanrell 2015), where the clefted element precedes the copula (e.g., *[Ella]_{FOC} ha sido la que se ha encontrado el cuerpo* ‘It was her who found the body’).

As mentioned in Chapter 2, while the clefted constituent is generally considered to be the contrastively-focused element in Spanish (see, e.g., Zubizarreta 1999, Van Valin 2005), Cabrera (1999) and Feldhausen & Vanrell (2015) state that simple clefts on the one hand and (inverted) pseudo-clefts on the other hand have different information-structural properties. The results issued from the Spanish dataset seems to corroborate this finding, showing that 26 out of 29 clefts express information focus, while only 3 express contrast. This supports the claim that contrast/correction is only one of the possible information-structural functions associated with Spanish clefts, and that these structures can also be used to convey new information, albeit with a limited frequency.

4.5.1.6 Reduced clefts

Reduced clefts are the least frequent means of marking focus in the Spanish corpus (n=21). They are introduced mainly by a copula (e.g. *Pues, ha sido [su compañera de piso]_{FOC}* ‘So, it was her flatmate’), although some can be found with the verb ‘to have’ (e.g., *Pues, habían, como yo calculo, que [unas 8 personas]_{FOC} o por ahí* ‘So, there were some 8 people or something like that’). The sentences could be either main clauses or embedded ones (e.g., *Sabemos que fue [el lampista]_{FOC}*

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‘We know that it was the plumber’). It is possible to find any kind of NPs associated with reduced clefts, although the most common collocations are definite NPs with *ser* and indefinites with *haber*. As for the association of these structures with focus type, reduced clefts almost exclusively appear with information focus, with only 3 tokens expressing contrast. Overall, it seems that contrast is only marginally expressed by all structures, especially elliptical ones.

4.6 Corpus results for French

In this section, I report the results for the French focused subjects found in the corpus. As was the case for the Spanish corpus, I first present all the answer types that encode narrow focus on the subject, without differentiating among different focus types. I then show the results for the overall distribution of the two focus types, and I finally look at the interaction between different answer types and different focus types.

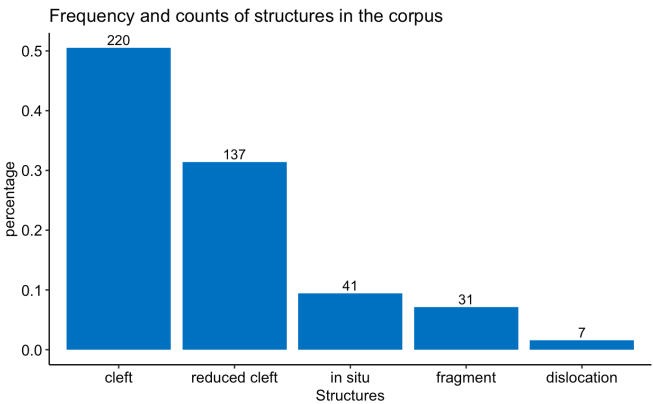


Figure 4.2: Frequency of answer types for French

Figure 2 shows that French speakers produced a total of 436 subject foci. Among the 436 sentences, 50% (N=220) are clefts, 31% (N=137) are reduced clefts, 9% (N=41) are *in situ* subjects, 7% (N=31) are fragment answers and only 3% (N=7) are dislocations.

The overall distribution of structures differed significantly from chance, $\chi^2(4, N = 436) = 365.15, p < .001$. Post-hoc pairwise comparisons (Bonferroni-corrected) revealed that clefts occurred significantly more often than reduced clefts, *in situ* constructions, fragments, and dislocations (all $p < .001$). Reduced clefts were also significantly less frequent than clefts, fragments, and dislocations (all $p < .001$).

4.6 Corpus results for French

and *in situ* constructions occurred at a similar rate as fragments ($p = 1.00$). All other pairwise comparisons were significant ($p \leq .001$), indicating that most structures differed in frequency from each other.

As mentioned previously, theoretical studies on French focus have often advanced the claim that *c'est* clefts are the most common (and, for some authors, the only) means to focus the subject. The results reported in this section show that subjects are indeed mainly focalized through cleft sentences. It is important to note, however, that I do not differentiate at this stage among different cleft formats. This implies that the label CLEFT includes cases of *c'est*, *il y a* and pseudo clefts. Importantly, the French dataset also shows that focused subjects can be expressed by other means, including both full and elliptical strategies. As was the case for the Spanish sub-corpus, French speakers produced 5 different answering strategies with varying frequency. Some of these strategies overlap with the strategies that Spanish speakers produced (e.g., clefts, fragments, *in situ*, reduced clefts), while dislocations are found only in the French data.

Table 4 shows that French speakers produced 85% (N=370) information foci and 15% (N=66) contrastive foci. This result is somewhat similar to the Spanish one, reported in Table 2, where information focus is by far the most frequent type, while only a limited number of contrastively-focused subjects can be observed. Table 5 shows the proportion of different focus types for each answering strategy.

Table 4.4: Distribution of focus types

Focus Type	Count
Contrast	66
Information	370

Table 4.5: Distribution of focus types by focus structure

	contrast	information
cleft	46	174
reduced cleft	7	130
in situ	10	31
fragment	1	30
dislocation	2	5

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Every strategy reported in Table 5 exhibits more instances with information focus, compared to contrastive focus. Among the 220 clefts, it is possible to find 78% (n=174) information foci and 22% (n=46) contrastive ones. Among the 137 reduced clefts, 97% (n=130) are information and only 3% (n=7) are contrastive foci. Among the 41 *in situ* foci, 76% (n=31) are associated with information and 24% (n=10) with contrast. Among the 31 fragments, almost all (97%, n=30) are information foci and only 3% (n=1) are contrastive. Finally, among the 7 dislocations produced, 71% (n=5) express information and 29% (n=2) express contrast.

Post-hoc pairwise comparisons (Bonferroni-corrected) were conducted to examine which structures differed in their distribution of focus types. The results showed that clefts differed significantly from all other structures (reduced clefts, *in situ* constructions, fragments, dislocations; $p < .001$), and reduced clefts differed significantly from clefts, fragments, and dislocations ($p < .001$). *In situ* constructions and fragments did not differ significantly from each other ($p = 1.00$), indicating similar distributions of contrastive and informational focus. All other pairwise comparisons were significant ($p \leq .01$), demonstrating that the choice of structure certainly affects the type of focus realized.

4.6.1 Discussion

4.6.1.1 Overview

The first exploratory corpus study revealed that the most frequent means to encode subject focus in French is through a cleft sentence. As is the case for the Spanish results, this finding seems to be in line with what theoretical linguists have argued with respect to subject focus and its realization. However, here again, it is possible to observe a certain degree of variation in the different focus-marking strategies. French speakers also produced a considerable number of reduced clefts and, to a lesser extent, other strategies, such as *in situ* focus, fragment answers and dislocations.

As for the focus types, the overall distribution shows that the majority of answers produced express information focus, with only a small percentage expressing contrast. The results for French, thus, seem to follow the same pattern observed for Spanish, where the degree of markedness of focus types is also reflected in the frequency through which it is produced by speakers. I will now discuss the different answer types individually.

4.6 Corpus results for French

4.6.1.2 Clefts

Half of the answers types produced by speakers (N=220) were subject cleft sentences. As mentioned above, the cleft category reported in Figure 4 does not differentiate among different cleft types. A closer look reveals that the corpus contains 109 *c'est* clefts (e.g. *C'est [sa femme]_{FOC} qui l'a trouvé* 'It's his wife who found him'), 98 *il y a* clefts (e.g., *Il y a [une autre étudiante]_{FOC} qui vit dans l'immeuble* 'There is another student that lives in the building') and 13 pseudo clefts (e.g., *Ce qui m'intéresse bien c'est [son mari]_{FOC}* 'What interests me the most is her husband').

Thus, not only *c'est*, but also other cleft formats can encode subject focus in French; this is a finding that contradicts claims found mainly in the theoretical tradition (e.g., Lambrecht 1994). The fact that a considerable number of *il y a* clefts, for instance, expresses narrow focus on the subject seems to confirm Karssenbergs' (2017) corpus study, in which the author shows that *il y a* clefts do not necessarily exhibit an all-new focus type. Here again, there is a strong association with information focus, with a limited number of clefts expressing contrast. Lambrecht (1994) claims that pragmatic inferences like contrast can only be expressed by *c'est* clefts. A closer look at the different cleft types reveals that a small number of *il y a* clefts is also associated with contrast (N=9). However, none of them expresses correction *stricto sensu*, but rather selection from a set of closed alternatives (as in (19)). In contrast, all cases of correction are indeed expressed by *c'est* clefts.

- (19) a. *Et, au niveau de cet étage, les locataires sont là?*
 'And, speaking about this floor, are the neighbors there?'
 a. *Ou ils sont en vacances?*
 'Or are they on holidays?'
 b. *Il y en a [deux]_{FOC} en vacances et [un]_{FOC} qui est encore là.*
 'So, there are two on holidays and the one that is still there.' (sgs
 French, 7/182-184)

It must be noted that the answer contained in (19) is ambiguous between a contrastive focus and a contrastive topic reading. The difference between contrastive focus and contrastive topic is subtle but central in the study of information structure.

Contrastive focus identifies an element that contrasts with other possible alternatives in the discourse. It answers a wh-question or corrects a presupposition. A constituent marked as contrastive topic, on the other hand, introduces a topic-comment partition where the topic is contrasted with alternative topics (e.g., A:

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What about Paul and Marie? What did they buy? B: Well, [PAUL]_{CT} bought the wine, and [MARIE]_{CT} bought the cheese). It signals that the speaker will provide partial answers across alternatives, often leaving the door open to further elaboration (Krifka 2008).

The example in (19) is ambiguous because the speaker does not explicitly formulate a *wh*-question about the subject, such as *Who is currently in the building?*. Consequently, the yes/no question in (56a) could be interpreted either as *Which neighbour is in the building?* (i.e., contrastive focus) or as *What are the neighbours doing?* (i.e., contrastive topic). Given the contextual setting of the interview, in which participants are asked to solve a murder case, I assume that the communicative intention of the speaker was to determine which neighbour is present on each floor in order to narrow down the pool of potential culprits. For this reason, I analyze the sentence in (56b) as an instance of contrastive focus.

Concerning the NP types associated with each cleft type, there is a strong tendency towards the following collocations: pronouns and definite NPs with *c'est* clefts, indefinite NPs with *il y a* clefts and heavy NPs with pseudo clefts. The question of the interaction between cleft type and other factors, such as NP type or verb type will be discussed in detail in Chapter 5.

4.6.1.3 Reduced clefts

French speakers also produced a considerable number of reduced clefts (n=137). As was the case for the Spanish data set, it is interesting to note that the second most frequent strategy is an elliptical one; this is further evidence in support of the claim that these structures are far from being uncommon in spontaneous speech.

The corpus shows two types of reduced clefts: 77 reduced *c'est* (e.g., *C'est [moi]_{FOC}* 'It's me') and 60 of the *il y a* type (e.g., *Il y a [un homme]_{FOC} aussi* 'There is also a man'). Interestingly, a closer look at the association between the two types of reduced clefts and the NP type contained in the clefted element reveals a similar pattern to the one found for full clefts: a majority of pronouns, proper names and definite NPs occur with the *c'est* type, while a majority of indefinite NPs collocate with *il y a* reduced clefts.

Similar to the other strategies, reduced clefts express contrast in only a very limited number of cases, and have an almost total association with information focus.

It is interesting to note that some items annotated as reduced clefts in French contain the start of a relative clause that is, however, incomplete (i.e., "Trailing off", e.g., *Non, ça doit être [les flics]_{FOC} qui ont...* 'No, it must be the cops that

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have...'). These cases might be taken as evidence for the reduction hypothesis (Jenkins 1973), if one assumes that the speaker had the intention to produce a full cleft but, for discourse-related reasons, left the sentence incomplete. Nevertheless, this phenomenon does not occur regularly, and the number of cases is not large enough to provide this kind of generalizations.

4.6.1.4 *In situ*

Some *in situ* strategies have also been used to express subject focus (n=41). It is remarkable to observe that the majority of *in situ* focused subjects are quantifiers such as *tout le monde* 'everybody' or negative quantifiers, such as *personne* 'nobody'. Some personal pronouns, proper names and definite NPs are also present, while not a single case of indefinite NP has been found.

The presence of *in situ* foci in this dataset goes against the claim that French completely bans foci from the preverbal position (Lambrecht 2001: 492) because of its prosodic peculiarities (phrase-final stress instead of word stress). Rather, it is in line with Féry (2001), who found robust experimental evidence in favor of the existence of preverbal foci in French. The corpus shows that these strategies are not very frequent, but that they can combine with both information and, to a lesser extent, with contrastive focus. A closer look at the contrastive cases reveals that the *in situ* strategy can be used to express both selection (as in 20) and correction (as in 21):

- (20) a. *Donc dispute violente?*
 'So, was it a violent fight?'
 b. *Ouais, carrément.*
 'She, totally.'
 a. *Qui insultait qui?*
 'Who was insulting whom?'
 b. *[Elle]_{FOC} insultait [lui]_{FOC}.*⁷
 'She insulted him.' (sgs French, 93/190-193)
- (21) a. *On l'a retrouvé où?*
 'Where was he found?'

⁷It has to be pointed out that this is an interesting case of double focus: apart from focus on the subject, the same utterance also contains focus on the object. In this case, the SVO order could be an artifact of this phenomenon. However, other occurrences of *in situ* subjects can be found in association with selection.

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- b. *On l'a retrouvé chez elle.*
'He was found at her place.'
 - a. *m.*
'm.'
 - b. [*Je*]_{FOC} *l'ai retrouvé.*
'I found him.'
- (sgs French, 63/93-96)

As is the case for the Spanish *in situ* subjects, a prosodic analysis would reveal further insights into these strategies, especially in the case of correction, where a higher pitch tone is expected on the new variable. I leave such an analysis for further research.

4.6.1.5 Fragments

Unlike the Spanish speakers, French speakers only produced 27 fragment answers. It is interesting to note that some answering strategies that are numerous in the Spanish corpus are very scarce in the French one. This difference will be discussed in the comparative analysis in section 3.7.

The majority of the fragments found in this dataset express information focus, while only 1 out of 27 is, in fact, associated with contrast. At the level of the NP, the majority of subjects are definite noun phrases; the remainder consists of a few pronouns and only 2 indefinite NPs.

Dislocations

As mentioned above, dislocations can be found in the French but not in the Spanish corpus. They are, however, extremely scarce ($n=7$). The dislocated constituents are mostly strong personal pronouns (especially the first person singular *moi* 'I') or definite NPs. Although dislocations are generally treated as topic-marking strategies, the corpus shows that some speakers have made use of these constructions to mark focus. The fact that subject focus can be marked by a dislocation is in line with the prosodic requirements of French and with Féry's (2001) Phrasing Hypothesis: by positioning the subject constituent in the left periphery, the speaker creates two intonational phrases, one for the focused subject and one for the background proposition. The subject can thus receive prosodic prominence by virtue of being positioned phrase-finally, and can be marked as focus.

Even if extremely scarce, it is possible to see that dislocated subjects can express both information and contrastive focus.

4.7 Comparative analysis of frequencies: the “copy” hypothesis

4.7 Comparative analysis of frequencies: the “copy” hypothesis

Looking at the overall distribution, the first important consideration is that focused subjects appear to be relatively infrequent in both languages. This finding is in line with what Lambrecht (1994) or Skopeteas & Fanselow (2010) have claimed about the degree of markedness of the subject in focus (see Chapter 1), i.e., the assumption of a default association ‘subject = topic’, implying that deviations from this configuration should be structurally marked (see Lambrecht 2001: 490; Zerbian et al. 2007: 336; Hartmann & Zimmermann 2007). This markedness seems to be reflected not only in the association between subject focus and non-canonical forms but also in its frequency of production. It is interesting to note, though, that the data shows variation at the level of the strategies that express the same pragmatic function. In both languages, speakers produced the same number of answering strategies (5 for each language), albeit with different frequencies. The fact that a focused subject can be expressed by other means such as elliptical forms is not surprising *per se*. However, to the best of my knowledge, there have been no study conducted so far that investigate the frequency with which different strategies are used language-internally, or that compare French and Spanish in this respect.

Overall, the results from the two sub-corpora appear to support the theoretical claim that, due to its rhythmic structure, French exhibits a relatively rigid word order and relies on constructional strategies to convey certain information-structural functions. In contrast, Spanish achieves this more economically through word order alternation. While the findings reported here reinforce this claim, the variation observed in both languages suggests that these are tendencies rather than rigid rules. In other words, although Spanish postverbal subjects and French clefts are the most common strategies, they are by no means the only ones.

The absence of postverbal subjects in the French data supports Lahousse’s (2006, 2011) claim that postverbal subjects in French are now limited to a narrow range of linguistic contexts and lack the same information-structural properties as their Spanish counterparts. On the other hand, clefts appear in both languages, as the results suggest, though their distribution varies significantly. The observation that clefts in the Spanish corpus represent only 8% of the total answers (compared to 50% in the French corpus) suggests that, *ceteris paribus*, Spanish speakers tend to favour more economical strategies, such as subject-verb inversion, over the more complex and construction-heavy cleft sentences.

The *in situ* strategy, on the other hand, appears to be a disfavoured option in both languages. Notably, both Spanish and French *in situ* focused subjects almost

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never appear as indefinite NPs. This finding seems to confirm a tendency observable in many languages: positioning a brand-new referent in the sentence-initial slot is generally avoided. It is well known that not all NP types are equally felicitous in the sentence-initial position, and this slot appears to be influenced by the “definiteness effect” (see e.g., Keenan & Schieffelin 1976; McNally 1998), which suggests that highly accessible referents are preferred over less accessible ones. Moreover, as mentioned earlier, French employs syntactic strategies, such as *il y a* clefts, to avoid placing “bad” subjects at the beginning of the sentence (Karssen-berg 2018c). Given that no instances of indefinite NPs are associated with the Spanish *in situ* strategy, it can be argued that this tendency also applies to Spanish. Thus, the results are innovative in several respects. First, they demonstrate that there is no deterministic relationship between form and function, indicating that speakers utilize various means to express the same pragmatic function. Second, they provide frequencies for elliptical strategies, illustrating that similar structures can be found in both languages.

The findings regarding elliptical answers are particularly interesting if observed from a comparative perspective: although both French and Spanish have the possibility to express the same function through either a reduced cleft or a fragment, the distribution of these strategies shows an opposite tendency in the two languages. For Spanish, fragments appear with a frequency that is comparable to reduced clefts in French (and not to their French counterpart), while reduced clefts in Spanish are as infrequent as fragments in French. How can we account for this puzzling finding? In other words, why do French speakers prefer to use a reduced cleft when they could opt for a more economic strategy like a fragment?

One possible explanation may be related to the typological differences between the two languages. Spanish is typologically a pro-drop language, whereas French is not. Consequently, even when producing elliptical answers, French speakers may prefer a strategy in which the subject position is overtly filled by an element, such as the non-referential pronoun *c’* that accompanies the copula in a reduced cleft construction. If this explanation is plausible, we would expect to observe similar tendencies when comparing other null subject vs. non-null subject languages, for instance Italian and Brazilian Portuguese. In these languages, focused subjects are reportedly expressed by postverbal subjects and clefts, respectively (Kato 2006).

Similarly, the preference for reduced clefts in French could be linked to the rhythmic structure of this language (phrase-final stress). Since French supposedly does not assign prosodic prominence on a word alone, the presence of the pronoun *c’* or *il* and the corresponding copulas or verb *avoir* allows speakers to

4.8 Summary

create phrasing, and, as is the case for full clefts, to respect the prosodic requirements of the language.

Another possible explanation could be related to the Reduction Hypothesis (Jenkins 1973): assuming that both reduced clefts and fragments are indeed syntactically elliptical sentences, derived from their full counterparts, we could postulate that, when speakers intend to produce a subject in focus with an elliptical form, they have a stronger tendency to “copy” the same structure of the strategy they use more frequently (e.g., a cleft in French), and simply omit the background part for discourse-related reasons. This would explain why reduced clefts are more frequent in French, where the most common way to express a focused subject is a cleft, and why fragments are more frequent in Spanish, where the default way of expressing the same function is through a postverbal subject.

If this explanation holds true, we would expect to observe a high frequency of reduced clefts in French for the realisation of subject focus, but not, for instance, for object focus. It is well established that French primarily employs clefts as a focusing strategy for subjects, while for focusing direct objects, speakers tend to use more economical means, such as *in situ* strategies (SV[O]_{FOC}) (Skopeteas & Fanselow 2010, 2011, Destruel 2016). Therefore, if a similar study were conducted focusing on objects rather than subjects, one would expect to find a higher number of fragment answers as the corresponding elliptical strategy for object focus. Since the present study focuses exclusively on subject focus, these questions are left for future research.

The three explanations suggested above are not contradictory; rather, they are interconnected. Due to the typological and prosodic characteristics of the language, French tends to favour cleft sentences, while Spanish relies on subject-verb inversion as the preferred means of focusing the subject. However, as mentioned earlier, these claims should be interpreted as probabilistic rather than deterministic predictions. When speakers choose to produce an elliptical form, they retain the focused element from the corresponding full form while omitting the presupposed part of that structure. The alternation between complete and elliptical forms will be further explored in the next chapter, where I examine the contexts that trigger the use of full versus elliptical strategies in both languages, analysing the answer types in relation to the type of QUD they address.

4.8 Summary

The corpus study reported in this chapter has investigated the frequency of different strategies to mark focus on the subject in Spanish and French. The findings for both sub-corpora have shown that there are different ways of expressing

4 Frequency of subject focus-marking strategies

the same IS-function, and that speakers produced both full and elliptical answers. Moreover, the chapter investigates possible associations between different strategies and different focus types. While the type of focus most frequently found in both languages conveys new information, some cases of contrast are also visible.

Interestingly, almost all the strategies can be found in the two languages (with the exception of postverbal subjects for French and dislocations for Spanish). The frequencies in each language, however, differ considerably. Reduced clefts, for instance, are the second-most common means in French but the most infrequent in Spanish. Moreover, the most frequent elliptical strategy in Spanish appears to be fragment answers, a structure that was very rare in the French corpus. To explain this difference in frequency, I have proposed the “copy” hypothesis, which suggests that speakers tend to replicate the focused part of the corresponding full structure most common in their language, while omitting the background information. The question of why speakers choose to omit the background proposition and express only the focused element will be addressed in the next chapter.

5 The alternation between full and elliptical answers

5.1 The “immediacy” hypothesis

The corpus study conducted in Chapter 3 revealed that subject focus can be expressed through both full and elliptical strategies in Spanish and French. Interestingly, while French clefts and Spanish postverbal subjects are the most common answer types, the second preferred option in both languages is an elliptical form – reduced clefts for French and fragments for Spanish – indicating that these structures are far from rare in spontaneous dialogues.

As already discussed in Chapter 2, little has been said about why speakers prefer to use elliptical or full answers within the same conversation. Although several authors have pointed out that elliptical answers are often the most natural answer types in Q-A pairs with fast turns (e.g., [Belletti 2005, 2008a](#), [Lahousse & Lamiroy 2012](#), [Escandell-Vidal & Leonetti 2019](#)), previous literature on this topic has been primarily concerned with the syntactic nature of these structures, rather than with understanding why they appear and what determines the alternation with their full counterparts (however, see the recent doctoral thesis by [Bourgoin 2022](#)). [Belletti \(2008b\)](#), for instance, analyses reduced clefts as cleft sentences whose relative clause is not uttered for discourse-related reasons. In particular, she argues that reduced clefts are the most felicitous focus-marking strategy for the subject in French when the question **immediately** precedes the answer, as in (19), already illustrated in Chapter 2, that I report here:

- (35) a. *Qui (est-ce que qui) a parlé?*
 ‘Who spoke?’
 b. *C’est [Jean]_{FOC} (qui a parlé).*
 ‘It is Jean (who spoke).’ ([Belletti 2008b](#): 192)

Although a full cleft would not be ungrammatical, its use in the same context would probably be judged as infelicitous by many speakers, since uttering the relative clause would lead to a redundant repetition of the proposition already contained in the immediately-preceding question. Along the same lines,

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Katz (2000) argues that such abbreviated responses are possible when the relative clause is highly activated due to having just been mentioned (e.g., in the case of an immediately-preceding question or assertion).

These claims suggest that the syntactic form used to express focused subjects in dialogues may be influenced by the type of QUD (explicit or implicit) that triggers them. If a reduced cleft is an appropriate response when the question immediately precedes the answer, it naturally leads to the question of how responses are structured when the question does not directly precede the answer or is implicit, as is often the case in spontaneous speech. In other words, if immediately preceding questions tend to elicit elliptical answers, one would expect an association between not-immediately-preceding or implicit questions and full answers. If this is the case, the factors determining the alternation between full and elliptical answers may be tied to the degree of activation of the background proposition, as suggested by Katz (2000). However, this assumption has not yet been empirically tested.

In the literature on information structure, the concept of activation is often associated with referential entities and referential choice. It is well known, for instance, that the level of activation of the referents in discourse determines the morphological form through which these referents are expressed, and that there is an inverse relationship between the level of activation of a referent and the form with which such a referent appears. In other words, the more recently an entity has been mentioned, the more accessible it still is in the discourse model, and the higher the likelihood that the speaker will use a pronominal or zero form (Givón 1983). Givón's (1983) seminal work on topic continuity has pointed out that "the cross-linguistic generalisation is that less "coding material" (or less phonetic bulk) corresponds to more accessible referents, while more coding material corresponds to less accessible referents" (Givón 1983: 18). Such an inverse relationship has been theorised in the Accessibility Theory (Ariel 1988) as well, according to which the more "informative, rigid and unattenuated an expression is, the lower the degree of accessibility it codes, and vice-versa, the less informative and rigid and the more attenuated the form is, the higher the accessibility it codes" (Ariel 2001: 32). The term "informativity" refers in this case to the amount of lexical information. Thus, highly accessible referents would be more likely expressed by pronouns, while less accessible referents would be associated to full lexical NPs. Ariel (2001) identifies a hierarchy of accessibility that can be represented as the following referring expressions scale:

- (1) $\emptyset^1 > \text{Overt pronoun} > \text{Full NP} > \dots >$

¹Zero anaphora in pro-drop languages.

5.1 The “immediacy” hypothesis

The more a referent is activated in the discourse, the more its referring form will be minimal or short, like the case of zero anaphora ($\emptyset$) in pro-drop languages, or of overt pronoun in non-pro drop languages. Conversely, the less activated a referent is in discourse, the higher will be the likelihood for this referent to be expressed by forms which are found on the right part of Ariel’s (2001) scale. The CG includes both referents and propositions. Speaker and hearer continually share and update a communicative space that contains these entities and the propositions associated with them. Therefore, if there is an inverse relationship between the activation of referents and the amount of morphological material used to express them, propositions might follow the same pattern. Since propositions, like referents, can vary in their level of activation within the discourse, it is reasonable to hypothesise a similar activation scale for propositions, based on the principle discussed above:

(2) Deletion > Full realisation

Thus, a highly activated proposition is more likely to be omitted (in cases of deletion), while a less activated proposition is more likely to be fully realized. It is important to note that no strict one-to-one correlation is expected between the degree of activation and the expression or omission of a proposition. Instead, these relationships are predicted to be probabilistic, representing tendencies rather than categorical grammatical rules. In a dialogical setting, the presupposition is generally contained in the preceding QUD.

According to Lambrecht (1994), the use of an information question is appropriate only if the open proposition resulting from removal of the question expression (the *wh*-element) from the sentence is pragmatically presupposed in the discourse. In other words, a question like ‘Who ate the cookie?’ evokes the assumption that the addressee can identify the particular cookie the speaker has in mind, and accepts the fact that some individual ate this cookie as uncontroversial (except in the case of a rhetorical question, suggesting the answer ‘No one’). This implies that in case of immediately-preceding questions, where the answer directly follows the question, the proposition is highly activated. Conversely, with questions that do not precede the answer or are implicit, the level of activation of the proposition decreases. Following this line of argumentation, I formulated the following hypothesis:

- (3) **H1:** Speakers tend to use elliptical answers when the preceding QUD is immediate, while full answers are preferred when the QUD is either implicit or not immediate.

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The reader may have noticed that I postulate three possible levels of activation of the BG material (immediate, distant, implicit) and only two possible outcomes (deletion vs. full realisation). While a more detailed analysis that identifies an intermediate level (e.g., pronominalisation) would have been ideal, a pilot study conducted on the same corpus revealed that a third level could not be observed. In principle, a realised but distant QUD should have a higher degree of activation than an unrealised (implicit) QUD. However, the pilot study revealed that this distinction does not affect the types of answers these questions elicit, as both implicit and distant QUDs resulted in the same outcomes. The decision to exclude a third level in my dependent variable is thus empirically motivated.

In order to test H1, a second corpus analysis was carried out, using the data issued from the corpus query reported in Chapter 3. The results of this study demonstrate that the level of immediacy of the preceding QUD and, hence, the degree of activation of the background proposition has indeed an effect on the alternation between full and elliptical answers. It also shows, however, that such an effect is different for the two languages: while French speakers tend to avoid using full forms in the case of immediately-preceding QUDs, Spanish speakers are less sensitive to this tendency. Conversely, in the case of not-immediate or implicit QUDs, both French and Spanish speakers exhibit a clear preference for expressing more material, i.e., to employ fuller forms. I present an account of these findings in terms of economy of the language, showing that the choice of the sentential form is, to some extent, ruled by principles, such as “The Principle of the Least Effort” (Zipf 1972) and “The principle of Communicative Efficiency” (Levshina & Moran 2021, Levshina 2022).

Although the results of this study are not surprising, the chapter presents several innovative points: i) it tests claims that have so far been made only at a theoretical level, ii) it stresses the importance of the activation of propositions in the CG and how this has an impact on speakers’ linguistic expression, iii) it provides a new method of operationalising the activation of the QUD, by identifying three levels of distance (immediate, not-immediate, implicit). The details of the corpus analysis are illustrated in the following sections: section 4.2 reports on the methodology of the study; section 4.3 and 4.4 show the results of the analysis. Finally, section 4.5 discusses the findings from a comparative perspective.

5.2 Methodology

In this section, I report the design of the study and the criteria for the annotation of the items. The goal is to investigate whether the realization or the deletion

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of the background proposition contained in the answer (dependent variable) is influenced by the immediacy of the preceding QUD (independent variable). The material consists of the answer types extracted from the previous corpus query (Chapter 3) and their corresponding QUD. As illustrated in Chapter 3, Spanish speakers produced a total of 352 subject foci, and French speakers 436. Both the answer types and the QUDs were annotated according to the criteria listed in the following sections.

5.2.1 Annotation of answer types

The corpus study reported in the previous chapter has demonstrated that each language possesses five different strategies to express narrow focus on the subject. Although syntactically different, these structures can be grouped into two categories: i) answers with a focused subject and an overt background proposition; and ii) answers where only the focused subject is uttered. To the first category belong postverbal subjects, *in situ* foci and cleft constructions for the Spanish dataset, while the French data consists of clefts, *in situ* foci, and, although very scarce, dislocations. The second category, on the other hand, includes fragments and reduced clefts for both languages. The tables below report the counts for each category and each language.

Table 5.1: Spanish

Full answers	Elliptical answers
Postverbal subjects (N=167)	Fragments (N=102)
<i>In situ</i> (N=33)	Reduced clefts (N=21)
Clefts (N=29)	
Total = 229	Total = 123

The category of full answers received the tag COMPLETE, while elliptical answers were coded as ELLIPTICAL.

5.2.2 Annotation of QUDs

Each answer type had already been extracted together with the implicit or explicit corresponding QUD. In this step, I annotated the QUDs, distinguishing three levels of annotation for the QUD type:

5 The alternation between full and elliptical answers

Table 5.2: French

Full answers	Elliptical answers
Clefts (N=220)	Reduced clefts (N=137)
<i>In situ</i> (N=41)	Fragments (N=31)
Dislocations (N=7)	
Total = 268	Total = 168

Immediate QUD: The case of the immediate QUD is a prototypical Q-A pair with a fast turn. The question is explicitly uttered, it directly precedes the answer, and is thus easily retrievable. This type of question has been annotated as IMMEDIATE. Examples are provided in (4) and (5) for French and Spanish, respectively. Both in the QUD and in the answer, the BG proposition is underlined for better visibility:

- (4) FR:
- a. *En fait, il y avait qui dans l'immeuble quand ça s'est passé?*
'So, who was in the building when all this happened?'
 - b. *Alors en fait il y avait [la grand-mère du dessus]_{FOC} qui était là.*
'So, actually, there was the old lady from upstairs who was there.'
- (sgs French, 9/261-262)
- (5) SP:
- a. *¿Quién vive por ahí?*
'Who lives there?'
 - b. *Vive [un señor importante]_{FOC}.*
'An important man lives there.'
- (sgs Spanish, 3/18-19)

Distant QUD: The second type is less straightforward. The question that triggers the focused subject does not immediately precede it. Typically, there are intervening utterances between the QUD and its answer. The basic idea here is that multiple utterances in the discourse model compete for the limited resource of activation. The criterion of intervening utterances as a measure of decreased accessibility (or activation decay) of the proposition is also parallel to a factor that has been claimed to affect referential

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choice, namely the distance between the anaphora and its antecedent measured by the number of intervening, competing referents (e.g., [Arnold & Griffin 2007](#)). In the case of referents, competition would make the speaker express more coding material to refer to that particular entity. Building on these claims, I assume that the presence of competing utterances would contribute to the activation decay of the BG proposition. This type is coded as DISTANT. Consider (6) and (7):

(6) FR:

- a. *Et les enfants, qui s'en occupe?*
'And who takes care of the children?'
 - b. *Donc, en ce moment, ils sont pas là.*
'So, at the moment, they are not there.'
 - b. *Ils sont en vacances.*
'They are on holidays.'
 - b. *Sinon, c'est [une nourrice]_{FOC} qui les garde le soir.*
'Usually it's a babysitter that takes care of them at night.'
- (sgs French, 14/133-136)

(7) SP:

- a. *¿Qué gente entra en esa casa, además de la familia?*
'Which other people have entered in the house apart from his family?'
 - b. *Pues sí que tienen mujer de la limpieza.*
'Well, he has a cleaning lady.'
 - a. *¿Quién tiene llaves?*
'Who has the key?'
 - b. *m.*
'm.'
 - b. *Tienen la mujer de la limpieza.*
'They have the cleaning lady.'
 - b. *Después, estos días también han venido [el electricista, el lampista]_{FOC}.*
'Then, these days, the electrician, the plumber came as well.'
- (sgs Spanish, 40/127-132)

5 The alternation between full and elliptical answers

In (6), it is possible to see that the QUD *Qui s'en occupe?* 'Who takes care of the children?' does not immediately precede the answer. Before answering the actual QUD, speaker b utters additional information, which represents not-at-issue content, and intervenes between the question and the answer, thus decreasing the level of activation of the background proposition contained in the question (i.e., to take care of the children). Similarly, in the Spanish example in (7), speaker a asks who had access to the apartment, apart from the family. Speaker b answers that the family has a cleaning lady. The speaker specifies that the cleaning lady can enter the apartment, but does not clearly say if she had access to the flat during those days. Rather, the actual answer to the original question is provided at the end of the dialogue (i.e., the electrician, the plumber).

Implicit QUD: The third type of QUD is more complicated. It is not uncommon in spontaneous speech to find implicit material. Rather, many questions in dialogues are not uttered explicitly. Sometimes, speakers anticipate possible questions of their interlocutors, and this results in more spontaneity in the conversation. When the QUD is implicit, it has to be retrieved by looking at the preceding utterances and at the answer itself. Reconstructing an implicit QUD, however, can potentially be an arbitrary process, especially when it comes to marked constructions such as clefts, that usually trigger specific IS-interpretations (e.g., focus-background). To avoid circularity and manage a correct retrieval of the QUD, I followed the criteria listed in the QUD guidelines by [Riester et al. \(2018\)](#), [Riester \(2019\)](#). The authors propose a series of constraints that regulates the reconstruction of the QUD, and allows its derivation from the preceding discourse context. The constraints are derived from the focus literature of the past decades, in particular, [Rooth \(1992\)](#), [Schwarzschild \(1999\)](#) and [Büring \(2009\)](#). For instance, implicit QUDs must be answerable by an assertion that they immediately dominate (Q-A-Congruence), they must contain as much given material as possible (Maximize-Q-Anaphoricity constraint) and can only consist of given or at least highly salient information (Q-Givenness constraint). Consider the example in (8) taken from [Riester \(2019\)](#):

- (8) a. And all I can say is that his condition was extremely bad during
his last year
b. He literally suffocated ([Riester 2019](#): 9)

The assertion in (8b) gives rise to a set of alternative QUDs, such as:

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- Q1: What happened?
- Q2: What about him?
- Q3: Who literally suffocated?
- Q4: Who owns a bicycle?

According to the Q-A-Congruence, Q4 is ruled out because it cannot be answered by the assertion that it immediately dominates. Q1 is also excluded because of the Maximize-Q-Anaphoricity constraint, which states that the QUD must contain as much given or salient material as possible, and a question like Q1 does not contain any of the given material found in the assertion. Finally, the Q-Givenness constraint, according to which an implicit QUD cannot introduce new material (except from function words and *wh*-particles), excludes Q3, because the fact of being ‘literally suffocated’ is new information, and fails to provide a link with the previous context. Conversely, the personal pronoun ‘he’ is connected to the previous sentence by virtue of reference continuity (the possessor ‘his’ in ‘his condition’ in (8a)). Q2 is hence the optimal candidate as the implicit QUD of the assertion contained in (8b).

Riester et al. (2018), Riester (2019) also note that, usually, there is no single way of formulating implicit QUDs, since language allows for synonymous formulations. In other words, the assertion contained in (8b) could as well be an answer to a question such as ‘how bad was his condition/situation?’. Nevertheless, these constraints provide specific criteria for the retrieval of the implicit question. This type of QUD is tagged as IMPLICIT. Examples are provided in (9) and (10):

(9) FR:

- a. *Mais il y avait une soirée.*
‘But there was a party.’
- b. *mh.*
‘m.’
- a. *Donc, justement, c’est [les voisins du haut]_{FOC}
qui ont organisé cette soirée.*
‘So, it was exactly the neighbors from upstairs that organized
this party.’ (sgs French, 59/ 338-340)

(Implicit QUD: Who organized the party?)

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(10) SP:

- a. *Económicamente le iba bien y así?*
'Were they wealthy?'
- b. *Sí, a ver, estos pisos son un poco caros.*
'Yes, well, the apartments here are rather expensive.'
- b. *Y, vivían sólo [dos personas]_{FOC}.*
'And only two people lived in this apartment.'

(sgs Spanish, 15/ 183-185)

(Implicit QUD: How many people lived in this apartment?)

Let us try to reconstruct the implicit QUD answered by the assertion *C'est les voisins du haut qui ont organisé cette soirée* 'It is the neighbours from above who organized this party' contained in (9), considering both the material in the assertion and the context preceding it. To avoid being biased by morphosyntactic cues, I do not take into account the fact that the assertion is a cleft sentence, and I only build on the semantic content of the dialogue. The Q-A-Congruence constraint rules out an implicit QUD such as 'what about him?' because it would not be semantically congruent with the answer.

The referent *les voisins du haut* 'the neighbours upstairs' is discourse-new, and, therefore, cannot be part of the background proposition.² In other words, a QUD such as 'What about the upstairs neighbours?' is excluded as well. The referent *soirée* 'party', however, has already been mentioned in the preceding utterance. Its co-reference with its antecedent is also testified by the use of the demonstrative *cette* 'this'. Applying the Q-Anaphoricity constraint, I assume that the implicit QUD must somehow contain this referent. The verb *organiser* 'to organise' has not been previously mentioned either. However, the word *soirée* 'party' activates a series of possible QUDs in the mind of the hearer, such as 'Who came to the party?', 'How many people?', 'How was the music?', 'How was the food?' or 'Who organised this party?'

Among the different possibilities, it seems plausible that the last question (Who organised this party?) is the most felicitous in context. Speaker a wants to know about possible noises in the building, speaker b informs speaker a of a party, and assumes that speaker a wants to know who are

²Recall that according to the Q-Givenness constraint, implicit QUDs cannot contain new material and must consist of given or highly-salient material.

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the people responsible for the party/noise of that particular evening. Thus, it is possible to assume that *organiser* ‘to organise’, although not properly given, is highly salient, and that its salience is activated by the referent *soirée* ‘party’. For this reason, it can be considered part of the implicit QUD. The discourse marker *justement* ‘rightly’ is additional evidence of the link between the current assertion and the previous context, proving that ‘Who organised the party?’ is a sub-question of the main QUD ‘*Est-ce qu’il y a eu des problèmes de bruit?*’ ‘Were there usually problems with noisy parties?’. Speaker a is thus signalling that s/he is providing additional information with respect to the noise heard that evening. In summary, the implicit QUD can contain material, such as *soirée* and *organiser*, but cannot include brand-new information, such as the upstairs neighbours, which in turn can be considered the focus of the sentence, i.e., the part of the assertion that satisfies the wh-variable in the implicit QUD. Therefore, I assume that the cleft sentence in (9) has a classical focus-background partition, with the clefted element being the focus and the relative clause the background proposition.

Similarly, in the Spanish example (10), speaker a is asking about the economic situation of the neighbour in question. Speaker b provides evidence of their wealth by informing speaker a that the apartments in the building are very expensive and that there were only two people living in that particular flat (and hence only two people paying rent). As was the case in the French example with the concept ‘party’, the word *piso* ‘apartment’ is salient because it evokes a series of possible QUDs. These might include, for instance, ‘Who lived in the apartment?’, ‘For how long?’ or ‘How many people were living there?’. Speaker a already knows that a couple is living in the apartment in question. What he/she does not know, however, is if they share rent with someone else. Speaker a, thus, informs him/her that only two people are living in that flat.

The three types of QUDs are illustrated in Table 2 together with their corresponding tags:

Both in the French and in the Spanish dialogues, it has been observed that the types of explicit QUDs could be of two modalities: wh-question and yes-no questions. These two question types are intrinsically different not only with respect to their syntactic configuration, but also with regard to the pragmatic inference they trigger. While wh-questions contain an overt wh-element which, according to the Alternative Semantic Framework (Rooth 1985, 1992), must be filled

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Table 5.3: QUD types

Immediate QUD	Distant QUD	Implicit QUD
The question immediately precedes the answer.	The question does not immediately precede the answer.	The question is implicit.
Tag: IMMEDIATE	Tag: DISTANT	Tag: IMPLICIT

with one (or more) possible alternatives (i.e., the focus), in yes-no questions (also called polarity questions), the variable is, in principle, satisfied by the polarity item ‘yes’ or ‘no’. Typical of spontaneous speech, however, is the phenomenon of over-answering yes-no questions, i.e., of generating extended responses that provide additional information to yes-no questions that pragmatically must be interpreted as wh-questions (Wahlster et al. 1983, Steensig & Heinemann 2013). Indeed, a cooperative speaker has the ability to recognize when it is appropriate to provide more than a mere literal, direct answer to a question, and to decide what that extended response should be. Consider the example in (11):

- (11) a. *Y, ¿Algún vecino tú crees que se podría haber quejado del ruido o que hubiera bajado?*
‘And do you think that some neighbour could have complained about the noise or could have come downstairs?’
b. *Sí, ayer se quejó [una vecina]_{FOC} del ruido.*
‘Yes, yesterday a woman complained about the noise.’
(sgs Spanish, 41/158-159)

In (11), the actual answer to the yes-no question is represented by the polarity item *sí* ‘yes’, situated at the beginning of the sentence. In this case, however, a simple polarity item would not be taken as a cooperative answer, since the yes-no question contains as pragmatic implicature (Grice 1975) the implicit wh-question ‘Who complained?’. Such an implicature is well captured by Speaker b who cooperatively answers the implicit QUD, thus making the dialogue between the two successful. These cases are so frequent in spontaneous speech that it is possible to find the answer to the implicit wh-question directly, even without the polarity item. In (11), for instance, speaker b’s answer would be entirely acceptable even if the polarity item had been omitted.

5.3 Results for Spanish

Although cases like the one just described involve implicit wh-question, they have not been annotated as implicit QUDs in the present study. Recall that the independent variable is the immediacy of the background material. In the case of a yes-no question functioning as a wh-question, the background proposition is still explicitly stated and immediately precedes the answer. Therefore, a QUD like (11a) is tagged as IMMEDIATE, since the background is considered highly activated because of its proximity to the answer. The correlation between different modalities of preceding QUDs and cleft types is tackled in [Cassarà et al. \(2022\)](#) who conducted a study on the same corpus, showing that wh-questions appear more frequently with reduced clefts, while yes-no questions tend to collocate with full clefts. For the purpose of the present analysis, however, I do not differentiate between different modalities of QUDs in the annotation, and I concentrate only on their level of immediacy or implicitness.

5.3 Results for Spanish

Figure 7 reports the result for the Spanish answers in relation to their QUD. As the graph shows, in the IMMEDIATE condition, 51% (N=87) of the answers are complete and 49% (N=78) are elliptical. In the DISTANT condition, 79% (N=48) are complete answers and 21% (N=13) are elliptical ones. Finally, in the IMPLICIT condition, it is possible to observe 86% (N=78) complete and 14% (N=13) elliptical structures.

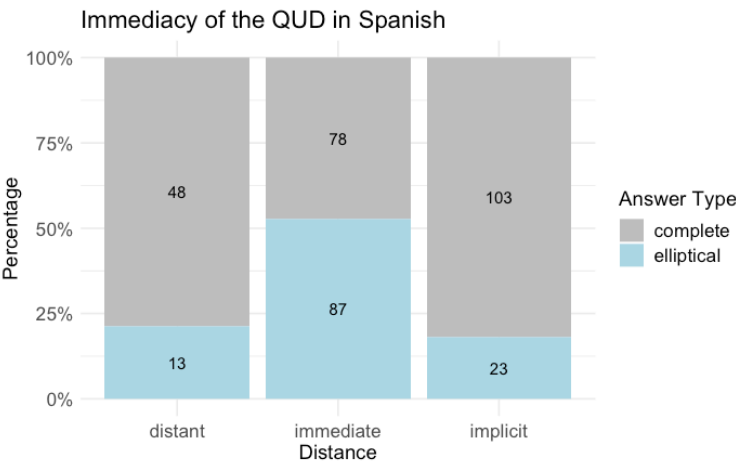


Figure 5.1: Immediacy of the QUD in Spanish

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To examine whether elliptical answers occurred significantly more often than complete answers within each QUD distance, binomial tests were conducted. In the immediate condition, the number of elliptical (87) and complete (78) answers did not differ significantly ($p > 0.05$). In contrast, in the distant condition, elliptical answers (13) were significantly less frequent than complete answers (48), $p < 0.001$. Similarly, in the implicit condition, elliptical answers (23) were significantly less frequent than complete answers (103), $p < 0.001$.

Thus, when the QUD is immediate, no significant difference can be observed in speakers' choice between a full and an elliptical answer (even though there is a slight preference for full answers). This implies that in the case of an immediately-preceding question, Spanish speakers prefer to answer with strategies that contain an explicit BG (postverbal subject, an *in situ* subject, a cleft), or with strategies where only the focused subject is visible (reduced clefts or fragments). However, when the question is distant or implicit, a clear preference can be observed for answers with an overtly-realised BG, suggesting that in those cases, speakers opt for strategies where they express more material. Thus, the hypothesis (H1) is only partly confirmed for the Spanish data.

5.4 Results for French

As for the French results, participants produced 42% (N=67) of the answers with an overt BG and 58% (N=91) with an elided one in the IMMEDIATE condition. In the DISTANT condition, 77% (N=100) are full items and 23% (N=30) are elliptical ones. Lastly, the IMPLICIT condition is associated with 68% (N=101) full answers and 32% (=47) elliptical strategies.

A Pearson's Chi-squared test showed that the proportion of elliptical versus complete answers differed significantly across QUD distance, $\chi^2(2, N = 436) = 53.8$, $p < 0.001$. Binomial tests within each distance condition revealed that in the distant condition, elliptical answers (30) were significantly less frequent than complete answers (100), $p < 0.001$; in the immediate condition, elliptical answers (91) were significantly more frequent than complete answers (67), $p < 0.05$; and in the implicit condition, elliptical answers (47) were significantly less frequent than complete answers (101), $p < 0.001$. These results indicate that elliptical answers occur particularly often for immediate questions, while complete answers dominate for distant and implicit questions.

The results for the French sub-corpus reveal a different picture than the one visible for the Spanish data, at least in the IMMEDIATE condition, where speakers show a significant preference for elliptical answers. Similarly to Spanish, in

5.5 Comparative analysis

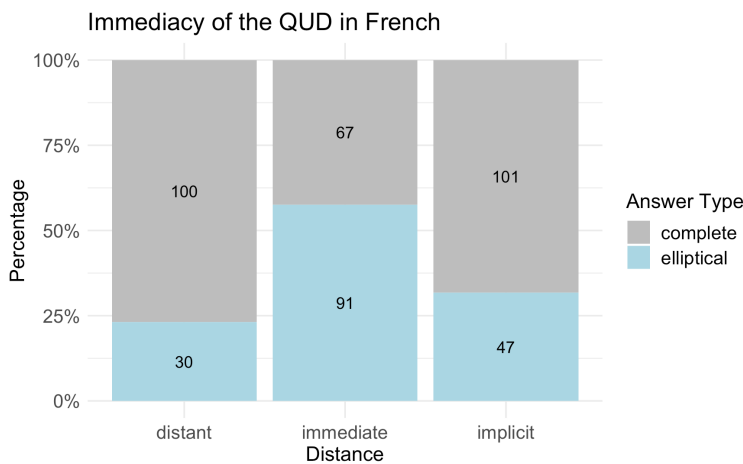


Figure 5.2: Immediacy of the QUD in French

the cases of implicit or distant QUDs, there is a clear tendency to express more material, and to answer with a full strategy (as was the case in Spanish). The hypothesis (H1) is therefore fully confirmed for French.

5.5 Comparative analysis

Both the Spanish and the French dataset revealed interesting findings on the alternation between full and elliptical answers and their usage in spoken dialogues. The study showed that there is a clear effect of the degree of activation of the background proposition on the answer types produced by speakers. While elliptical answers are associated with a higher activation of the background material (even if to a lesser extent for the Spanish data), full answers are clearly more frequent when the BG proposition is less activated, like in the case of a distant or an implicit QUD.

This result is not surprising *per se*, and several authors have already pointed out this correlation before, even if at a theoretical level (see section 4.1). However, to my recollection, these assumptions had never been operationalized and tested. In a dialogical setting, the QUD method gives clear insights into how the CG is managed, and how this constant evolution is reflected in speakers’ linguistic choices.

As mentioned in section 4.1, the idea of levels of activation of referents has already been acknowledged in many theories of CG content and CG management.

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Along the same lines as Ariel (2001), Chiarcos (2011) in his “Iconicity principle in referential choice” claims that “the more hearer salient a discourse referent is, the less marked is the preferred referring expression” (Chiarcos 2011: 201). Similar to Ariel (2001), this implies that there is an inverse relationship between the amount of linguistic coding and the assumed accessibility of the referent: the more accessible the referent is, the less coding is needed.

The corpus study conducted here shows that this inverse relationship is applicable not only to referents but also to other components of communication, such as propositions. Starting from the consideration that propositions can also be subject to different degrees of activation, this corpus study demonstrated how a higher level of salience of the proposition results in a smaller amount of linguistic material. Although this pattern is not as fine-grained as is the case for referring expressions, the results revealed that processes like deletion or overt realization of the proposition are actually indicators of different degrees of activation of the proposition itself. The background material is, by definition, a proposition that is already known and shared by speaker and hearer. However, the concept of givenness alone is not able to capture specific linguistic choices. For instance, empirical studies on referential choice have shown that factors like distance from the last mention and competition (presence of intervening referents) might explain the phenomenon in a more comprehensive way (e.g., Arnold & Griffin 2007). By applying the same principle to the BG proposition in dialogues, I demonstrated that factors such as distance from the QUD, intervening utterances or implicitness have a considerable impact on the choice of the answer produced.

5.5.1 Why do French and Spanish differ?

The association between immediately preceding questions and elliptical answers, such as fragments or reduced clefts, is more pronounced in French (58%) than in Spanish (49%). This difference between the two languages may be due to differences in syntactic weight. As noted in Chapter 3, most full answers in French are cleft sentences, whereas in Spanish, they are primarily postverbal subjects. From a syntactic perspective, there is a considerable difference between the two structures: a cleft sentence is a bi-clausal structure, where the BG material is encoded under the form of a relative clause. As such, clefts are “heavy” and costly syntactic processes, and include additional lexical material (e.g., *c’est... qui* ‘it is...that’). In the case of postverbal subjects, the background material consists of a predicate, and for transitive verbs, an object that can either be fully realized or cliticized. As postverbal subject constructions do not include additional lexical elements, they

5.5 Comparative analysis

are inherently ‘lighter’ than clefts. This difference could explain why, for Spanish immediate QUDs, there is no significant preference between full and elliptical answers. That is to say, repeating the entire background of a cleft construction, including the relative clause, requires more effort than repeating a verb and, for example, a complement.

A closer look at the Spanish data reveals that in many of the occurrences of immediate QUDs with full answers, the BG proposition, although repeated, is often reformulated. Consider (12):

- (12) a. *¿Hay alguno que no se lleve bien?*
 ‘Is there anyone that doesn’t get along with her?’
 b. *Bueno a ver, había [las chicas del tercero]_{FOC}*
 que siempre tenían problemas con ella.
 ‘Well, let’s see, there were the girls from the third floor that always
 had problems with her.’ (sgs Spanish, 21/118-119)

In (12), the BG proposition contained in the question *llevarse bien* ‘to get along’ is reformulated by speaker b, who prefers a different wording rather than the exact repetition (*tener problemas* ‘to have problems’). This is evidence of the fact that, even in case of an answer with an expressed background, Spanish speakers tend to avoid the exact, same repetition of the BG proposition.

Moreover, as will be illustrated in Chapter 5, the majority of the verbs associated with postverbal subjects are monoargumental verbs, especially unaccusatives (as in (13)). This implies that the BG proposition is often expressed only by a verb, and that repeating it - although it has been immediately mentioned in the answer - would not lead to the same infelicity in context as repeating an entire relative clause, as in the case of a cleft sentence (12).

- (13) a. *¿Quién ha fallecido?*
 ‘Who died?’
 b. *Ha fallecido [la chica del segundo]_{FOC}.*
 ‘The girl from the second floor died.’ (sgs Spanish, 8/30-31)

Conversely, in French, the association between immediately preceding QUDs and elliptical answers is quite strong. However, while French speakers clearly prefer to omit the background material by opting for an elliptical strategy, full answers still appear in 42% of cases with immediately preceding questions. As was the case in Spanish, in many instances, speakers tend to reformulate the background rather than repeat it exactly, as seen in example (14):

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- (14) a. *Tu dis qu'il y a des gens qui sont venus hier?*³
 'You said that there are people that came here yesterday?'
 b. *Ouais, il y a [quatre gars]_{FOC} qui sont passés hier.*
 'Yes, there are four guys that stepped by yesterday.'
 (sgs French, 83/231-232)

Sometimes the repetition of the BG proposition is justified by the fact that the speaker adds a new element within the BG. This element could be an adverb, for instance, as (15):

- (15) a. *Ils ont une femme de ménage qui vient les aider?*
 'Do they have a housekeeper who comes and helps them?'
 b. *Pendant une période il y avait [une femme de ménage]_{FOC} qui venait une fois par semaine.*
 'During a certain period there was a housekeeper who came once a week.'
 (sgs French, 8/30-31)

Karssenberg (2017, 2018a) had already noted this phenomenon in her data: "However, it is important to note that in most specificational *il y a* clefts, the relative clause does not repeat a discourse-given variable verbatim: it usually contains at least a small piece of new information. In other words, the type of specificational cleft with a completely discourse-given relative clause, though often presented in analyses of clefts [...] is quite rare in my corpora. [...] In many cases, the extra piece of information is an evaluation on behalf of the speaker/writer [...]" (Karssenberg 2017: 251).

It has to be pointed out that, according to the QUD approach, the new element corresponds to not-at-issue material since it does not answer the current QUD. Rather, it corresponds to an answer to an implicit sub-QUD. Nevertheless, this could be taken as another motivation for the speaker to repeat the full BG, instead of having only the focused element.

Table 7 shows the differences between the two languages in terms of i) exact repetition of the BG (13), ii) reformulation (12) and iii) presence of a new element (15):

As can be observed in the table, the cases of exact repetition of the BG proposition are more frequent in Spanish than in French. As mentioned above, this might

³Note that, in this case, the whole question contains background material. The presuppositional content would be 'some people came here yesterday'. This being a yes-no question, the wh-question 'who are these guys?' is implicit. However, the BG proposition still immediately precedes the critical item.

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Table 5.4: Comparative frequencies of different types of immediate QUDs

	Spanish	French
Repetition	56/78 (72%)	23/67 (34%)
Reformulation	13/78 (17%)	24/67 (36%)
New element	9/78 (11%)	20/67 (30%)

be due to the fact that repeating an unaccusative verb is easier than repeating an entire relative clause. Moreover, a closer look at the cases of exact repetition in French reveals that, among the 23 cases, many are contrastive, which justifies the need to express more material. Finally, a closer look at the cases containing a new element in both languages reveals that new elements are generally adverbs or modifier clauses, adding spatio-temporal information to the element in focus.

5.5.2 Focus and the economy principle of language

Apart from these cases, it is safe to conclude that when the proposition is highly activated in the CG, its repetition is generally avoided because it would sound redundant and would lead to unnecessary prolixity. These results are in line with Levshina’s *Principle of Communicative Efficiency*, which states that speakers communicate in such a way as to minimize the cost-to-benefit ratio (Levshina 2022: 30). In her theory, Levshina clarifies how successful communication leads to evoking cognitive effects, which in turn is necessary to influence others or adjust our own behaviour and which ultimately is what guarantees our survival as a group. The author also evokes the concept of accessibility, which, as previously mentioned, is an already established notion in the literature on referentiality (Ariel 2001, Arnold & Griffin 2007). In her model, this notion is extended to other contexts, referring to “the ease with which some mental representations or forms can be activated in or retrieved from memory” (Levshina 2022: 18). Levshina offers an overview of phenomena related to coding efficiency from various areas of grammar: referential expressions, grammatical markers, clause connectors and other complex syntactic phenomena, shortening of lexical material, as well as phonetic reduction/enhancement.

When applying this principle to dialogical situations, it becomes evident that repeating the entire background proposition when it is highly activated may result in a loss of communicative efficiency, as it leads to redundancy and can sound unnatural. Instead, an elliptical answer is preferred, serving as an optimal strategy

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to maintain the flow of communication. On the other hand, when the question is distant from the answer, the level of activation of the proposition decreases, especially when intervening utterances — such as sub-questions of the original QUD — are present (see examples 6 and 7). In such cases, speakers tend to provide more information to facilitate cooperation and ensure successful updating of the common ground (CG). By fully expressing the proposition and linking it to the focus constituent, speakers signal to the hearer that the focus must be interpreted in relation to a specific proposition, thereby minimizing ambiguity.

Both the Spanish and the French data confirm this tendency, and reveal that in the DISTANT condition, the majority of the answers produced by both groups of speakers are complete strategies, i.e., answers with an expressed BG proposition. A similar tendency can be observed in the case of implicit QUDs, even though, in this case, a different pragmatic process might be involved: accommodation. The pragmatic notion of presuppositional accommodation (Lewis 1979) is generally considered a communicational strategy through which the addressee adds the presupposed proposition to the set of all propositions which s/he assumes to be part of the interlocutors' common ground (Beaver & Zeevat 2007). It is conceived as a universally-available adaptive mechanism to enhance communicative efficiency, and it is generally understood as a repair strategy: if a piece of information cannot be interpreted with respect to the current CG, then the current CG can minimally be changed in a way that it fits the requirement of the piece of information. The proposition is evoked, but not explicitly mentioned. However, speakers accommodate, the proposition is implicitly shared in the CG content, and the addressee reconstructs it in order to make his/her interlocutor's contribution informative.

The fact that both implicit and not immediate QUDs correlate with full answers is in line with the generalization that speakers express more when they presume that the hearer knows less, i.e., when they judge it useful to clarify and to remind the addressee that the answer containing a particular referent has to be linked with a particular proposition. Information structure is a continuous updating of the CG, and it is dependent on the speaker's intention to communicate information based on what s/he assumed the hearer already knows. Therefore, in the case of implicit or distant questions, the cooperative speaker assumes that s/he has to express more material for a successful communication with the hearer.

Conversely, in the case of an explicit and immediately-preceding QUD, there are enough contextual cues to determine what is going to follow, which implies that the hearer does not need to perform any costly operation. In this case, an elliptical answer type, like a fragment, is sufficient, whereas the need to use a more explicit focus-marking device such as a cleft, diminishes. Zimmermann & Onea

5.6 Summary

(2011) also claim that in the case of an explicit QUD, “heavy” focus marking is less necessary and a more economic strategy is preferable.

The results issued in this chapter are also in line with a theory of economy of language (Zipf 1972), which emphasises the fundamental role played by the *Principle of Least Effort*, which involves tending towards the minimum amount of effort necessary to achieve the maximum result. Concerning linguistic behaviour, he distinguished the opposing pressures exerted by the speaker’s and the hearer’s economies of effort, the one oriented toward minimal linguistic articulation, the other toward maximal explicitness. According to Carston (2005), Zipf’s (1972) speaker’s economy can be understood as a force pushing in the direction of a single word or sound that would express all possible meanings, thus sparing the speaker the mental effort that is involved in selecting the appropriate linguistic forms for the meanings s/he wants to convey. The findings of this study confirm this tendency, showing that, in the presence of enough contextual cues for successful understanding, speakers prefer to express less. Conversely, they choose to express more when such cues are not as clear.

Moreover, this study further emphasizes how our linguistic expressions are shaped by the types of questions they respond to. The QUD approach to focus is not new in itself. As discussed in Chapter 2, Roberts (1996) frames common ground management as a discourse process driven by hierarchies of unresolved questions. While it is well-established that the use of ellipses is tied to attention and short-term memory, the systematic analysis linking ellipses (versus full forms) with the QUD framework presents an innovative contribution to this area of research.

5.6 Summary

In this chapter, I have investigated the alternation between full and elliptical answers in subject focus realization. I posited the hypothesis that the activation of the BG proposition is the factor determining such alternation, and I tested this hypothesis for both Spanish and French speakers. Although some differences can be found, both the Spanish and the French data show that elliptical answers are more frequent in contexts of high activation of the background material, whereas full strategies are preferred when such activation decreases.

As such, propositions are subject to the same Iconicity principle (Chiarcos 2011) as referents, where an inverse relationship can be observed between the level of activation and the amount of linguistic coding. To interpret the results, I have provided an account in terms of communicative efficiency. In particular, I claim that these communicative choices are subject to Levshina’s principle of communicative efficiency (Levshina 2022) and, to the principle of the least effort (Zipf

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1972). Based on these findings, I propose that communicative strategies such as accommodation are reflected in speakers' linguistic choices, and in the way they decide to cooperate for a successful updating of the CG content.

Several authors have pointed out the fact that answers to questions in natural speech typically delete discourse-old information from the question or pronominalize arguments which cannot be grammatically deleted (e.g., Krifka 2008). Examples can be found also in several unrelated languages, such as Northern Sotho (Zerbian et al. 2007) or Bantu languages (Downing & Hyman 2016). Such tendencies, however, had never been tested for Spanish or French. By adopting the QUD method, I have suggested a possible means to operationalize claims that had been posited at a theoretical level. Thus, the “immediacy” hypothesis is not necessarily exclusive to subject focus; rather, it can be extended to other types of constituent focus and, obviously, to other languages. Processes such as the activation of the background proposition or pragmatic accommodation are generally conceived of as universal, although their linguistic manifestation may vary across languages. This same hypothesis could be extended to object focus by exploring which structures emerge from a similar analysis and how they compare to the findings of this chapter. These questions, however, are outside the scope of this book, but remain nonetheless an interesting line of research for future work.

Although this chapter provides a pragmatic account for the alternation between full and elliptical strategies, it gives no indication as to why we find language-internal and cross-linguistic syntactic variation to express the same function. In other words, why do Spanish postverbal subjects alternate with preverbal ones in the expression of subject focus? Why do we find different cleft types with the same IS-function? Are semantic and pragmatic factors responsible for the occurrence of one structure rather than the other? These questions are addressed in the next chapter, where I investigate the impact of different predictors on Spanish subject position and on French clefts from a language-internal and a cross-linguistic perspective.

6 Pragmatic and semantic factors in syntactic variation

6.1 Focus type, Givenness, Argument structure

In Chapter 4, I demonstrated that the alternation between full and elliptical strategies can be explained by the degree of activation of the background proposition. The choice of an elliptical answer over a full one appears closely linked to common ground (CG) management and the principle of linguistic economy. However, this hypothesis does not fully account for why, within the same language, multiple full strategies can coexist. For example, it does not explain the alternation between Spanish postverbal and preverbal subjects, or the variation among different cleft forms in French, such as *c'est, il y a*, or pseudo-clefts, when these structures compete to fulfil the same information-structural function.

Put differently, if different syntactic strategies can express narrow subject focus, what drives their selection? Can linguistic or contextual cues account for both language-internal and cross-linguistic variation? While some authors claim that the alternation among different variants is a matter of “true optionality” (e.g., Akmajian argues that it-clefts and pseudo-clefts “are synonymous, share the same presuppositions, answer the same questions”; Akmajian 1970: 149), others defend the idea that the occurrence of more than one format within the same language is instead regulated by specific factors, some of which, interestingly, overlap for both French and Spanish.

As mentioned in Chapter 2, in Spanish, the alternation between the SV/VS order has been generally attributed to the **type of focus** expressed: while postverbal subjects (VS) would be mostly associated with a non-contrastive reading (information), preverbal subjects (SV) have been generally reported as instances of contrastive or corrective focus (for instance Zubizarreta 1998, Costa 2001, Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006).

Similarly, focus type has been claimed to be responsible also for the alternation among different cleft types in French. De Cesare & Garassino (2015), for instance, state that the semantic distinction between the “exhaustive” and the “listing” interpretation of identificational sentences is syntactically expressed via two differ-

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ent kinds of cleft constructions in spoken French. The exhaustive reading is encoded through the *c'est*-cleft construction (*C'est les enfants qui sont allés à l'école* 'It is the children who went to school'), while the listing reading is expressed via the *il y a*-cleft construction (*Il y a les enfants qui sont allés à l'école* 'There are the children that went to school'). Moreover, such a view is supported by Karssen-berg (2017) in her empirical analysis of *il y a* clefts with a focus-background partition.

Another factor that has been claimed to be relevant for the two languages is the **information status** (givenness) (Firbas 1966, Chafe 1970, Prince 1992) of the subject itself. Givenness refers to "information the speaker believes the listener already knows and accepts as true", and new is "information the speaker believes the listener does not yet know" (Clark & Haviland 1977: 3). As already mentioned in Chapter 1, subjects are generally given entities, usually known by both speaker and hearer, or in some way bridged to one of the interlocutors (e.g., *A friend of mine lives in this district*). Thus, occurrences of new subjects are less frequent in spontaneous speech and, in many languages, receive a special marking. Spanish, for instance, is said to position the subject in the postverbal slot when this is brand-new, while the preverbal position is usually reserved to highly-activated subject referents (Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006). Similarly, it is often claimed that spoken French disallows brand-new subjects in sentence-initial position (also referred to as "bad subjects" in the literature; e.g., Beaver et al. 2005, Karssen-berg 2018c), and resorts to special constructions to avoid uttering the new referent sentence-initially (Lambrecht 2010). *Il y a* clefts, for instance, would be one of these strategies: by means of this particular syntactic construction, the new subject does not appear as the first element uttered, but rather after the verb *avoir*, thus avoiding the sentence-initial placement. Along the same lines, Dufter & Gabriel (2016) argue that "it-clefts are preferred with shorter constituents such as pro-forms, whereas pseudo-clefts more readily accommodate longer, in particular clausal, elements in the clefted position" (Dufter & Gabriel 2016: 24).

Finally, a third relevant factor is the **argument structure** of the verb. As mentioned in Chapter 2, the different thematic roles that different types of verbs assign to their subjects (and objects) are generally said to affect not only the realization of the arguments itself (linking), but also the order in which these arguments appear within the sentence. For instance, Spanish OE-psych verbs, such as *molestar* 'to disturb, to annoy' display a word order where the object (whether direct or indirect) precedes the subject. This is generally attributed to the direct object being an EXPERIENCER, a thematic role with proto-agent properties (Dowty 1991). Similarly, formal syntacticians regularly claim that VS is the most natural word order in sentences containing an unaccusative verb, due

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to the fact that the subject of an unaccusative verb originates in the postverbal position (see, for instance, [Burzio 1986](#), [Rizzi 2013](#), [Belletti 1988](#)). Although the naturalness with which unaccusative verbs allow inversion could be related to the position in which their subjects are projected in syntax, it has been shown that unaccusativity itself does not provide a basis for explaining inversion in languages like Spanish or Italian, at least in the case of “free inversion” (e.g., [Leonetti 2018](#)). Rather, its interaction with the information-structural properties of the sentence is the determining factor.

[Gabriel \(2007\)](#) provides experimental evidence for the interaction between focus and argument structure in Spanish, showing that focused subjects of transitive verbs have a higher likelihood of being realized preverbally (SV) than focused subjects of unaccusatives, where speakers overwhelmingly showed a preference for the postverbal slot. However, this tendency could be reversed when the subject is part of the topical or backgrounded portion of the sentence, causing it to appear at the beginning of the utterance. Gabriel’s experiments demonstrate that the subject’s position is not governed purely by syntactic requirements, but rather by an interaction between pragmatics and syntax.

Importantly, if the link between focus and argument structure has been noted for Spanish and other languages, the same reasoning has never been applied to French. Although certain authors have noted a correlation between certain verb types and certain cleft types (e.g., [Apothéloz 2012](#) on the correlation between pseudo clefts and verbs of saying), such a correlation has never been systematically investigated.

This chapter aims at filling this gap, by investigating the role of the three aforementioned factors in relation to subject focus and how this interaction is reflected in the syntax of both languages. On one hand, the corpus study presented here tests claims previously formulated in the literature, while on the other, it introduces an innovative element to the theory of subject focus by evaluating the influence of verb type in correlation with various cleft constructions. Additionally, it explores potential interactions among the factors discussed above. For instance, it has already been suggested that given subjects tend to appear with transitive verbs, while new subjects are generally accompanied by unaccusatives (e.g., [Du Bois et al. 2003](#)). This raises the question of whether such interactions manifest in the syntax of both languages and whether this association also influences focus-marking constructions.

The chapter is organized as follows: section 5.2 presents the hypothesis of the study; sections 5.3, 5.4, and 5.5 outline the materials and methodology employed in the analysis. Sections 5.6 and 5.7 report the findings from the Spanish dataset, while sections 5.8 and 5.9 focus on the French data. Finally, sections 5.10 and 5.11

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discuss the results and provide a brief summary of the chapter.

6.2 Formulation of the hypothesis

As discussed in the previous section, exhibiting the same IS-function is not a sufficient criterion to account for the co-existence of more than one focus-marking strategy in the same language. Rather, it is necessary to look both within and beyond the utterance to understand what determines speakers' preferences. The results of Chapter 3 revealed that, when it comes to the mapping between IS and syntax, Spanish speakers use mostly word order alternation, while French speakers showed a preference for constructional strategies. Such findings allow the formulation of the following hypothesis:

H2: If focus type, argument structure, and givenness influence the realization of focused subjects in Spanish and French, the impact of these factors will be reflected in the distinct focusing strategies employed by each language:

- In Spanish, in the alternation between *in situ* and postverbal subjects (SV/VS order).
- In French, in the alternation among different cleft types (*c'est*, *il y a*, pseudo).

To test this hypothesis, a corpus study was designed using data extracted from the corpus query in Chapter 3. In this study, each factor was tested individually, followed by an analysis of their interactions with the other predictors.

6.3 Material

The corpus query reported in Chapter 3 revealed 167 occurrences of postverbal subjects and 33 *in situ* subjects for the Spanish side, while 237 clefts have been found in the French data. Among the latter, 109 are *c'est* clefts, 98 are *il y a* clefts and only 13 are pseudo clefts. Since pseudo clefts are too scarce, they have been excluded from the statistical analysis and have been discussed separately. The sentences have been annotated for i) focus type ii) givenness of the subject referent iii) argument structure of the verb. The criteria for the annotation of the three predictors are reported in the following section.

6.4 Criteria for the annotation

6.4.1 Focus type

I adopt mainly Kiss’ (1998) notions of focus types, who distinguishes between “identificational” (exhaustive) and “information” (non-exhaustive) focus (Kiss 1998). However, to avoid confusion with the term “information focus”, already used in Chapter 3,¹ I employ the term **exhaustive focus** to refer to the cases in which the focused subject is selected among a set of alternatives of the same semantic type, thus filling the wh-variable contained in the (implicit or explicit) QUD, and excluding all the other possible alternatives contained in the set. The set itself may be open or closed. Thus, the exhaustive focus type also includes cases of contrastive or corrective foci (Van Leusen 2004, Steube 2001, Repp 2010), in line with Kiss’ (1998) definition. Conversely, the term **not-exhaustive focus** is used for those instances of focused subjects that do not convey exhaustivity, but simply non-presupposed information. In other words, the focused subject that constitutes the answer to the (implicit or explicit) QUD does not automatically exclude the other alternatives of the set.

Table 6.1: Focus types investigated

Exhaustive focus	Not-exhaustive focus
Performs exhaustive identification on a set of entities, and expresses exclusion of other explicitly-given alternatives, either by selection or correction.	Indicates the non-presuppositional nature of the information.
Tag: EXHAUSTIVE	Tag: NOT-EXHAUSTIVE

Similar to the previous corpus studies, each item has been extracted with the QUD it constitutes an answer to, which enables the distinction between different types of foci. Examples in both languages are reported below:

¹Recall that, in Chapter 3, this term indicates any instances of new information filling the wh-element contained in the QUD, whether exhaustive or not, in line with Krifka (2008).

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(1) Spanish

a. Exhaustive Focus

- i. *Y, ¿Tampoco se sabe si han desaparecido o?*
'And, you don't know if they disappeared?'
- ii. *No, yo creo que no han desaparecido las joyas.*
'No, I think that the jewellery didn't disappear.'
- b. *Sólo ha desaparecido [el cuadro]_{FOC}.*
'Only the painting disappeared.' (sgs Spanish, 22/196-198)

b. Not-exhaustive focus

- i. *¿Quién gritaba?*
'Who was screaming?'
- ii. *[La chiquilla]_{FOC}.*
'The little girl.'
- b. *También gritaba [la chica]_{FOC}.*
'Also the girl was screaming.' (sgs Spanish, 17/346-348)

(2) French

a. Exhaustive Focus

- i. *Est-ce que c'est toi qui l'as découvert, ou?*
'Is it you who founds it, or?'
- ii. *Non, c'est [sa femme]_{FOC} qui l'a découvert.*
'No, it is his wife who found him.' (sgs French, 11/29-30)

b. Not-exhaustive focus

- i. *En fait, il y avait qui dans l'immeuble quand ça s'est passé?*
'So, who was in the building when all this happened?'
- ii. *Alors, en fait, il y avait [la grand-mère du dessus]_{FOC} qui était là.*
'So, there was the old lady from upstairs that was there.'
- b. *Il y a [un étudiant au premier étage]_{FOC} qui était là aussi.*
'There was a student on the first floor that was there too.' (sgs French, 9/261-263)

Distinguishing an exhaustive from a not-exhaustive focus type can be a hard task, especially when dealing with spontaneous speech data. Interestingly, some clear-cut cases can be observed as in the case of examples (1) or (2b), where adverbs such as 'only' or 'too' function as clear indicators of semantic exhaustivity or the lack of it, respectively. In other cases, exhaustivity is simply pragmatically

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conveyed by the context.

In line with Destrueel (2012) and others (Horn 1981, Destrueel & DeVaugh-Geiss 2018, De Vaugh-Geiss et al. 2018), I assume that exhaustivity in clefts is not encoded semantically in the construction itself, but rather conveyed pragmatically through contextual cues. For instance, if speaker a asks ‘who lives in the apartment on the second floor?’ and speaker b provides a value for the open variable (e.g., a young couple lives there), I consider that exhaustivity in this case is pragmatically conveyed, because the value provided by b is the only one that satisfies the wh-variable opened by a, and excludes all the other possible alternatives. Some sentences, however, might be compatible with both readings and constitute, in principle, cases of both exhaustive and not-exhaustive focus. To avoid any confusion, such cases were annotated as DOUBT, and subsequently excluded from the analysis. Consider the following example:

- (3) a. *Est-ce que quelqu’un lui devait des sous?*
 ‘Did anyone owe her money?’
- b. *Non, je crois pas, non.*
 ‘Non, I don’t think so, no.’
- a. *Alors si c’est pas une histoire d’argent, si c’est pas histoire de dépression et machin, si c’est pas une histoire d’amant, ça aurait pu être [la femme du locataire]_{FOC}, enfin, qui aurait tué cette personne, parce qu’elle sortait avec son mari.*
 ‘So, if it’s not a matter of money, if it’s not a matter of depression and stuff, if it’s not an affair, it could have been the tenant’s wife who, well, allegedly killed this person because she was dating her husband.’
 (sgs French, 60/284-286)

In (3), speaker a tries to give an answer to the implicit QUD ‘Who is the murderer?’, which is the implicit QUD of the whole game task. However, the value provided in the clefted element (the tenant’s wife) is accompanied by the conditional mood, an indicator that this value may or may not be the only possible alternative for the wh-variable contained in the implicit QUD. This case is somewhat different from a clear-cut exhaustive focus assertion, such as ‘It was the tenant’s wife who killed the victim’. Moreover, there are not enough contextual cues to establish whether the tenant’s wife committed the murder alone, or whether someone else was also involved (in which case it would be a non-exhaustive focus type). Given the presence of the conditional mood indicating probability rather than certainty, and the contextual nature of this assertion, this case has been annotated as DOUBT.

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6.4.2 Givenness of subjects

For the purpose of this study, I use the term givenness to indicate textual givenness, i.e., whether the referent has already been previously introduced in the dialogue or not. An exception to this criterion is the interlocutor (speaker a and speaker b) which are situationally-given referents. Although they have not always been formally introduced in the text, I consider them to be given in the situation. To determine the degree of givenness of the other referents, I distinguished two levels of annotation:

- **GIVEN:** the referent has already been previously mentioned in the text. This is independent of the referential form through which it appears (pronoun, proper name, definite NP). Examples (4) and (5) are provided for the two languages.

(4) Spanish

- a. *Y ¿Nadie avisó al médico entonces?*
'And nobody warned the doctor?'
- b. *[Yo]_{FOC}, cuando me he enterado, rápidamente he llamado al médico.*
'I called the doctor as soon as I realized what happened.' (sgs Spanish, 51/20-21)

(5) French

- a. *Et, est-ce qu' il habite au-dessus des étudiants ou pas du tout?*
'Is he the one living above the students or not at all?'
- b. *Non, en fait.*
'Actually, non.'
- b. *Donc, c'est [Boussicot]_{FOC} qui habite au-dessus des étudiants.*
'So, it's Boussicot who lives above the students.' (sgs French, 19/383-385)

- **NEW:** the subject referent is introduced for the first time in the dialogue. Here again, the criterion for the annotation is independent of the morphological form through which it appears. Although the most frequent way of introducing brand-new referents in the text is through an indefinite determiner, cases of brand-new referents accompanied by a definite NP may also be found. This usually happens when the referent, although being new,

6.4 Criteria for the annotation

is somehow bridged either to one of the interlocutors or one of the other given characters of the story (e.g., the wife). For coherence with the main criterion of the annotation, such cases have also been annotated as NEW. Examples of brand-new referents for the two languages are provided below:

(6) Spanish

- a. *Y, volviendo a las amistades mm del señor, ¿Eran?*
‘And, coming back to the acquaintances of the man, who were they?’
- a. *¿Frecuentaban mucho por aquí estas amistades que usted dice que tenía?*
‘Did they use to come over here, these acquaintances that you say that he had?’
- b. *Bueno, normalmente cambiaban.*
‘Well, they change continuously.’
- b. *Pero en los últimos meses habían venido mucho [dos personas]_{FOC}.*
‘But, lately, two people came more often.’ (sgs Spanish, 2/277-280)

(7) French

- a. *Il y a d’autres voisins qui sont rentrés ou sortis avant?*
‘Are there other people who entered or left the building before this moment?’
- b. *Oui.*
‘Yes.’
- a. *Dites-moi qui, s’il-vous-plaît!*
‘Tell me who, please!’
- b. *Non, posez les questions.*
‘No, ask me specific questions.’
- b. *Donc, en fait, il y a [une femme qui habite au dessus]_{FOC} qui est rentrée aussi.*
‘So, actually, there is a woman who lives upstairs who came back as well.’ (sgs French, 10/332-336)

- HEAVY: in both the French and the Spanish data, a small number of subjects are not entities but clausal subjects (or subject complements), which

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are traditionally considered to be non-referential. Given that the annotation of information status only applies to referential entities, these cases have been excluded from the analysis. An example can be found below:

(8) French

- a. *Et toi, tu as une idée sur la question?*
‘And you, do you have an idea on this matter?’
- a. *Il y avait quelque chose qui te laissait prévoir que ce mec, il pourrait avoir des problèmes, ou?*
‘Was there something that made you think that this man could have problems, or?’
- b. *Moi, ce qui me gênait un peu chez lui c’est [le fait qu’il soit rosicrucien]_{FOC} parce que ça lui apportait des fréquentations un peu louches.*
‘As for me, what bothered me a little bit was that he was a Rosicrucian, because he had dubious acquaintances.’ (sgs French, 78/255-257)

It is worth noting, though, that these cases are almost exclusively found in French pseudo clefts, in line with the literature that associates this cleft type with long, heavy subjects (Blanche-Benveniste et al. 1990, Roubaud 1997, Calude 2009).

An important consideration has to be made for the cases of “bridging”. The concept was initially introduced by the work of Clark & Haviland (1977) to refer to the following expression: “we bought some food for the picnic. The beer was warm”. To interpret the expression “the beer”, the reader has to find a referent not clearly expressed in the previous discourse, but can be inferred from what is given already. Here, although it is not explicitly said that we bought some beer for the picnic, the first assumption is that we did, and the beer mentioned in the second part of the utterance is included in the food which the speaker bought. What is involved in the interpretation of utterance such as this is not only encoding and decoding of syntactic and semantic information, but also pragmatic inferences to identify the intended referent of the definite noun phrase in the second sentence.

Thus, bridged referents are typically regarded as a subset of given entities. However, in my analysis, I do not categorize bridging cases as such due to the specific context of the dialogues. Given that the murder scene takes place in a particular building and the interviewer is the building’s doorman, many – if not all – of the

6.4 Criteria for the annotation

referents mentioned in the interviews can be seen as bridged in one way or another. For example, tenants, their relatives, and friends are inherently connected to the building and thus serve as bridged referents.

To avoid this underspecification, I adopt a textual rather than a pragmatic notion of +/- givenness. This means that referents are annotated as given if they have been previously mentioned in the text (the interview) and as new if they appear for the first time, regardless of whether their referring expression is phrased as “his mother, his friend, the neighbour from above, etc.”.

6.4.3 Argument structure

Historically, the notion of argument structure is based on the recognition that there are no consistent semantic correlates to grammatical relations (in particular, subjects and objects) (Waltereit 2017). The semantic contribution made by the subject can vary according to the argument structure of the verb it accompanies. The literature (Hale & Keyser 2002, Levin & Rappaport Hovav 2005) recognizes three basic types of verbs: transitives, unergatives and unaccusatives. Transitive verbs are those that take two arguments, a subject and a direct object (DO). Typically, the subject of transitive verbs has agentive properties. It is an AGENT because it functions as the initiator or causer of the action described by the verb. The direct object, on the other hand, has patient properties. It is the THEME or CAUSEE that is affected by the main action described by the verb (see Dowty 1991 for further discussion on the properties of the AGENT and PATIENT thematic-roles).

The second type of verb is the intransitive verb, which occurs only with a single argument, the subject. Intransitives can be further differentiated between two kinds: unergative and unaccusative (Perlmutter 1978). Whereas unaccusatives select a subject with theme properties, unergatives take agentive subjects. Thus, while in sentences containing a prototypical transitive verb, the subject is generally considered an AGENT, unaccusative verbs do not assign any agentive properties to their only argument (the subject), giving it instead the theta-role of THEME. Similarly, in subject-experiencer psychological verbs (e.g., *amar* ‘to love’ in Spanish), the subject is an EXPERIENCER, while in OE-psychological verbs (e.g., *preocupar* ‘to worry’), the subject is generally a STIMULUS or, in some analyses, a THEME (see, for instance, Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006).

The annotation of argument structure conducted here does not follow strictly the theta-role criterion, but simply the number and type of arguments that each verb selects. For instance, verbs like *matar a alguien* ‘to kill somebody’ and *conocer a alguien* ‘to get to know somebody’ both select a subject and a direct object. From

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the theta-role perspective, however, it is possible to make a distinction between the agentivity cline of the subject in *matar* ‘to kill’ and the subject in *conocer* ‘to get to know’.

Based on the classification made in Dowty (1991), the difference would lie in the fact that, in the former case, subject and object display a clear-cut agent-patient asymmetry, while in the latter case, this asymmetry is somewhat blurred, because the object contains some proto-agent properties as well. For the purpose of my analysis, these fine-grained distinctions have not been taken into account. Rather, I have conducted a classification in “macro-categories”, based on the fact that both verbs select a subject and a direct object, albeit with slightly different degrees of agentivity. Thus, verbs like *conocer* ‘to know someone’ and *matar* ‘to kill’ have been both annotated as transitives, disregarding the micro-differences in their agentivity level. Within the sentences investigated, 5 different verb types have been identified:

- TRANSITIVE VERBS: two-placed verbs selecting a subject and a direct object, where the subject is generally the AGENT and the DO is generally the PATIENT (e.g., SP: *encontrar* ‘to find’; *conocer* ‘to get to know’; *llamar* ‘to call’; *avisar* ‘to warn’, etc.; FR: *tuer* ‘to kill’; *retrouver* ‘to find’; *découvrir* ‘to find out’; *prévenir* ‘to warn’; *ouvrir* ‘to open’; *appeler* ‘to call’, etc.).
- UNACCUSATIVE VERBS: verbs selecting a single argument, the subject, who does not exhibit any agentive properties. It is generally considered to be a THEME (e.g., SP: *llegar* ‘to arrive’; *venir* ‘to come’, *vivir* ‘to live’, *entrar* ‘to come in’, etc. FR: *venir* ‘to come’; *aller* ‘to go’; *habiter* ‘to live’; *mourir* ‘to die’; *arriver* ‘to arrive’, etc.).
- UNERGATIVE VERBS: based on the classification made by Mendikoetxea (1999) for Spanish and Legendre (1989) for French, unergatives are verbs that select only one argument, the subject, which, unlike unaccusatives verbs, exhibits proto-agent properties (eg. SP: *gritar* ‘to yell’; *quejarse* ‘to complain’; *trabajar* ‘to work’, etc. FR: *agir* ‘to act’; *se plaindre* ‘to complain’).
- OE-PSYCH VERBS: like transitive (or also ditransitive) verbs, object-experiencer psych two-placed verbs are verbs that select a subject and a direct or an indirect object. The peculiarity of these verbs is that the (direct or indirect) object has the thematic role of EXPERIENCER, while the subject is the STIMULUS or, for some authors (cf. Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006), the THEME (e.g., SP: *gustar* ‘to like’; *molestar* ‘to bother’; FR: *frapper* ‘to struck’; *étonner* ‘to surprise’; *marquer* ‘to impress’).

6.5 Methodology

- COPULAR VERBS: copular verbs or simply copulas and attributes (e.g., SP: *ser unas ocho personas* ‘to be more or less eight people’; FR: *être un ami* ‘to be a friend’, *devenir* ‘to become’).

Some problematic cases are due to the polysemy of the verb *être* ‘to be’ in French. Although these types of verbs are generally used as copulas and accompanied by attributes, some speakers employ them in place of other verbs, such as *habiter* ‘to live’ (e.g., *Il y a une femme qui est au troisième étage* ‘there is a woman living on the third floor’).

In this case, it is possible to observe a mismatch between the lexical semantics of the verb and the pragmatic use that speakers make of it. In other words, the verb *être* does not convey the original meaning of ‘to be’ but ‘to live’. Given the lack of attributes, from an argument structure point of view, these cases behave more as unaccusative verbs than as copulas. Thus, they have been annotated as UNACCUSATIVES.

6.5 Methodology

In the first part of the analysis, I conducted descriptive statistics in order to investigate the simple effect of each independent variable (focus type, subject-givenness and argument structure) on the dependent variable of each language (occurrences of SV/VS for Spanish, and of *c’est/il y a* clefts for French). In experimental settings, each participant is generally required to produce one single observation for every stimulus. This guarantees that the assumption of statistical independence is not violated. Independence means that the value of one observation does not influence or affect the value of other observations. Independent data items are thus not connected with one another in any way. Conversely, non-independent observations introduce bias and can make statistical tests give false positives. Since my analysis builds on interviews where one participant can produce more than one single occurrence of subject focus, the independence assumption cannot be respected. This implies that, since the same speaker can utter more than one critical item, data produced by the same speaker are expected to show similarities.

To provide a solution for this problem and demonstrate the significance of the results, I conducted inferential statistics as well. Statistical inference uses data from a sample of individuals to reach conclusions about the whole population. Inferential statistics were carried out by running a generalized linear mixed-effects model with the answer type as a dependent variable. As random intercepts, I included the interview number, which corresponds to each speaker. Including the

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interview number allowed me to check whether there are any possible clusters in the data, and hence if the results are statistically significant.

In the second part of the analysis, I investigated different levels of interactions. As a first step, I analysed the interaction between argument structure and givenness of the subject, to check whether the interaction of the two factors increases or decreases the probability to choose one syntactic construction or the other. It is generally acknowledged that given subjects tend to appear with transitive verbs, while new subjects are generally accompanied by unaccusatives (e.g., the “Preferred Argument Structure” (PAS), Du Bois et al. 2003). Since this hypothesis has already been formulated in the literature, analysing the interaction between the verb type and the information status of the subject referent is mostly a confirmatory study. Subsequently, I investigated the interaction among my three predictors. Unlike the previous interaction, I do not have a specific hypothesis for this part of the study. Therefore, the three-way interaction has an exploratory, rather than confirmatory, nature. All significance tests were analysed using the `lme4` package (Bates et al. 2015) in R (CoreTeam 2019). The model converged in all the cases analysed except for one (in the Spanish data set, the main effect of focus type on cleft type). For this case, I ran logistic regression instead, and did not include the random intercept.² In the following sections, I report the results of the main effects and the interaction effects for each language.

6.6 Spanish subject position: results

In this section, the results of the influence of each factor on Spanish subject position are reported and discussed. As already announced in Chapter 3, the tag IN SITU indicates the case in which the subject precedes the verb, while sentences where the subject follows the verb are tagged as POSTVERBAL. The analysis has been carried out with 200 items, among which are 33 *in situ* subjects and 167 postverbal subjects. Since the two subject positions have a different distribution in the corpus, with *in situ* being scarce, statistical tests have been conducted in order to check the significance of the findings.

6.6.1 Focus type and subject position

Table 9 shows the influence of focus type on subject position. It is possible to observe that among the 33 *in situ* subjects, 82% (n=27) encode exhaustivity, while

²A closer look at the counts of each interview revealed that the model did not converge because of the elevated number of interviews containing only 1 observation per interview.

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only 18% (n=6) are not exhaustive. Similarly, in the case of the 167 postverbal subjects, 72% (n=119) express exhaustive foci and only 28% (n=46) are of the not-exhaustive type. Thus, with both preverbal and postverbal subjects, there is a clear tendency to express exhaustivity rather than the lack of it. Of the 200 items, 3 subject items have been annotated as DOUBT due to the impossibility to establish the type of focus they convey, and have excluded from the analysis.

Table 6.2: Spanish subject position by focus type

	in situ	postverbal
exhaustive	27	118
not-exhaustive	6	46

The results of the mixed-effects model show that the effect of focus type on the variable answer type is not statistically significant (estimate = 0.59, SE = 0.58, p-value > 0.05). Exhaustivity is generally conveyed through contextual cues, even though it is possible to find cases with focus particles such as *sólo* or *solamente* ‘only’, which help in the interpretation of the sentence. Similarly, not-exhaustive foci are either pragmatically inferable from the context or semantically conveyed through additive particles, such as *también* ‘too’. A closer look at the data reveals that, among the 27 exhaustive preverbal subjects, 17 express new, exhaustive information and 10 contrast. As for postverbal subjects, contrast is encoded in only 12 out of 119 exhaustive focus items, which indicates that, in comparison, contrast seems to be more frequently expressed by *in situ* subjects than by postverbal ones.

Apart from contrast, focus type, or more precisely exhaustivity, does not seem to be a decisive factor in explaining speakers’ choice between preverbal or postverbal subjects in subject focus realization. Thus, according to this data, there is no observable clear-cut correlation between focus type and answer type in the Spanish data set.

6.6.2 Givenness and subject position

In Table 10, the number of answer types by givenness of the subject referent are reported. Of the 200 items, 1 postverbal subject was tagged as HEAVY, and hence excluded from the counts. Among the 33 *in situ* subjects, 70% (n= 23) are previously-mentioned subjects and 30% (n=10) are brand-new entities, whereas among the 166 postverbal items, 37% (n=62) are given and 63% (n=103) are new.

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Confidence intervals indicate that the percentage differences between *in situ* and postverbal items in both the GIVEN and the NEW condition are significant. Additionally, the results of the mixed-effects model show that the effect of information status on answer type is statistically significant (estimate = 1.80, SE = 0.51, p-value < 0.001).

Table 6.3: Subject position by givenness

	given	new
in situ	23	10
postverbal	61	103

Unlike the case of focus type, here it is possible to see a clear correlation between the information status of the referent and the type of answer chosen by speakers. The two answer types seem to be the mirror image of each other in this respect, showing opposite tendencies: *in situ* subjects co-occur preferentially with given entities while postverbal subjects do so with new ones. The correlation between givenness and subject position is noticeable when the subject is new, with 103 out of 166 cases illustrating this tendency. This is not surprising, since previous studies have already identified a tendency for new subjects to appear in non-canonical positions, while highly-activated referents generally appear preverbally (see Chapter 2).

A closer look at the data reveals that newness can be conveyed under different forms: while the most common referring expression is an indefinite NP (e.g., *un señor importante* ‘an important man’), cases where a new subject is expressed by a definite NP can also be found:

- (9) a. *¿Quién ha fallecido?*
 ‘Who died?’
- b. *Ha fallecido [la chica del segundo]_{FOC}.*
 ‘The girl from the second floor died.’ (sgs Spanish, 08/30-31)

In (9), the referent contained in the answer *la chica del segundo* ‘the girl from the second floor’ is a referent that has not previously mentioned in the discourse. Recall that the interviewer is also the doorman of the building in which the (alleged) murder has been committed. In the dialogue in (9), speaker a, who has been informed of a murder, asks who has died. Speaker b introduces the referent for the first time by using a definite NP. It could be argued that this choice is

6.6 Spanish subject position: results

motivated by the fact that *la chica del segundo* is somehow contextually-bridged by the situation (i.e., the building). Looking further up in the context, in any case, it is clear that the referent has not been introduced before, and is therefore new. Among the given entities, on the other hand, it is possible to find a majority of pronouns and definite NPs. The fact that “light” linguistic elements, such as pronouns, are mostly associated with the preverbal position is also not surprising (see section 5.1 of the present Chapter). Thus, so far the results seem to reflect tendencies already discussed in the literature with respect to the interplay between syntax and information status.

6.6.3 Argument structure and subject position

Table 11 reports the proportions of answer choice by verb type (or argument structure). Among the 200 items, the graph shows a majority of unaccusative verbs (n=123), followed by transitive verbs (n=49), some OE-psychological verbs (n=14), a few unergative verbs (n=11) and only 3 copular verbs. In this case, the absolute frequencies are presented, rather than the relative ones. As for the distribution between preverbal and postverbal subjects, the strongest observable association is between unaccusative verbs and postverbal subjects (69%, n=110), while some cases of postverbal with transitives (18%, n=31), OE-psychs (7%, n=14), unergatives (4%, n=9) and copular (2%, n=3) can also be found. *In situ*, on the other hand, appear to be transitive (55%, n=18), unaccusative (40%, n=13) and unergative (5%, n=2). Statistical tests showed that the effect of verb type on the position of the subject is again significant (estimate = 1.90, SE = 0.54, p-value < 0.001).

Table 6.4: Spanish subject position by argument structure

	copular	OE_psych	transitive	unaccusative	unergative
in situ (n=33)	0	0	18	13	2
postverbal (n=167)	3	14	31	110	9

Although a slight preference can be observed for preverbal subjects in the case of transitive verbs, this tendency is not as clear-cut as in the case of unaccusatives and postverbal subjects. Thus, preverbal foci seem to combine with both monoargumental and transitive verbs, while no case has been found in correlation to OE-psychological verbs or copular ones. The fact that unaccusatives combine with postverbal subjects is again not surprising, as this tendency has

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already been observed for several Romance languages (see section 5.1).

It is interesting to note, however, that this is more a tendency rather than a deterministic correlation, as some cases of preverbal subjects can also be found with unaccusatives. A closer look at the 13 cases of preverbal subjects with unaccusative verbs reveals that there is an almost equal distribution between contrastive ($n=6$) and non-contrastive foci ($n=7$), showing that contrast alone cannot be responsible for this correlation.

6.7 Multifactorial analysis: interaction of predictors for the Spanish dataset

This section presents the results of the multifactorial analysis conducted on the Spanish and French datasets. Section 5.7.1 examines the interaction between verb type and different degrees of givenness, while Section 5.7.2 extends the analysis by including exhaustivity as a factor. Although the limited size of the data does not permit strong generalizations, the statistical results suggest a correlation between postverbal position and the combination of unaccusativity with subject newness, in line with tendencies already noted in the literature (e.g., PAS, Du Bois et al. 2003).

6.7.1 Two-factor interaction: verb type and givenness

This section explores the interaction between verb type and the givenness of the subject referent, aiming to confirm or reject the hypothesis, widely discussed in the literature, that given subjects tend to occur with transitive verbs, whereas new subjects are generally associated with unaccusatives (PAS, Du Bois et al. 2003). The goal is to determine whether these tendencies are reflected in the syntactic structure of the language when subject focus is expressed. As previously noted, unergative verbs, OE-psychs, and copular verbs were too infrequent to be included in the statistical analysis and were therefore excluded. Consequently, the interaction between verb type and givenness generates four possible conditions: GIVEN-TRANSITIVE', GIVEN-UNACCUSATIVE', NEW-TRANSITIVE', and NEW-UNACCUSATIVE'.

To assess whether the interaction effects are statistically significant, I performed a logistic mixed-effects model analysis, with the choice of answer as the dependent variable, including the interview number as a random effect.

Figure 5 shows the results for the Spanish data set. The data reveals that among 39 given-transitives, 36% ($n=14$) are *in situ* subjects, while 64% ($n=25$) are postverbal; the given-unaccusative interaction resulted in 30 items, 27% ($n=8$) of which

6.7 Multifactorial analysis: interaction of predictors for the Spanish dataset

are *in situ* subjects and 73% (n=22) postverbal ones. In the new-transitive combination, it is possible to find 10 items, 40% (n=4) of which are *in situ* and 60% (n=6) of which are postverbal. Finally, the combination of new and unaccusatives was found to be the most frequent one, with a total of 91 items, 6% (n=5) of which are *in situ* and 94% (n=86) are postverbal. A mixed-effects model showed that the interaction effect of the two variables on answer type is statistically significant for this Spanish data set (estimate = 2.40, SE = 1.15, p-value < 0.05).

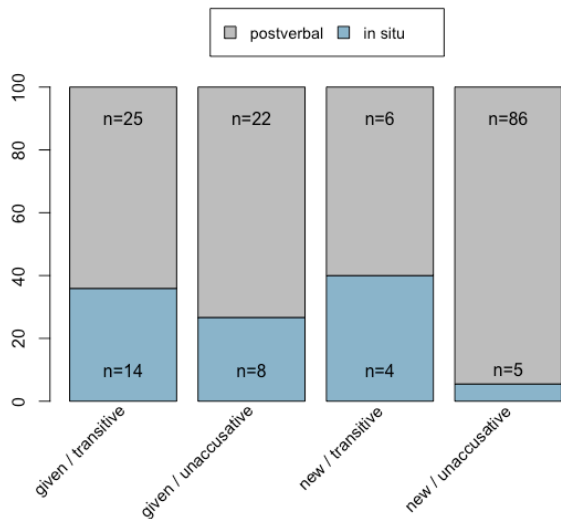


Figure 6.1: Interaction of givenness and argument structure

By comparing the proportions of *in situ* subjects, it is possible to observe a rather homogeneous distribution in the given-unaccusative, new-unaccusative and new-transitive conditions, while almost the half of *in situ* (14 out of 31³) contain transitive verbs with given subjects.

The comparison of the distributions of postverbal subjects in the different conditions, on the other hand, results in a much clearer tendency: if no significant difference can be observed between the shares of postverbal subjects in the given-transitives (n=25) and given-unaccusative (n=22) conditions, only 6 out of 139 postverbal subjects⁴ were found in the new-transitive condition, while the vast

³Recall that 31 represents the totality of *in situ* subjects without the items containing unergatives.

⁴The totality of postverbal subjects containing transitive and unaccusative verbs was originally 141 (see Table 11) However, only 139 have been used to conduct the analysis reported in Figure 5, since 2 items have been annotated as doubt.

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majority (n=86) belongs to the new-unaccusative interaction. Thus, if the subject is given, its interaction with either a transitive or an accusative verb does not lead to significant differences in the choice of the answer type. Conversely, if the subject is new, the effect of verb type is clearly visible, and the presence of new entities accompanied by unaccusative verbs strongly enhances the likelihood that speakers will choose a postverbal subject.

6.7.2 Three-factor interaction

This section explores the interactions among all three predictors. Unlike the two-factor interaction, no specific hypothesis has been formulated here. Rather, this part aims at simply exploring how different focus types interact with the other two factors. The analysis has been conducted in R (CoreTeam 2019). However, due to the scarcity of the data, it was not possible to carry out inferential statistics on this data set.⁵

Table 6.5: Interaction of focus type, verb type and information status.

Focus type	Verb type	Information status	In situ	Postverbal
exhaustive	transitive	given	14	25
		new	3	3
	unaccusative	given	7	19
		new	2	60
not-exhaustive	transitive	given	0	0
		new	1	3
	unaccusative	given	1	3
		new	3	26
Total			31	139

Table 12 presents the results for the interaction of exhaustive vs. non-exhaustive focus, verb types, and the subject’s information status, with raw counts indicated. As shown, many combinations yielded very few items, and some produced none

⁵Because of the few items that would result from each interaction, a mixed-effects model would not have converged. Thus, no random effect has been added to this analysis, and the statistics have been carried out descriptively.

6.8 French cleft types: results

at all. For example, there are no occurrences of non-exhaustive foci with transitive verbs and given subjects. The most frequent pattern is the association between unaccusative verbs and new subjects, a finding consistent with previous analyses. Additionally, in both exhaustive and non-exhaustive conditions, this combination often results in postverbal subjects. Thus, unaccusatives paired with new subjects tend to appear as postverbal, regardless of the focus type. The interaction with exhaustivity seems irrelevant in this regard. For the remaining conditions, some combinations produced as few as three items, with others having only one or no observations. As a result, comparisons between these conditions and the focus type interaction are not feasible. In summary, the analysis does not permit significant conclusions due to the limited data.

The next section presents the results for the French dataset. As with Spanish, I first examine the individual effects of each predictor before addressing their interactions.

6.8 French cleft types: results

In this section, I present and discuss the findings from the French dataset, following the same structure as the Spanish results. I first examine the correlation between answer type and focus type, followed by information status, and finally, argument structure. As mentioned earlier, the corpus query in Chapter 3 revealed 220 clefts: 109 are *c'est* clefts (tagged C'EST), 98 are *il y a* clefts (tagged IL Y A), and only 13 are pseudo clefts. Due to their scarcity, pseudo clefts are not represented in the graphs but are discussed separately based on their properties.

6.8.1 Focus type and cleft type

Among the 109 *c'est* clefts, 1 was annotated as DOUBT and thus excluded from the analysis. As shown in Table 13, of the remaining 108 *c'est* clefts, 99% (n=107) express exhaustive focus, while only 1% (n=1) belongs to the non-exhaustive focus type. Regarding the *il y a* format, out of 98 *il y a* clefts, 34% (n=33) are exhaustive, while almost twice as many (66%, n=65) are non-exhaustive foci. Logistic regression showed a significant main effect of focus type on cleft type (estimate = 5.43, std. error = 1.03, $p < 0.001$).⁶

The graph shows a clear-cut correlation between focus type and cleft type, where *c'est* clefts encode almost exclusively an exhaustive focus type, while the

⁶I attempted a mixed-effects model, but it did not converge in this case. Therefore, I simplified the analysis by eliminating the random intercept and using a logistic regression instead. As a result, the significance of the effect should be interpreted with caution.

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Table 6.6: Cleft type by focus type

	<i>c'est</i>	<i>il y a</i>
exhaustive	107	33
not-exhaustive	6	65

majority of *il y a* clefts express not-exhaustive focus, even though some cases of exhaustivity can also be found. In this respect, there seems to be a “division of labour” between *c'est* and *il y a* clefts in encoding focus type. Among the 107 *c'est* clefts associated with an exhaustive interpretation, 43 express contrast, while the majority encode new exhaustive information. The number of contrastive foci associated with *il y a* clefts, on the other hand, was extremely low (2 out of 33), suggesting that there might be a tendency for contrast to be expressed almost exclusively by *c'est* clefts. Similar to Spanish, exhaustivity or not-exhaustivity in French can be understood from contextual cues or conveyed by the presence of exclusive or additive focus particles, such as *seulement* ‘only’ or *aussi* ‘too’, respectively. Examples are provided in (10) (already reported in Chapter 2) and (11):

- (10) *C'est seulement [moi]_{FOC} ensuite qui suis venue frapper pour la prévenir.*
‘It is only me, afterwards, who came to warn her.’ (sgs French, 38/187)
- (11) *Bon, c'est vrai qu'il y avait [ce gars]_{FOC} aussi qui venait là, depuis deux, trois semaines là, qui venait assez régulièrement.*
‘Well, it is true that there was this guy who, since 2 or 3 weeks, was coming over pretty regularly.’ (sgs French, 77/366)

The presence of focus particles like *only* in association with a *c'est* cleft also supports the view that exhaustivity is conveyed pragmatically rather than semantically in clefts, aligning with the findings of [Destruel \(2012\)](#) and others ([Horn 1981](#), [De Veugh-Geiss et al. 2018](#)). In other words, the cleft construction itself does not inherently result in an exhaustive interpretation of the focused element. If the syntactic form alone were sufficient to convey exhaustivity, the use of exclusivity particles would be redundant, as noted by [Dufter \(2009\)](#). Similarly, if *il y a* clefts were strictly associated with a non-exhaustive reading, we would not expect to find additive particles like *too* appearing with these constructions. Instead, the data suggests that the implicature of exhaustivity is cancellable and that its cancelability does not affect the truth-conditional value of the utterance.

6.8.2 Givenness and cleft type

Table 14 shows the relation between the subject’s information status and the type of cleft chosen by French speakers. The data shows that, among the 109 *c’est* clefts, 90% (n=98) contain a previously-mentioned subject referent, while 10% (n=11) contain a brand-new one. Conversely, among the 98 *il y a* clefts, 86% (n=84) contains a new subject, while only 14% (n=14) are associated with a given entity. The mixed-effects model shows that the association between information status and cleft type is statistically significant (estimate = 12.4, std. error = 2.4, $p < 0.001$).

Table 6.7: Cleft type by givenness

	<i>c’est</i>	<i>il y a</i>
given	98	14
new	11	84

Once again, there seems to be a clear-cut correlation between information status and cleft type, where *c’est* clefts encode mostly given subjects, while *il y a* clefts encode new ones. This tendency is rather striking and, as the table shows, *c’est* and *il y a* clefts seem to be the “mirror image” of each other in encoding different degrees of activation of the subject.

This result is not surprising *per se*: previous studies (Lambrecht 1988, De Cesare & Garassino 2015, Karssenbergh 2017) have already identified an asymmetry in the type of referent focalized by the two cleft types in their analyses. *Il y a* clefts have commonly been associated with the introduction of brand-new referents in discourse. For instance, Lambrecht (2000) notes that *il y a* clefts serve as a syntactic strategy to comment on newly introduced referents—essentially adding new information—resulting in an all-focus interpretation (following the “Principle of Separation of Role and Referents” Lambrecht 1994: 185). The data from the present corpus show that *il y a* clefts continue to encode new subjects, even when a focus-background partition is present, with the relative clause providing information already shared in the CG. Interestingly, both *c’est* and *il y a* clefts exhibit tendencies that are probabilistic rather than deterministic. While *c’est* clefts are more frequently associated with given subjects, they are occasionally used with brand-new subjects as well, though less commonly. Conversely, although *il y a* clefts predominantly occur with new subjects, given entities do appear too. Furthermore, a closer look at the data reveals that, as in Spanish, there is no one-

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to-one correspondence between newness/givenness and a specific referring expression. New subjects may be expressed through indefinite NPs (e.g., *une vieille dame* ‘an old lady’) but can also appear as definite NPs (e.g., *la jeune femme* ‘the young woman’). Notably, the association between *il y a* clefts and personal pronouns is entirely absent from this dataset, whereas personal pronouns dominate the referring expressions associated with *c’est* clefts, followed by definite NPs and some proper names (e.g., *Madame Nuding*). In conclusion, while information status seems to play a decisive role in cleft type selection in French, the strong correlation between information status and cleft format does not exclude the possibility that the same cleft type may be linked to varying degrees of activation of the subject referent. These confirmatory results validate the data and emphasize the plausibility of the new findings presented in this chapter.

6.8.3 Argument structure and cleft type

This section reports the proportion of cleft types by the argument structure of the verb they are associated with. Table 15 shows that both *c’est* and *il y a* can be associated with different verb types, even though some clear-cut tendencies can be observed: among the 109 *c’est* clefts, 84% (n=91) are associated with transitive verbs, 15% (n=17) with unaccusative verbs and only 1% (n=1) with unergative verbs. Conversely, among the 98 *il y a* clefts, 6% (n=6) are transitives, 90% (n=88) are unaccusatives and 4% (n=4) are unergatives. Thus, the strongest association can be observed between *c’est* clefts and transitive verbs and *il y a* clefts and unaccusatives. A mixed-effects model showed once again that the effect of verb type on the kind of cleft chosen by French speakers is statistically significant (estimate = 5.17, SE = 1.07, p-value < 0.001).

Table 6.8: Cleft type by argument structure

	copular	OE-psych	transitive	unaccusative	unergative
<i>c’est</i>	0	0	91	17	1
<i>il y a</i>	0	0	6	88	4

As already mentioned in the introduction of the present chapter, the literature on the association between argument structure and verb type is extremely scarce. These findings are, therefore, a novel contribution to the topic. The results reveal that, also in the case of argument structure, *c’est* and *il y a* clefts stand in opposition to each other with respect to the type of verb they contain. Unergative

6.9 Multifactorial analysis: interaction of predictors for the French dataset

verbs appear to be slightly favoured by *il y a* clefts, even though their number is too infrequent to formulate any generalization. Among transitives, particularly frequent are verbs like *retrouver* ‘to find’, *trouver* ‘to find’, *découvrir* ‘to discover’, while from the unaccusative side, *habiter* ‘to live’, *vivre* ‘to live’, along with motion verbs such as *arriver* ‘to arrive’, *partir* ‘to go’ or *monter* ‘to go up’ are the ones more frequently used. The high frequency of these lexical verbs is most probably due to the specificity of the game task used to collect the corpus: recall that the interviewee has to pretend to solve a fictional murder case that occurred in a building. Questions like ‘Who went up/down?’ or ‘Who found the body?’ are unsurprisingly common for both languages. Nevertheless, the association between transitives and *c’est*, on the one hand, and unaccusatives and *il y a*, on the other, shows that the predictor ARGUMENT STRUCTURE is decisive in accounting for cleft format choice. It is surprising, therefore, that it has never been systematically investigated.

6.9 Multifactorial analysis: interaction of predictors for the French dataset

As with the Spanish data, a multifactorial analysis was conducted for different types of French clefts. Sections 5.9.1 and 5.9.2 present the results of the two-factor and three-factor interactions, respectively. While the model did not reveal any statistically significant interactions, certain tendencies can nevertheless be observed. Given subjects of transitive verbs occur more frequently with *c’est*-cleft sentences, whereas new subjects of unaccusative verbs show a stronger association with the *il y a*-type.

6.9.1 Two-factor interaction

Figure 6 shows the findings for the interaction of the two variables in the French data. The data reveals that the most frequent combination is between given subjects and transitive verbs, resulting in 84 items, 98% (n=82) of which are *c’est* clefts, while only 2% (n=2) are *il y a* clefts. In the given-unaccusative condition, 26 items can be found, among which 54% (n=14) are *c’est* and 46% (n=12) are *il y a*. The combination between new and transitives resulted in 12 items, of which 67% (n=8) are *c’est* and 33% (N=4) are *il y a*. Finally, among the 79 items found in the new-unaccusative condition, 4% (n=3) are *c’est* and 96% (n=76) are *il y a* clefts. Mixed model effects showed that the interaction effect of the two variables on

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cleft type is not statistically significant for the French dataset (estimate = 2.58, SE = 4.30, p-value = 0.549).⁷

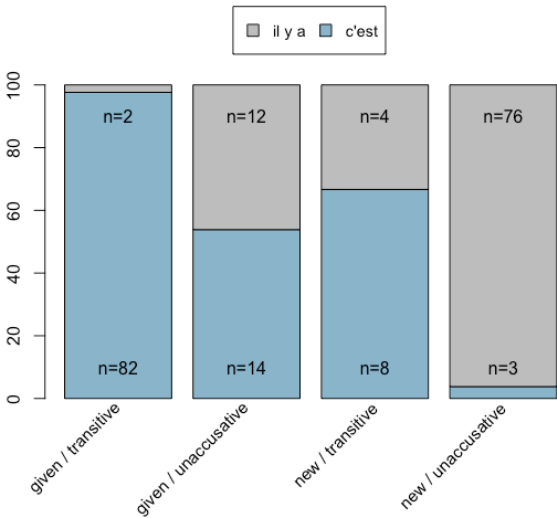


Figure 6.2: Interaction of givenness and argument structure

Although the model showed no significant interaction effect, observable correlations can still be identified. The given-transitive combination strongly favours the use of a *c'est* cleft, while the new-unaccusative interaction results in a notable majority of *il y a* clefts. In the other two conditions, such tendencies are not as pronounced. When we consider condition 1 (given-transitive) and condition 4 (new-unaccusative), *c'est* and *il y a* clefts appear to behave in opposing ways once again. As demonstrated in earlier sections of this chapter, there exists a “division of labour” between the two constructions regarding their association with verb types and varying degrees of activation of the subject referent. This section further illustrates that, even when these factors are combined, the preference for a specific cleft format remains robust.

⁷The fact that the interaction effect is not significant indicates that, regardless of whether the subject is given or new, there are consistently more cases of *c'est* clefts with transitive verbs than with unaccusative verbs. Thus, the impact of verb type remains approximately the same across both given and new information statuses.

6.9 Multifactorial analysis: interaction of predictors for the French dataset

6.9.2 Three-factor interaction

The raw counts presented in Table 16 indicate that some interactions resulted in very few (or no) items, a trend already noted in the Spanish dataset. Nonetheless, it is evident that speakers produced a high number of *c'est* clefts with an exhaustive focus type, a transitive verb, and a given subject.⁸ Conversely, in the non-exhaustive condition, there is a considerable number of *il y a* clefts associated with unaccusative verbs and new subjects.

Given the scarcity of data in the other combinations, it is challenging to determine whether the interaction with focus type significantly impacts the cleft format, assuming all other conditions are equal. For instance, the transitive-given/new association cannot be compared across the exhaustive and not-exhaustive conditions due to the limited items produced. However, when the verb is unaccusative and the subject is new, there appears to be a tendency to favour the *il y a* cleft, regardless of the type of focus encoded (whether exhaustive or not). Thus, similar to the findings in Spanish, this part of the analysis does not provide clear evidence of whether exhaustivity, in conjunction with the other two predictors, influences cleft choice.

Table 6.9: Interaction focus type, verb type and information status

Focus type	Verb type	Information status	<i>c'est</i>	<i>il y a</i>
exhaustive	transitive	given	81	1
		new	8	1
	unaccusative	given	14	6
		new	3	22
not-exhaustive	transitive	given	1	1
		new	0	3
	unaccusative	given	0	6
		new	0	54
Total			107	94

6.9.3 Pseudo clefts

As mentioned previously, due to its scarcity (n=13), pseudo clefts were deemed unsuitable for a statistical analysis with multiple factors or for the formulation

⁸Recall that the total of *c'est* clefts analysed here is 107 (not 108), because 1 item had been annotated as “doubt” regarding its +/- exhaustivity, see section 5.8.1.

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of any type of generalization. Therefore, they were excluded from the previous tables. Nevertheless, a qualitative analysis of these structures reveals interesting insights that are discussed in the present section. Pseudo clefts are discussed in the literature as focus-marking devices associated with specific features, such as syntactic weight of the focused element, containing mostly verbs expressing evaluations, feelings, attitudes, personal opinions or saying verbs (Apothéloz 2012). Structurally, they exhibit the opposite configuration to *c'est* clefts, in that the background material contained in the relative clause is generally found at the beginning of the utterance, while the clefted element appears at the end. This structural peculiarity has been claimed to be the reason why these constructions often appear with “heavy”, long subjects in the clefted element.

Cross-linguistically, there is a tendency to avoid placing heavy elements (e.g., clausal subjects) at the beginning of the sentence, and pseudo clefts, due to their configuration, have been reported as an optimal strategy to place the focalized “heavy” element later in the structure (Prince 1978, Blanche-Benveniste et al. 1990, Roubaud 2000, Calude 2009, Apothéloz 2012).

Comparing these observations with the items found in the corpus, it is possible to observe that, indeed, pseudo clefts follow this pattern. The type of subject contained in the clefted element is almost exclusively (in 12 out of 13 cases) a syntactically “heavy” subject, generally a clausal subject, evidence of what has been previously discussed about these constructions. Only 1 out of 13 cases has been found to contain a subject referent:

- (12) a. *Tu peux aller l'interroger.*
 ‘You could interrogate her.’
 a. *Elle aura sûrement des trucs à te dire.*
 ‘She will have for sure things to say.’
 b. *Non, moi, ce qui m'intéresse bien, donc, c'est [son mari]_{FOC}.*
 ‘No, me, what interests me the most it's her husband.’ (sgs French, 77/249-251)

The occurrences found in the corpus exhibit a specificational semantics, where the variable *ce qui* or *ce que* contained in the relative clause at the beginning of the structure is filled with the value contained in the clefted element (*c'est X* ‘it is X’). Given the clausal nature of the focalized subject, it is sometimes not straightforward to determine the type of focus that these constructions express. There seems to be a tendency, though, to encode an exhaustive interpretation of the proposition, and to exclude the other possible alternatives:

6.9 Multifactorial analysis: interaction of predictors for the French dataset

- (13) a. *Il y avait quelque chose qui te laissait prévoir que ce mec, il pourrait avoir des problèmes, ou?*
 ‘Was there something that made you foresee that this man could have problems, or?’
- b. *Ben, moi, ce qui me gênait un peu chez lui c’est [le fait qu’il soit rosicrucien]_{FOC} parce que ça lui apportait des fréquentations un peu louches.*
 ‘Well, as for me, what bothered me a little about him is the fact that he was a Rosicrucian, because that meant that he had dangerous acquaintances.’ (sgs French, 78/256-257)

In (12), speaker a suggests to speaker b to go interrogate the woman they are talking about. Speaker b, however, answers that s/he is only interested in the husband, excluding his/her interest for the interrogation of the wife. In example (13), the two speakers are talking about one of the neighbours living in the building. Speaker a is trying to find out if there is something about his personality that could appear suspicious. The interpretation of the pseudo clefts contained in the answer goes more in the direction of ‘the only thing that bothered me about him was...’, suggesting that there were no other aspects of his personality that could result unusual. Thus, in both example (12) and (13), it seems that the focalized subject contained in the clefted element of the pseudo clefts excludes all the other possible alternatives.

Overall, the pseudo clefts found in the corpus seem to exhibit features that have already been identified by previous research. Their scarcity might be due to the type of data investigated here. More precisely, because pseudo clefts tend to express feelings, personal opinions or emotions, they are not very compatible with a type of dialogue with many fast turns, where speakers are supposed to solve a murder case in an objective way. Rather, this construction type might be more common in traditional sociolinguistic interviews, where speakers utter longer stretches of text, usually relating their personal experiences.

Finally, all the 13 items appear with OE-psychological verbs, such as *étonner* ‘to surprise’, *marquer* ‘to strike’, *intéresser* ‘to interest’ and *gêner* ‘to bother’, thus expressing personal feelings and emotions, and almost all the sentences are in the 1st person singular (*moi, je* ‘I’) which grammatically corresponds to the (either direct or indirect) object of the sentence, apart from 2 cases which are impersonal constructions (e.g., *Ce qui est étonnant c’est qu’il avait les clefs* ‘What is surprising is that he had the keys’). These findings are, once again, in line with previous research.

6.10 Comparative analysis

The findings of this chapter provide several points for both language-internal and comparative discussion. The three factors investigated in relation to the answer type chosen by either Spanish or French speakers appear to influence this choice, albeit to varying degrees. Since information status, verb type, and, at least for French, focus type seem to affect speakers' selection between SV/VS in the Spanish data and between *c'est* and *il y a* clefts in the French data, it is reasonable to assert that the hypothesis formulated in this chapter is partly confirmed.

6.10.1 Clefts and exhaustivity

The results regarding exhaustivity show a strong correlation with specific cleft types only in the French dataset. This finding is not particularly surprising; in the literature on focus, exhaustivity has already been linked to the choice of different cleft formats. In this regard, the results from the French analysis align with what has been claimed by De Cesare & Garassino (2015) and Karssenberg (2017) regarding the differences between *c'est* and *il y a* clefts when both exhibit the same information-structural partition.

Furthermore, the data indicate that exhaustivity is not semantically but rather pragmatically conveyed in these types of clefts. The presence of exclusive focus particles such as *only* and the occurrence of some *c'est* clefts with a not-exhaustive interpretation demonstrate that the implicature of exhaustiveness is cancellable and that such cancellation does not have quantificational effects (i.e., it does not alter the truth-conditional value of the sentence).

The correlation between *il y a* clefts and not-exhaustive focus is also not surprising. Authors such as De Cesare & Garassino (2015), Verwimp & Lahousse (2017), and Karssenberg (2017) have argued for the “listing” or “enumerative” function of these constructions when they exhibit a focus-background partition, where the focused element is generally not the sole value that fills the *wh*-variable contained in the (either implicit or explicit) Question Under Discussion (QUD), but rather one of several possible options.

Moreover, within the exhaustive occurrences of focus, cases of contrast and correction are more frequently found in French *c'est* clefts. Once again, this finding aligns with the results of previous studies on contrast in this language (e.g., Lambrecht 1994). While focus type has not yielded statistically significant results for Spanish, the findings for givenness and argument structure are noteworthy: the data demonstrate strong correlations between these factors and specific syntactic structures in both languages.

6.10.2 Clefts and argument structure

As already mentioned, the literature correlating argument structure and clefts in French is almost absent. A closer look, however, reveals that authors such as Hetzron (1975) claim that different cleft formats (at least *c'est* clefts and pseudo) correlate with linear order and with the syntactic function of the argument contained in the clefted element. According to the author's view, *c'est* clefts, because of their configuration, would be ideal strategies to focus the subject because they allow the subject to be placed in an initial-position (which is the most natural position for subjects to appear). Conversely, pseudo clefts serve as effective strategies for focusing the object because the clefted element appears at the end of the utterance. This positioning allows the object to be placed sentence-finally, which is the most common position for objects in sentences. Additionally, according to Lambrecht (1994), "clefts are one specific solution in spoken French to the competition between syntax and pragmatics: different types of clefts allow to preserve a certain linear order of the constituents and guarantee at the same time the pragmatic effect of focus" (Lambrecht 1994: 25).

Building on this assumption, one could argue that this theory applies not only to different syntactic functions but also to various types of subjects. It is well known that subjects are not homogeneous; they make different semantic contributions depending on their level of agentivity and degrees of activation. Consequently, different types of clefts may serve as strategies to encode focus on distinct types of subjects while maintaining the linear order in which these subjects would appear if they were not focalized.

However, determining whether this explanation is on the right track is challenging based solely on the current data. The occurrences of pseudo clefts and, to some extent, Spanish *in situ* subjects are too scarce, necessitating a confirmation experiment. Nevertheless, the findings of this chapter and the hypotheses proposed could serve as a foundation for further research on this topic.

6.10.3 Focus-marking strategies and "bad" subjects

The literature on both Spanish and French focus highlights the fact that the choice of the focus-marking strategies is highly dependent on the type of subject: light, highly activated subjects, such as pronouns, are better focalized *in situ* through prosodic prominence rather than moved to a postverbal position (e.g., Gabriel 2007). Conversely, long, heavy or brand-new subjects are claimed to be more often found postverbally. Similarly, as mentioned repeatedly, *il y a* clefts are reported as strategies to avoid positioning "bad" subjects sentence-initially

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in spoken French (Lambrecht 2010, Karssenberg 2018c). The correlations found in the two sets of data confirm previous claims in this respect.

As for argument structure, the strong correlation between the VS order and unaccusative verbs in Spanish is, once again, expected. Leonetti (2017), for instance, argues that the distribution of subject inversion reflects a scale of “markedness” that goes from the simplest, core cases of VS with unaccusatives in presentational contexts to the most complex case of inversion with transitive verbs, VSO. Theoretically, the least marked patterns should be the most widespread, while the most marked ones should be the least natural and common.

Similarly, the frequent occurrence of subject-verb inversion with unaccusative verbs has been attributed to the absence of agentive properties assigned to their subjects. Authors such as Contreras (1978) and Gutiérrez-Bravo (2006) claim that different degrees of prominence among thematic roles are reflected in the word order of various languages. Non-prominent roles, such as THEMES or PATIENTS, typically favor inversion, while prominent roles, such as agents, tend to appear sentence-initially.

Gutiérrez-Bravo (2006) accounts for this phenomenon in terms of “structural markedness”. He posits that THEMES or PATIENTS in preverbal position are generally considered more marked than AGENTS. Consequently, different languages employ various strategies to mitigate such structural markedness. He considers the VS order in Spanish as one strategy to avoid placing a non-agentive subject in preverbal position.

The findings from the Spanish dataset support these claims: the majority of narrowly focused subjects are postverbal subjects of unaccusative verbs. This result may explain why the “immediacy” hypothesis, formulated in Chapter 4, is only partially confirmed for the Spanish data set. In Chapter 4, the results indicated that when the Question Under Discussion (QUD) immediately preceded the answers, no significant differences were observed in speakers’ choices. Unlike French speakers, Spanish speakers opted for both full and elliptical answers. The predominance of full answers in Spanish, which consist of verb + subject, may account for why the repetition of background (BG) material is not perceived as “heavy” as in French, where the discourse-old proposition is generally encoded by an additional clause.

6.10.4 Mapping semantic roles and information-structural functions onto syntax

Regarding the results of the different interactions, the exploratory analysis — where the three factors interacted — did not yield significant results. The scarcity

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of data points limits the ability to draw conclusions or make generalizations. Conversely, the confirmatory analysis, which investigated the interaction between verb type and information status, provided intriguing insights. Among the total *in situ* focused subjects in Spanish, the most frequent combinations involved a given subject with a transitive verb. Similarly, this combination resulted in a majority of *c'est* clefts in French. In contrast, the pairing of unaccusative verbs with new subjects led to a predominance of VS order and *il y a* clefts in Spanish and French, respectively. These correlations are illustrated in Figure 7:

Combination	Spanish	French
TRANSITIVE + GIVEN	in situ e.g. [Yo] _{FOC} <i>encontré el cadáver</i> 'I found the corpse.'	C'est cleft e.g. <i>C'est [moi] qui a appelé la police</i> 'It's me who called the police.'
UNACCUSATIVE + NEW	Postverbal e.g. <i>Vive [un señor importante]_{FOC}</i> 'An important man lives here'	Il y a cleft <i>Il y a [une vieille dame]_{FOC} qui vit au-dessus.</i> 'There is an old lady who lives upstairs.'

Check 'C'est moi qui ai appelé la police'.

Check where the 'here in the translation of 'An important man' comes from.

Figure 6.3: Comparative overview of Spanish and French correlations

According to Lambrecht (2010), grammars reflect universal cognitive constraints on the mapping between the informational structuring of utterances, the semantic structuring of propositions, and the formal structuring of sentences. These constraints restrict the possible alignments among the following pragmatic, semantic, and syntactic parameters:

- pragmatic relations (topic and focus)
- pragmatic statuses of discourse referents (hearer-new vs. hearer-old, discourse-new vs. discourse-old)
- semantic roles (agent and patient)
- grammatical relations (subject and object)

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- syntactic positions (e.g., preverbal vs. postverbal position in SVO languages)
- morphosyntactic and prosodic forms

In other words, there are clearly visible tendencies across languages where certain features reflect syntactic structures. Specifically, given arguments tend to precede new ones, AGENTS appear before PATIENTS, subjects come before objects, and topics are positioned before foci. However, Lambrecht does not explain how these elements interact and how this interaction is resolved in syntax. In this chapter, I tested the interaction between several of these features: subjects that are also foci, varying levels of agentivity, and degrees of givenness. The results indicate that being a given AGENT promotes its placement in sentence-initial position, while being unagentive (due to the presence of an unaccusative verb) and brand-new favors postverbal placement. The typological differences between Spanish and French lead to variations in this placement; in Spanish, it is resolved through word order (SV/VS), whereas in French, it is managed through two different construction strategies: *c'est* and *il y a* clefts. In Spanish, this mapping is more straightforward. In French, however, it requires additional explanation. As illustrated in Figure 7, a *c'est* cleft, due to its syntactic configuration, allows the subject to be positioned early in the sentence, while the object is placed at the end. Conversely, as noted by Lambrecht (2010), an *il y a* cleft serves as an optimal strategy to delay the appearance of the subject. This strategy aligns with the spoken French constraint of avoiding placing brand-new subjects at the beginning of a sentence, thus positioning them later in the structure.

One might argue that, unlike the Spanish SV structure, the subject in a *c'est* cleft does not appear at the very beginning of the sentence. Instead, it is introduced by a non-referential pronoun and a copula. This could be attributed to the fact that clefts have become grammaticalized structures. Both the copula and the relative pronoun can be considered semantically light and function as “discontinuous grammatical morphemes that serve the pragmatic function of focus marking” (Wehr 2011: 197) or as morphological focus markers in the form of a “circumfix” (Haase 2000: 126).

6.10.5 The case of pseudo clefts

Finally, in the case of pseudo clefts, their unique structural configuration allows the focused subject to be positioned at the end of the sentence, preceded by the relative clause that typically constitutes the background (BG) material. In the corpus, pseudo clefts are rare but are always accompanied by OE-psych verbs. Observing these types of verbs in other Romance languages, such as Spanish or

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Italian, reveals a special syntactic word order where the (direct or indirect) object precedes the verb and the subject, resulting in an OVS order (e.g., *A Ester no le gustan estas fiestas* ‘Esther doesn’t like these types of parties’).

Theories of thematic prominence have attributed this special configuration to the fact that the subject selected by these types of verbs is not the prototypical AGENT but rather the STIMULUS of the sentence, that provokes feelings and emotions to the object, who has the thematic role of EXPERIENCER. In these theories, the EXPERIENCER is considered to have more agentive properties than the STIMULUS (Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006),⁹ and is therefore placed in a position higher in the structure because of the mapping constraints identified by Lambrecht (2010). Observing again the syntactic configuration of pseudo clefts, it is possible to see that, when accompanied by OE-psych verbs, a pseudo cleft allows the positioning of an argument that is the object-experiencer in a higher position than the subject stimulus (e.g., *Ce qui m’intéresse bien, donc, c’est son mari* ‘What interests me more is her husband’).

Thus, the difference in syntactic positions or cleft types in Spanish and French respectively can be captured in terms of features, such as agentivity level and activation state of the argument(s) in the sentence. In line with Lambrecht (2010), syntactic variation seems to reflect universal cognitive constraints. The occurrence of different variants in the same pragmatic context could be due to the different semantic contributions of the subject, and the findings reported in this chapter provide evidence of the fact that such constraints are also visible in interaction with focus.

6.10.6 Additional cross-linguistic evidence

To highlight even more the importance of argument structure in focus realization, it is possible to look cross-linguistically at languages where change is “in progress”. In Brazilian Portuguese (BP), for instance, a language well known for being in a transitional phase, two main focus-marking strategies are reported for the subject: clefts sentences *à la* French and postverbal subjects *à la* Spanish. Interestingly, their alternation is claimed to be linked to the verb type contained in the sentence (Kato 2006): speakers tend to choose it-clefts for transitive verbs, while postposed subjects are maintained with monoargumental verbs, as in (14) and (15):

⁹This is also due to the fact that the EXPERIENCER is, by definition, an animate entity, while the STIMULUS can either be animate or inanimate.

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- (14) Brazilian Portuguese
- a. *O João telefonou?*
'Did John call?'
 - b. *Não. Telefonou [o PEDRO]_{FOC}.*
'No, Peter called.' (Kato 2006: 9)
- (15) *É [o Pedro]_{FOC} que ama a Maria.*
'It is Peter who loves Maria.' (Kato 2006: 10)

Thus, BP can be considered, in this respect, a hybrid variety between two different languages (e.g., French and Spanish) with a different typology with respect to focus realization, where the alternation between different focus-marking strategies is strictly dependent on argument structure of the verb.

6.11 Summary

In this chapter, I have tested and discussed factors previously claimed to impact focus realization in both Spanish and French. These factors have often been investigated separately and not in their interactions, making this study a novel contribution to the field. It demonstrates that the interplay between certain aspects of information status and argument structure significantly affects the choice of focus-marking strategies in both languages. Notably, the role of argument structure has not been analysed in correlation with cleft sentences before. I formulated the hypothesis that the three factors investigated — focus type, information status of the subject referent, and argument structure — are reflected differently in Spanish and French due to their typological differences in encoding focus. In Spanish, the influence of these factors is evident in word order alternation, particularly in the position of the subject. In contrast, French, with its relatively rigid word order, exhibits the impact of the same factors through the choice of cleft format.

Although focus type was not found to have a significant impact on the Spanish data, the hypothesis is still partly confirmed. The roles of givenness and argument structure, however, are clearly visible in the data, with strong correlations: given subjects of transitive verbs are predominantly encoded as preverbal subjects in Spanish and as *c'est* clefts in French, while new subjects of unaccusative verbs are most commonly represented by postverbal subjects and *il y a* clefts. To find common ground between the two languages, I have linked these tendencies to theories suggesting that specific features map onto specific syntactic positions.

6.11 Summary

Such an analysis, however, has several limitations. Certain interactions between factors could not be observed due to the low number of data points. It would be beneficial to conduct experimental studies, such as forced-choice tasks or acceptability judgments, with selected stimuli in a more controlled experimental setting. I leave this for further research.

Part III

Analysis and conclusion

7 Discussion

This chapter offers a final reflection on the findings of the empirical studies. Section 6.1 examines the results from a variationist perspective, while Section 6.2 considers how the same predictors account for the distribution of different focus-marking strategies in the two languages. Section 6.3 situates French and Spanish within a broader typology of focus realization, and Section 6.4 reflects on synchronic variation as well as potential diachronic change in the structures identified in the corpus. Finally, Section 6.5 outlines the limitations of the study and suggests possible directions for future research.

7.1 A variationist approach to subject focus

In this book, the question of subject focus in French and Spanish was investigated by adopting a quantitative variationist perspective. Within the variationist approach, a variable is defined as a general or abstract feature that is subject to variation, while the actual instantiations of the variable in speech are known as the variants (Meyerhoff 2018). By examining the discourse functions of these structures in context, one can discern whether two or more alternating syntactic structures are indeed competing variants and, therefore, belong to the same envelope of variation.

To investigate the phenomenon of subject focus, I adopted this perspective by starting from the pragmatic contexts that trigger the use of specific syntactic structures. Although these strategies may involve a change in referent and/or syntactic function, they all serve the same information-structural purpose and can therefore be regarded as optional variants. Put differently, the syntactic structures analysed in this book are treated as pragmatically equivalent realizations of the same underlying variable.

Furthermore, these structures exhibit noticeable differences at the syntactic level. For instance, when comparing the *in situ* strategies in both languages to an *il y a* cleft, one can observe that the focused element has changed its syntactic function: while it appears as the subject in the *in situ* structure, in the *il y a* cleft,

7 Discussion

it functions as the direct object of the sentence.¹ Nevertheless, all the strategies found in the Spanish and French datasets fulfil the same semantic and pragmatic requirement previously illustrated by example (1) in Chapter 3, which I repeat here:

- (1) a. (Who ate beans?)
 b. [Mary]
 textscfoc ate beans. (Velleman & Beaver 2016: 7)

Following Hamblin (1973), the (implicit or explicit) QUD in (1a) can be interpreted as a set of propositions, each being the denotation of a congruent answer: $\{\text{ATE}(\text{BEANS})(x) \mid x \in \text{ENTITY}\}$. The utterance in (1b), on the other hand, identifies one of these propositions and adds it to the CG content, stating that of all the possible alternative entities that could have eaten the beans, Mary did. The fact that this semantic and pragmatic requirement can appear as a canonical SVO structure, a cleft sentence, a VS order or a reduced cleft is evidence of the fact that there is variability in subject focus realization, and that subject focus itself can be considered a linguistic variable. However, this does not imply that the differences among these structures are neglected. As Adli (2006) writes, “if there is optionality at the level of the syntax module, this does not mean that the resulting variants are in free variation for all other modules of grammar” (Adli 2006: 198). Rather, the *raison d’être* of such optionality must be individuated and accounted for.

Indeed, a key tenet of the variationist approach is the idea of “orderly or structured heterogeneity” (Weinreich et al. 1968: 99-100). Variation is not random, but structured in regular ways along a number of internal linguistic and external social dimensions, including, for instance, linguistic context, speaker position/status, and text type (register, style, genre, etc.). Just like two representations of the same phoneme can be motivated by, say, differences in the social class of the speakers, one must be able to motivate the alternation among different syntactic forms that compete to express the same function.

In this study, I have looked at the pragmatic and linguistic factors that might explain the variation found among the different syntactic strategies. For instance, in Chapter 4, I investigated the alternation between full and elliptical forms when they are used to express the same communicative function. The results have shown that full forms (e.g., VS, *in situ*, clefts, etc.) are found more frequently when answering QUDs that are not immediate or implicit, while elliptical forms

¹The same phenomenon occurs with a *c’est* cleft, where the focalized element appears as the attribute of the copula *être*.

7.2 *Predictors of focus-marking strategies*

(e.g., reduced clefts and fragments) generally occur in the presence of immediately preceding QUDs. These results, however, are interpreted at a probabilistic level. Notably, one variant appearing with a higher frequency in a specific context does not automatically exclude the possibility that the same form could be used in a different context. In other words, it has been shown that a full cleft may well be a felicitous answer to an immediately preceding QUD, or vice versa, a reduced cleft might occur in a context that involves an implicit QUD.

Thus, these cases are significantly different from cases where constraints on a variable are entirely regular and predictable, allowing for the consistent determination of which variant will surface. For example, in many phonetic and phonological variables, linguistic cues – such as syllable position – dictate the variant of a particular phoneme that is used. In such instances, the realizations of that phoneme are determined by its syllabic context. In contrast, with the variation observed in subject focus realization, the same speaker may alternate between variants, using one in some contexts and another in others. Even if there is a higher probability that one variant will be favoured over another, no contextual constraint guarantees that a specific form will be employed 100% of the time. Nevertheless, it remains possible to predict the likelihood of encountering different forms in various contexts and among different speakers, especially in the presence of specific predictors.

7.2 Predictors of focus-marking strategies

To investigate what influences the alternation between different word orders in Spanish and different cleft formats in French, I examined the possible impacts of the same predictors on the two languages. In particular, I analysed whether the information status of the subject, the verb type contained in the syntactic structure and exhaustivity would be able to predict the choice of one rather than the other form. The results showed again a scenario where certain forms appear with a higher frequency with specific features rather than others.

For instance, it has been demonstrated that unaccusative verbs frequently combine with new subjects, while, at least in French, transitive verbs are often paired with given subjects. Moreover, these characteristics tend to correlate with specific syntactic structures, such as verb-subject (VS) order with unaccusative verbs and new subjects. However, these findings indicate tendencies rather than deterministic correlations. The same features may also appear in different word orders or cleft formats, albeit less frequently. This further supports the notion that there is no strict one-to-one correspondence between form and function, and that various syntactic constructions can often be used interchangeably. Therefore, opting

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for a *c'est* cleft in contexts where speakers would typically use an *il y a* cleft (e.g., with an unaccusative verb and a new subject) does not result in ungrammaticality, and the choice among different forms is primarily influenced by pragmatic constraints rather than solely by syntactic or semantic requirements.

Among the three factors investigated, focus type – specifically exhaustivity – has been shown to differ somewhat from the other two. Certain theories have posited that exhaustivity is inherently a semantic notion (Szabolcsi 1981, Kiss 1998), which carries quantificational effects on the sentence in question. In other words, while pragmatic constraints do not influence the truth-conditional value of a sentence, exhaustivity does. As shown in Chapter 5, exhaustivity affects syntactic variation in both languages, although this effect is more pronounced in the French dataset. This finding might lead one to argue that the constructions investigated cannot be considered optional variants because they do not satisfy the criterion of semantic equivalence due to their differences at the semantic level. However, such a claim is not supported by the data. In the case of Spanish, the effect of exhaustivity on word order is barely perceptible. In fact, mixed-effects modelling indicates that the association between focus type (i.e., exhaustivity) and syntactic structure is not even significant. For the French data, on the contrary, the results reveal a clear pattern linking exhaustive focus with *c'est* clefts and not-exhaustive focus with *il y a* clefts. This could be interpreted as evidence against the interchangeability of the two cleft formats. Given that *c'est* clefts express exhaustive focus while *il y a* clefts express its opposite, one might argue that these constructions cannot be used interchangeably in the same context and do not represent optional variants of the same variable. However, even in the case of French, the data does not support this assertion.

First, the results indicate probabilistic tendencies rather than deterministic rules. *Il y a* clefts can also convey exhaustivity, and, albeit less frequently, *c'est* clefts can appear in not-exhaustive contexts. Moreover, as argued in Chapter 5, exhaustivity is not syntactically encoded in either construction but is pragmatically inferred from contextual cues.

The evidence for this claim, already supported by other researchers (see, for example, Horn 1981, Dufter 2009, Destruel & DeVeugh-Geiss 2018), is that both types of clefts can be accompanied by particles that indicate either exhaustivity or its absence. This is visible in examples (2) and (3), already illustrated in Chapter 2 and Chapter 5, that I report again here:

- (2) *C'est seulement [moi]*
 textscfoc ensuite qui suis venue frapper pour la prévenir.
 'It is only me, afterwards, who came to warn her.' (sgs French, 38/187)

7.3 A typology of focus realization

- (3) *Bon, c'est vrai qu'il y avait [ce gars]
textscfoc aussi qui venait là, depuis deux, trois semaines là, qui venait assez
régulièrement.*
'Well, it is true that there was this guy who, since 2 or 3 weeks, was
coming over pretty regularly.' (sgs French, 77/366)

Thus, differences that may arise between the two constructions are not encoded in the syntactic structure itself, but rather derived by the context in which the sentence is found. As mentioned above, pragmatic differences should not exclude variants from the envelope of variation; instead, they should be considered possible factors that might explain what determines such variation.

The occurrence of competing variants for subject focus expression raises the important question of where to situate French and Spanish in a typology of focus realization. This question is addressed in the next section.

7.3 A typology of focus realization

As mentioned in Chapter 1, previous accounts of focus and its realization tend to adopt a strict characterization of languages and their way to express IS-functions (e.g., Lambrecht 1994, see Chapter 1). Under such a typology, French is said to use constructional strategies, while Spanish employs word order alternations.

These conclusions were often based on theoretical studies of the two languages, which, as mentioned in Chapter 2, tend to identify one single means to express focus in each language, thus excluding variability (e.g., Minimalist or OT-approaches and the VS order in Spanish). Later, experimental studies have contributed to weaken these claims, and have shown that speakers have at their disposal several means. The corpus study conducted in this book has contributed to support this view, adding elliptical structures and their frequency to the possible strategies that had already been identified in the literature.

As indicated by the results of the corpus query in Chapter 3, certain strategies for expressing focus are more frequent than others. However, this does not imply that speakers lack alternative means to convey the same function. Classifying Spanish as a “word order language” in contrast to an “intonation language” would fail to accurately represent the language’s complexity. While the corpus study revealed that postverbal subjects are the predominant means of expressing subject focus in Spanish, other strategies — such as prosodic and constructional approaches — are also employed.

Similarly, characterizing French solely as a language that utilizes constructional strategies for focus expression overlooks the phenomenon’s complexity. Although

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the corpus results indicate that clefts are the most frequent means of marking focus in French, speakers also use prosodic strategies to convey focus. Thus, even when defining a typology based on frequencies rather than categorical judgments derived from personal introspection, it remains essential to conduct extensive investigations across various corpora of spontaneous speech. This would yield a more realistic portrayal of the language and provide a stronger empirical foundation for analysis.

The extensive empirical research conducted over the past decade has shown that certain focus-marking strategies, although attested, occur less frequently than others. Conversely, some strategies are not only more common but also fulfil multiple information-structural functions, thereby challenging the notion of a strict one-to-one correspondence between form and function. A natural follow-up question, then, is whether this previously assumed one-to-one mapping resulted merely from a lack of empirical investigation, or whether certain strategies and word order patterns have in fact become more or less permissive over time. This issue is addressed in the following section.

7.4 Syntactic variation and language change

Variationist sociolinguistics has established that there is a robust connection between the variation found in any community of speakers at a given point in time and the long-term processes of change studied by historical linguists. He showed that synchronic variation is very often the root of diachronic change. By conducting longitudinal studies on different generations of speakers in New York, he demonstrated that synchronic variation is a reflex of long-term trends (Weinreich et al. 1968).

As is often the case in variationist sociolinguistics, numerous studies have explored the relationship between synchronic variation and diachronic change in phonological variables. Differently from the phonetic/phonological variables, however, syntax is generally more impermeable to change, and syntactic shifts tend to occur in a much larger span of time. A type of language change that has received considerably less attention is the one investigating shifts at the level of the information structure of a given language, or, more precisely, changes occurring at the interface between syntax and information structure. Intuitively, variation and change at the phonetic/phonological level is easier to grasp than changes in the pragmatic constraints of a language, which are, by definition, more subtle. Nevertheless, there have been some studies investigating the changes in the mapping of IS onto syntax, especially in the passage from Latin to Modern Romance

7.4 Syntactic variation and language change

languages. For instance, Medieval Romance varieties are generally claimed to display a V2 word order, featuring the fronting of one or more constituents to the left of the inflected verb (Benincà 2006, Ledgeway 2012, Salvi 2011, Wolfe 2015, 2024, *inter alia*). This position was generally reserved for different IS-functions. In Modern Romance languages, it is possible to observe that certain word orders are not available in equal measure for all the members of the family.

Lahousse & Lamiroy (2012), for instance, investigate the availability of the VOS order in Spanish, Italian and French. To account for the fact that this pattern is almost absent in Modern French, the authors postulate an hypothesis in terms of progressive grammaticalization with respect to the interface between grammatical structure and information structure. They provide evidence for a continuum from Spanish → Italian → French, where Spanish is the least grammaticalized, and French the most grammaticalized language. Additionally, data provided by Dufter (2008) shows that there is a significant increase in the frequency of clefts from Latin to Modern French. The virtual loss of VOS in French, thus, seems to be compensated by the increasing use of these constructions in Modern French. These studies illustrate how changes at the interface between information structure and syntax have influenced the distinctions among Modern Romance languages today. They further support the argument that language change can only be fully understood by considering pragmatic constraints and including these structures within the same envelope of variation. Additionally, as noted by Lehmann (2008), “on the one hand, information structure is present in the source constructions that undergo grammaticalization, and may direct their course. On the other hand, information structure is itself susceptible to grammaticalization” (Lehmann 2008: 1). It is possible that certain word orders expressing multiple IS-functions become restricted to a single pragmatic function.

For example, the XPV order was available in many Medieval Romance varieties and is said to express various information-structural functions. Modern Italian has been largely claimed to have limited this position – more generally, the fronting of a constituent – to contrastive or corrective foci (However, see Cruschina 2021 on how gradualness in the notion of contrast can account for different subject positions in Italian). Conversely, certain constructions or word orders that were initially restricted to specific IS-functions may become more permissive in terms of pragmatic interpretation, allowing for use in discourse contexts different from their original ones. Caloi et al. (2018), for instance, conducted experiments on Heritage Italian showing that even non-contrastive focused subjects, when accompanying transitive or unergative verbs, may appear in SV rather than VS order. These findings suggest two main points: first, they indicate that a change may be ongoing in this variety of Italian; second, they

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once again highlight the crucial role of argument structure in the realization of focus.

Il y a clefts have traditionally been described as presentational or event-reporting constructions, typically associated with an all-focus interpretation (Lambrecht 1994). However, recent corpus studies have shown that these constructions can also express narrowly-focused subjects (Karssenbergh 2017, 2018b). The results obtained from the sgscorpus further confirms that *il y a* clefts exhibiting a focus-background partition are not uncommon, supporting the claim that these structures can serve more than one IS-function. Two factors may account for this phenomenon: (i) earlier studies on *il y a* clefts were primarily based on introspection rather than actual spoken data, whereas more recent studies rely on corpora, offering a fuller perspective on the functions conveyed by this cleft format; (ii) there may have been a change in the IS-functions these constructions express. It is plausible that *il y a* clefts were initially used predominantly in all-focus contexts, and that over time their use has expanded to include narrow-focus cases. Detecting such change in progress is challenging. A longitudinal study – whether in real or apparent time – would provide clearer insights into whether these constructions have undergone shifts in their information-structural roles. This would, however, require speech data collected across multiple generations of speakers or at different time points.

7.5 Limitations of the study and next steps

While the studies presented in this work provide valuable insights into the interaction between information structure, syntax, and argument structure, several limitations must be acknowledged. These limitations concern both methodological and empirical aspects of the research, such as the scope of the data, the representativeness of the corpus and experimental samples, and the interpretative constraints inherent to the chosen analytical framework. Recognizing these boundaries is essential, as it helps to situate the findings within their proper empirical and theoretical context and to identify directions for future research.

7.5.1 Caveats of the study

The annotation of focus in this study relied on the Question under Discussion (QUD) approach, which provides a principled and replicable way to operationalize how a sentence is partitioned into background and focus. While the QUD

7.5 *Limitations of the study and next steps*

framework offers clear advantages for systematically identifying the information-structural function of the utterances, it also presents certain challenges. For instance, determining the precise QUD can be difficult in cases where multiple, equally plausible questions could underlie the same utterance, or where the discourse context does not explicitly indicate the speaker's intended question. Additionally, the method requires interpretation of the pragmatic context, which introduces some subjectivity in the annotation process. These factors suggest that, although the QUD approach is robust, complementary methods may further strengthen the reliability of focus annotation in future studies.

Furthermore, in the present annotation scheme, three levels of QUD were distinguished: immediate QUD, distant QUD, and implicit QUD. While this categorization allowed for a systematic analysis of focus, the implicit QUD category conflates two potentially distinct dimensions: immediate-implicit QUD, where the underlying question is closely related to the preceding discourse, and distant-implicit QUD, where the inferred question is more removed from the local context. By merging these two subtypes into a single category, the analysis may have obscured subtle differences in how focus interacts with discourse structure. Future research could benefit from a more fine-grained annotation that separates these dimensions, potentially yielding more detailed insights into the interaction between focus and discourse context.

A further limitation relates to the annotation of information status. In the present study, the information status of the subject referent was annotated on the basis of textual givenness, without distinguishing pragmatic givenness or introducing a separate category for cases of bridging. This methodological choice ensured consistency and replicability in annotation, but it may have oversimplified the pragmatic nuances of discourse referents. A more fine-grained distinction—taking into account inferable or bridging referents—could potentially yield different patterns, especially in contexts where the accessibility of information is determined by shared world knowledge rather than explicit textual mention. Future research could therefore benefit from adopting a more detailed annotation scheme that integrates pragmatic dimensions of givenness alongside textual ones.

A further limitation concerns the nature of the data used for the analysis. The corpus was based on semi-spontaneous speech elicited through a specific task in which participants were asked to solve a fictional murder case by answering questions. While this method allowed for the controlled elicitation of target structures and ensured comparability across speakers, it does not fully guarantee the spontaneity of the data. Participants were aware of the experimental context and of the need to provide informative answers, which may have influenced their linguistic choices, particularly in relation to focus marking and information pack-

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aging. Consequently, some of the patterns observed might reflect task-related effects rather than naturally occurring discourse behaviour. Future research should therefore complement these findings with data from more spontaneous conversational contexts.

Finally, beyond the issue of the spontaneity of the data lies the problem of the infrequency of certain constructions. While both the Spanish and French datasets demonstrate the availability of several variants to express the same function, some of these variants are highly infrequent. In the Spanish sub-corpus, for example, speakers produced only 33 *in situ* foci, 29 clefts, and 21 reduced clefts out of 352 items. Similarly, in the French corpus, *in situs*, fragments, and dislocations appear relatively rare, with just 41, 31, and 7 occurrences, respectively. This raises the question of whether these infrequent variants are genuinely comparable to the more commonly used structures, such as postverbal subjects, French clefts, or Spanish fragments. This question cannot be easily answered by examining frequency data alone. The phenomenon of subject focus is far more intricate and multifaceted. To provide a comprehensive understanding of the contexts in which it occurs and the resulting syntactic structures, it is essential to go beyond purely linguistic and discursive factors, incorporating extra-linguistic variables as well.

For instance, the study conducted in this book does not consider the role of register. The formal/informal dichotomy is known to significantly influence various linguistic phenomena, and the mapping of information structure onto syntax is no exception. An investigation of subject focus across different registers would likely account for the scarcity of certain structures.

In French, for example, the divergence between formal and informal language is said to be more pronounced than in other languages (see [Blanche-Benveniste 2006](#), [Katz & Blyth 2007](#), [Hamlaoui 2011](#), *inter alia*). Standard French (or formal French) refers to the highly codified variety learned later in life, typically in formal contexts and under the influence of literacy. While dominant in written language, Standard French also encompasses the spoken language of educated speakers in formal settings, such as media broadcasts or public speeches. Conversely, Colloquial French (informal French) refers to the variety used by most native speakers in everyday interactions, acquired early in life in naturalistic settings. Though primarily associated with spoken language, Colloquial French also appears in certain informal written contexts.

The differences between these varieties have even raised the question of whether speakers possess two distinct grammars. Variationist approaches, following the work of [Labov \(1972\)](#), argue against this, suggesting that natural languages are inherently variable. Other scholars, however, propose a diglossic explanation,

7.5 Limitations of the study and next steps

suggesting that speakers may have two overlapping but distinct grammars that coexist (Rowlett 2011). In her investigation of subject and object focus, Destruel (2016) compares the use of formal and informal registers in French, revealing that while clefts are the most common strategy for expressing subject focus in the colloquial variety, speakers in formal settings strongly preferred the *in situ* strategy. This demonstrates a significant effect of register, even when examining information-structural functions.

Additionally, social factors have not been considered in this study. Variation between different linguistic forms often mirrors social differences among speakers, such as education level or social status. Incorporating social variables could, therefore, provide further insight into why certain structures are more frequent than others.

7.5.2 For further research

A puzzling result that emerged from the data is the marked difference in the productivity of reduced clefts and fragments between French and Spanish. In French, reduced clefts are highly productive ($n=137$), while they are infrequent in Spanish ($n=21$). Conversely, fragments are common in Spanish ($n=102$) but scarce in French ($n=31$). To explain this discrepancy, I have proposed the “copy” hypothesis (see Chapter 3, section 3.7). According to this hypothesis, when speakers aim to produce an elliptical structure for discourse-related reasons, they tend to “copy” the focused part of the full structure that is more prevalent in their language, simply eliding the background (BG) proposition. Since clefts are the most frequent means of expressing subject focus in spoken French, French speakers producing elliptical structures would likely “copy” the clefted element and omit the BG proposition contained in the relative clause.

Similarly, in Spanish, where postverbal subjects are the most common structure, speakers would replicate the focused element and delete the remaining part of the utterance containing discourse-old information. As a result, the elliptical structure in Spanish manifests as a fragment. Clearly, this hypothesis requires empirical testing. Ideally, the same study should be replicated using a different dataset or by focusing on other constituents, such as object focus. Additionally, since elliptical constructions are common across many, if not all, languages, this hypothesis could be tested cross-linguistically. A comparative study on focus and the alternation between full and elliptical structures across languages could yield valuable insights into the patterns and properties of elliptical answers, revealing both differences and commonalities among languages.

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Moreover, the “copy” hypothesis does not fully explain the occurrence of fragments in French or reduced clefts in Spanish. In other words, it fails to account for the presence of alternative elliptical strategies within the same language. Although these structures appear with much lower frequency, Spanish speakers still produced some reduced clefts, and French speakers some fragments. As mentioned earlier, social or stylistic factors—which could provide further insight—were not considered in this study. At least for French, another possible explanation might be linked to the type of verb in the preceding QUD (which is elided in the answer). Some linguistic contexts may render a reduced cleft infelicitous, while a fragment would be more appropriate, and conversely, other contexts might favour the use of a reduced cleft over a fragment. Consider the following examples:

- (4) a. *Qui veut du gâteau?*
 ‘Who wants cake?’
 a. [*Moi*]_{FOC}!
 ‘Me!’
 b’. #*C’est [moi]*_{FOC}!
 ‘It is me!’
- (5) a. *C’est qui dans la photo?*
 ‘Who is this in the picture?’
 b. #[*Moi*]
 textscfoc!
 ‘Me!’
 b’. *C’est [moi]* FOC!
 ‘It is me!’

In example (4), a fragment seems to be a more felicitous answer than a reduced cleft. Conversely, in example (5), a reduced cleft appears to be a better option. While it is not yet clear what determines these preferences, it seems that certain contexts impose more constraints than others, and these constraints may be related to the type of verb (and possibly the thematic roles) in the question. It is important to emphasize that answering with a reduced cleft in the context of (4) or using a fragment in (5) would not result in ungrammaticality. Rather, it reflects probabilistic choices and speaker preferences. What exactly drives these preferences remains an open question and offers a promising direction for future research.

8 General conclusion

The primary aim of this study was to deepen the understanding of subject focus and its realization in Spanish and French. To achieve this, I adopted a quantitative variationist approach, treating subject focus as a linguistic variable and its various realizations as optional variants. Although Spanish and French belong to the same linguistic family, they are said to display significant differences in how they encode focus, particularly subject focus. Theoretical accounts have traditionally claimed that French expresses subject focus primarily through constructional strategies such as *c'est* clefts, while Spanish does so through postverbal subjects. These accounts often suggest a one-to-one correlation between word order patterns and discourse-functional motivations, thereby downplaying the potential for variation (for Spanish: Zubizarreta 1998, Costa 2001, Samek-Lodovici 2001, Gutiérrez-Bravo 2006, *inter alia*. For French: Prince 1978, Lambrecht 1994, Belletti 2005, *inter alia*).

In contrast, empirical studies have indicated that subject focus in both languages can be realized through various competing strategies, pointing to the presence of variation in this phenomenon (for Spanish: Gabriel 2007, 2010, Heideringer 2013, Uth 2014, Cabrera 1999, Feldhausen & Vanrell 2015, *inter alia*. For French: Dufter & Jacob 2009, Féry 2001, Choi-Jonin & Lagae 2005, Lahousse 2006, 2011, Karssenbergh 2017, 2018b, *inter alia*). However, both theoretical and empirical studies have largely concentrated on full sentences, neglecting cases where subject focus is encoded by elliptical structures, such as reduced clefts and fragments.

This book seeks to address this gap by conducting a corpus-based study of spontaneous dialogues in both languages. By identifying both full and elliptical strategies that speakers employ to express subject focus, this study provides new insights into the factors governing their alternation. Below, I offer a summary of the key contributions of this book.

8.1 Frequency of subject focus-marking strategies

In Chapter 3, I delineated the envelope of variation by selecting criteria that defined the variable of subject focus. Using the Question Under Discussion (QUD)

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approach to focus (Roberts 1996, Büring 2003, Beaver & Clark 2009), I extracted various focus-marking strategies for both Spanish and French and annotated them based on the type of focus they conveyed, distinguishing between contrastive and non-contrastive readings. In both languages, multiple strategies were available to express the same function, though they varied in frequency.

In the Spanish corpus, speakers used postverbal subjects, fragments, *in situ* focus, clefts, and reduced clefts. By contrast, in the French dataset, speakers employed clefts, reduced clefts, *in situ* focus, fragments, and dislocations. Notably, no cases of postverbal subjects appeared in the French corpus, and no instances of dislocations were found in the Spanish corpus.

Regarding focus type, the majority of cases in both languages were classified as information focus, i.e., focus expressing non-presupposed information. Contrastive foci, however, were rare in both datasets, aligning with previous accounts that characterize contrast as a more marked pragmatic function and, therefore, less frequent than simply conveying new information (Zimmermann & Onea 2011).

Regarding the frequencies of the various strategies, postverbal subjects (n=167) and cleft sentences (n=220) emerged as the most common response types in Spanish and French, respectively. Notably, the second most frequent strategy in both languages was an elliptical one: Spanish speakers produced 102 fragment answers, while French speakers produced 137 reduced clefts. This suggests that even when employing elliptical answers, the two languages exhibit significant differences. To explain this observation, I posited the hypothesis that speakers in both languages tend to ‘copy’ the focused part of the most frequently used full strategy and elide the background proposition for discourse-related reasons.

Furthermore, the results from the Spanish corpus indicated that *in situ* structures and clefts are not exclusively associated with a contrastive interpretation; they can also express information focus. This finding challenges previous accounts that asserted a necessary connection between the use of cleft sentences or *in situ* strategies in Spanish and a contrastive or corrective interpretation (Lambrecht 1994, Zubizarreta 1998). Instead, it aligns with the analyses by Féry (2001) and Gabriel (2007), who explored prosodic focus in Spanish, as well as with Feldhausen & Vanrell (2015), who examined peninsular Spanish clefts.

Overall, this chapter has confirmed the assertion that focused subjects in French and Spanish can be expressed through various, alternating strategies, highlighting the absence of a one-to-one correlation between form and function. Instead, multiple syntactic structures can accommodate different readings, with the appropriate interpretation emerging solely from the discourse contexts in which these structures are situated. Additionally, the corpus study conducted in this

8.2 The alternation between full and elliptical answers

chapter identified and analysed different elliptical structures that compete with full forms in expressing the same information-structural function. The investigation of the contexts in which these structures occur and are preferred over their full counterparts was the focus of Chapter 4.

8.2 The alternation between full and elliptical answers

In Chapter 4, I investigated the factors underlying the alternation between full and elliptical strategies that emerged from the corpus analysis in Chapter 3. Previous literature had suggested that reduced clefts in French are particularly well-suited as responses to immediately preceding questions (Belletti 2008a, Katz 2000). However, this assertion had never been empirically tested until now.

In my analysis, I postulated the hypothesis that while elliptical answers (such as reduced clefts and fragments) are more suitable for immediate QUDs, full strategies are predominantly used in response to distant or implicit QUDs – what I called the “immediacy hypothesis”. This hypothesis is grounded in the observation that when the QUD is immediate, the background information from the question is highly activated in the minds of both the speaker and the listener. In such cases, repeating the entire background in the answer can feel unnatural. Instead, opting for an elliptical response, where only the focused part remains, is more appropriate. Conversely, when the QUD is distant or is implicit, the activation of background material decreases, prompting a cooperative speaker to favour a full structure. To test this hypothesis empirically, I annotated each QUD preceding the answer that expressed subject focus and distinguished between three levels of annotation: i) Immediate QUD, ii) Distant QUD, iii) Implicit QUD. The results from both languages supported this hypothesis, although certain tendencies were more pronounced in French than in Spanish. In both languages, full structures were more frequent when preceded by distant or implicit QUDs. However, in the immediate condition, French speakers showed a strong inclination to respond with elliptical strategies, whereas this tendency was considerably weaker in the Spanish dataset.

In both languages, syntactic structures such as clefts or *in situ* responses, which contain both the focused element and the background proposition, tend to be more frequent when the triggering QUD is distant or implicit. In the French dataset, however, elliptical structures – like reduced clefts or fragments – where only the focused element remains while the background proposition is omitted, are more commonly found as answers to immediate QUDs.

To explain this discrepancy between the two languages in the immediate condition, I proposed a reasoning based on syntactic complexity. As established in

8 General conclusion

Chapter 3, the most frequent full answer type in French is a cleft sentence, while in Spanish, the corresponding full strategy appears to be a postverbal subject. These two structures differ inherently at the syntactic level: postverbal subjects result from a reordering of constituents in the sentence, whereas clefts are bi-clausal structures comprised of a main clause and a subordinate clause. This bi-clausal configuration renders cleft sentences inherently heavier and more complex than postverbal subjects. Moreover, the analysis of verb types in Chapter 5 indicated that most postverbal subjects involve unaccusative verbs, which means that these sentences consist of just a subject and a verb, lacking any additional arguments.

Based on these observations, I proposed that repeating the entire background proposition through a separate relative clause in a cleft is perceived as heavier and less felicitous by speakers than merely repeating a single verb in a postverbal subject. This perception may account for why Spanish speakers did not exhibit a significant preference for either a full or an elliptical answer in response to immediately preceding questions.

This chapter has made several innovative contributions. First, it has operationalized the level of activation of the background proposition in dialogical contexts by distinguishing various levels of immediacy in the preceding QUD. Second, it has explained the occurrence of elliptical answer types and their alternation with full sentences when expressing the same IS function. Third, it has provided evidence for the Principle of Communicative Efficiency (Levshina 2022), which posits that when sufficient contextual cues are available for successful understanding, speakers prefer to convey less. Conversely, they tend to express more when such cues are less clear.

8.3 Pragmatic and semantic factors in syntactic variation

In Chapter 5, I examined the alternation between postverbal and preverbal subjects in Spanish, as well as the various cleft formats in French. Previous literature has suggested that the choice between SV and VS order in contexts where the subject is in focus may be influenced by factors such as the givenness of the subject constituent and the type of verb used (Gabriel 2007). In French, the optionality between *c'est* and *il y a* clefts — when expressing the same information structure (IS) function — has often been linked to the type of focus. Specifically, it has been argued that while *c'est* clefts typically convey an exhaustive reading of the focused constituent, *il y a* clefts do so only marginally (De Cesare & Garassino 2015, Karssenbergh 2017).

8.3 Pragmatic and semantic factors in syntactic variation

In this chapter's analysis, I applied the same predictors to both languages. Specifically, I examined whether the verb's argument structure, the degree of givenness of the subject constituent, and exhaustivity could explain the syntactic variation observed in the two languages. First, I conducted descriptive and inferential statistics, exploring the main effect of each factor on the different syntactic structures, followed by an investigation of the interaction between the three predictors. To determine the significance of these results, I performed inferential statistics using mixed-effects modelling, with the interview number included as a random effect.

The results revealed that factors such as verb type and givenness align with specific syntactic structures in both languages. Notably, the combination of unaccusative verbs and new subjects correlates strongly with Spanish postverbal subjects and French *il y a* clefts. In contrast, transitive verbs and given subjects are more frequently associated with French *c'est* clefts and, to a lesser extent, with Spanish *in situ* foci. Moreover, the interaction of these two factors appears to reinforce this correlation.

This finding supports the claims made by Du Bois et al. (2003) and the Preferred Argument Structure (PAS), which had previously highlighted the link between transitive verbs and given subjects, as well as unaccusative verbs with new subjects. Additionally, prior research on the VS order had already indicated that this word order is more commonly found with unaccusatives (e.g., Burzio 1986 for Italian; Gabriel 2007 for empirical evidence on Spanish VS). However, the role of argument structure in relation to French clefts had not been systematically explored until now. On the one hand, the corpus study presented in this chapter confirms claims previously made in the literature. On the other hand, it provides new insights into the factors that may drive the optionality of different cleft formats when they compete for the same discursive function.

Regarding the role of exhaustivity, significance tests revealed that this factor does not yield significant results in Spanish. However, in French, there is a noticeable association between *c'est* clefts and exhaustive focus, and *il y a* clefts with a non-exhaustive focus type. Nevertheless, the data shows that this correlation is not deterministic, as both cleft formats can be found with either reading. This suggests that exhaustivity is not semantically encoded in the syntax of these constructions but is pragmatically conveyed, aligning with the views of Horn (1981), Dufter (2009), Karssenbergh (2017), Destruel & DeVaugh-Geiss (2018), *inter alia*. Additionally, some *c'est* clefts occur with exclusive particles like *seulement* ('only'), while some *il y a* clefts co-occur with additive particles such as *aussi* ('too'). If exhaustivity (or its absence) were semantically encoded in clefts, these particles would be incompatible with these constructions and thus not present.

8 General conclusion

While this book has provided valuable insights and addressed both longstanding and emerging questions, several unresolved issues remain. For instance, certain syntactic structures, such as French pseudo-clefts and dislocations, were too infrequent to be included in the statistical analysis, making generalizations impossible. Additionally, the interaction between the examined factors often resulted in a reduced number of occurrences, limiting the interpretability of the findings. A forced-choice task or an acceptability judgment test, conducted in a more controlled experimental setting where these factors are deliberately combined or mismatched, would offer more definitive evidence of the behaviour of the syntactic constructions under investigation.

Furthermore, the role of prosody was not considered in this study. The *in situ* strategies in both languages, where focus is conveyed by assigning intonational prominence to the subject, clearly call for a prosodic analysis. Such an analysis would offer deeper insights into how the two languages differ in their use of prosody for discourse-related functions. In short, much work remains to be done before we can fully understand how pragmatic functions are mapped onto syntactic structures. It is my hope that this book will inspire future research on these complex and fascinating phenomena.

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